House of Commons

Daily Report **Thursday, 22 October 2026**

This report shows written answers and statements provided on 22 October 2026 and the information is correct at the time of publication (06:16 P.M., 22 October 2026). For the latest information on written questions and answers, ministerial corrections, and written statements, please visit: http://www.parliament.uk/writtenanswers/

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Notes:

Questions marked thus **[R]** indicate that a relevant interest has been declared.
Questions with identification numbers of **900000 or greater** indicate that the question was originally tabled as an oral question and has since been unstarred.

ANSWERS

ATTORNEY GENERAL

Aria Thorpe

Suella Braverman: [35259]

To ask the Attorney General, whether the Crown Prosecution Service raised concerns about the judge's draft directions to the jury on unlawful act manslaughter in the trial of the case of Aria Thorpe in the context of the decision in Grey [2024] EWCA Crim 487.

Andy Slaughter:
The Judge circulated her draft directions to all parties in writing. Leading Counsel for the Prosecution and Defence subsequently provided the Judge, on two occasions, with a joint document setting out proposed amendments. Those amendments included a request by the Prosecution that the summing-up should make clear that the unlawful act relied upon, for the purposes of unlawful act manslaughter was an assault, and that the relevant mens rea for that assault included recklessness. Leading Prosecution Counsel also made oral representations in open court reiterating that submission.

Suella Braverman: [35260]

To ask the Attorney General, what recent steps the Crown Prosecution Service has taken to ensure prosecutors check draft jury directions against existing case law on unlawful manslaughter; and if she will ask His Majesty's Crown Prosecution Service Inspectorate to review the handling of the Aria Thorpe case.

Andy Slaughter:
The process for jury directions and consultation with advocates is clearly set out in the Crown Court Compendium. It stipulates that 'All written directions for the jury must be discussed, and preferably agreed, with the advocates well before they are provided to the jury'. This requirement is reiterated in the CPS policy Instructions for Prosecution Advocates which is incorporated into every prosecution brief and states 'Advocates must also ensure that appropriate judicial directions are given in accordance with the Crown Court Compendium.

Suella Braverman: [35261]

To ask the Attorney General, whether the Crown Prosecution Service (a) has met and (b) plans to meet the family of Aria Thorpe to discuss that case.

Andy Slaughter:
The CPS has maintained liaison with Aria's family. It would not be appropriate to comment further on those communications.

Domestic Abuse: Prosecutions

Josh Fenton-Glynn: [31109]

To ask the Attorney General, what assessment she has made of the adequacy of the amount of time taken by the Crown Prosecution Service to reach charging decisions in domestic abuse cases.

Andy Slaughter:
Tackling domestic abuse is a top priority for the government under our commitment to halve violence against women and girls.

Domestic abuse flagged charging decisions continue to have shorter timeframes than those for crime overall. In 2025/26, the mean average time from referral to charge in domestic abuse flagged cases was 25 days, compared with 44 days across all crime types. The median time from referral to charge was one day, indicating that many charging decisions were made shortly after referral to the Crown Prosecution Service (CPS). In addition, 74.9% of charging consultations in domestic abuse flagged cases were completed within 28 days, higher than the 71.7% recorded across crime overall.

The CPS continues to work with criminal justice partners to improve the timeliness of charging decisions, particularly in more complex cases where further evidence may be required before a charging decision can be made. Through the CPS and National Police Chiefs' (NPCC) Council Domestic Abuse Joint Justice Plan, the CPS is working closely with policing partners through the Pathfinder Programme to strengthen early collaboration between police and prosecutors, improve case quality, and support more timely progression from investigation to charging decision.

Alongside this, the CPS, NPCC and Home Office are currently piloting the Charging Authority Project across England and Wales, enabling the police to charge in select domestic abuse cases and forming part of wider efforts across the criminal justice system to reduce delays and improve the handling of cases. This initiative is being piloted in two CPS Areas, with plans for expansion currently being considered.

These charging initiatives form part of the CPS's objective to strengthen the handling of domestic abuse cases and deliver effective charging decisions, helping victims to access justice sooner while ensuring offenders are held to account.

Homicide: Acquittals

Suella Braverman: [35262]

To ask the Attorney General, how many Crown Court acquittals in homicide cases in each of the last five years have been followed by an acknowledgement that the jury was misdirected.

Andy Slaughter:
The CPS does not hold data that would identify, for each of the last five years, the number of Crown Court acquittals in homicide cases in which it was subsequently acknowledged that the jury had been misdirected.

BUSINESS, INNOVATION, SCIENCE AND TRADE

AI Growth Zones: North Lanarkshire

Imogen Walker: [30166]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what discussions he has had with the Lanarkshire AI Growth Zone on opportunities for local people to access jobs and training.

Kanishka Narayan:
The Government is working closely with the Lanarkshire AI Growth Zone partners to maximise local jobs, skills, and training opportunities. This includes bringing together North Lanarkshire Council, Scottish Government, DataVita, and local skills and education partners to build on skills, training, employment, and community benefit opportunities associated with the Lanarkshire AI Growth Zone.

Apprentices are already working on site alongside a growing local workforce, while industry partners are supporting Scottish AI start-ups and widening access to AI careers. The AIGZ is also creating wider economic opportunities, with Dell Technologies recently announcing the relocation of its Scottish headquarters to Lanarkshire because of the AIGZ.

The Government continues to work with North Lanarkshire Council, the Scottish Government, and local partners to ensure that the benefits of AI investment support local communities and skills development.

Air Pollution: Warnings

Barry Gardiner: [35228]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, whether the Met Office has a policy or is commissioned by his Department to issue and proactively send episode-specific air-quality warnings to news media, separately from supplying forecast data.

Chris McDonald:
The Met Office produces the public air-quality forecast on behalf of the Department for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs (Defra), which is available through GOV.UK and Met Office web and app products.

While air-quality warnings are not issued in the UK, the Met Office does provide an ad hoc Air Quality Notification/Alert service on behalf of Defra when pollution levels are expected to reach specified thresholds. Further information on how these alerts and notifications are used can be provided by Defra.

Artificial Intelligence: Economic Growth

Dr Ben Spencer: [30879]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what assessment he has made of the potential constitutional implications of powers to disapply

sectoral regulation through the AI Growth Lab; and whether such powers would be subject to the affirmative procedure.

Kanishka Narayan:
Through the upcoming Regulating for Growth Bill, the Government will create new cross-economy sandbox powers so that businesses can test cutting-edge new products and technologies safely, prove what works and then scale up delivery of these changes more quickly. The new powers will enable the 'AI Growth Lab', that would allow responsible innovation and adoption of AI-enabled products and services that our current regulation hinders. In developing the powers, we are clear that regulatory protections should not be undermined.

Artificial Intelligence: National Security

Stuart Anderson: [34779]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, how sovereign artificial intelligence and quantum computing capabilities are being ring-fenced for national security applications.

Kanishka Narayan:
The AI Research Resource (AIRR) is the UK's national AI computing infrastructure. We are dedicating AIRR capacity to AI R&D aligned with government priorities and providing dedicated access to core Government AI functions, including the AI Security Institute and Sovereign AI. This supports the AI Security Institute's work to understand and address security risks from advanced AI.

We are also investing in next-generation public compute infrastructure to strengthen the UK's sovereign compute capability and provide a flexible platform for advanced AI workloads and emerging technologies, including novel AI architectures and quantum computing in the future.

The National Quantum Computing Centre and UKRI work closely with stakeholders across government to ensure our quantum computing deployments are designed to support national priorities, including national security. This will continue with the ProQure programme which is designed to accelerate development of quantum computing capability and help create the evidence base needed for future deployment of large-scale quantum computing systems in the UK. ProQure will also include investment in sovereign capability through supply chain investment.

Artificial Intelligence: North East Somerset and Hanham

Dan Norris: [35931]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what opportunities are provided by his Department in North East Somerset and Hanham to help attract investment in artificial intelligence industries.

Kanishka Narayan:
Government is working closely with WECA to support the delivery of the West of England Growth Strategy, which sets out both key locations and target sectors, one

of which is identified as digital and technology including AI, to attract investment and deliver economic growth. Measures to deliver on the strategy and increase attractiveness to investors of the West of England's already vibrant economy include the recently announced Future Places Fund, to which Government has contributed £65m.

The Government's support for AI businesses is UK wide, and we are determined that the benefits of AI are felt in every part of the country. The Office for Investment's Venture Capital Unit connects UK AI companies with international investors to help them scale. Through our Sovereign AI Fund, backed by £500 million, we invest directly in and support strategically important British AI companies, and Innovate UK's £130 million Growth Catalyst provides grants.

Artificial Intelligence: Regulation

Vikki Slade: [31539]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, if he will take steps to introduce an independent regulator for Artificial Intelligence and Artificial Superintelligence.

Kanishka Narayan:
The government is ensuring that the UK is ready for both the challenges and opportunities that AI will bring. We have taken important steps to ensure that many AI systems are already regulated at the point of use by our existing expert regulators. This is both through sector-specific regulations such as medicines regulation, and cross-cutting legal safeguards including data protection, competition, product safety, and equalities laws. The safety of the British public is a non-negotiable priority. Where new protections are needed, we will act, legislating wherever necessary.

Bell Ribeiro-Addy: [34561]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what statutory safety obligations apply to frontier AI developers operating in the UK.

Kanishka Narayan:
AI is already regulated in the UK through existing laws and regulators, covering data protection, competition, product safety, and online safety. For example, data protection legislation applies to personal data processing regardless of the technology used. We have outlawed AI models generating child sexual abuse material and criminalised intimate deepfakes. We are also examining how the Cyber Security and Resilience Bill can respond to emerging AI risks to essential services, such as through developing a voluntary reporting framework on near-miss incidents. But we should not assume that the existing framework will always be sufficient as AI capabilities develop. The safety of the British public is a non-negotiable priority. Where new protections are needed, we will act, legislating wherever necessary. Any future measures will be evidence-based and focused on the risks we need to address.

Bell Ribeiro-Addy: [34562]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, whether he has considered the potential merits of legislating to introduce binding safety obligations on frontier AI developers.

Kanishka Narayan:
The government is ensuring that the UK is ready for both the challenges and opportunities that AI will bring. We have taken important steps to ensure that many AI systems are already regulated at the point of use by our existing regulators. We are also examining how the Cyber Security and Resilience Bill can respond to emerging AI risks to essential services, including through developing a voluntary reporting framework for near-miss incidents. But we should not assume that the existing framework will always be sufficient as AI capabilities develop. The safety of the British public is a non-negotiable priority. Where new protections are needed, we will act, legislating wherever necessary.

Artificial Intelligence: Training

Dr Ben Spencer: [31695]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what the distribution of course duration is among courses completed through the AI Skills Hub; and how many completions were of courses of (a) under 20 minutes, (b) 20 minutes to 2 hours and (c) over 2 hours.

Kanishka Narayan:
The AI Skills Hub provides access to a wide range of learning opportunities of from shorter self-paced courses to longer-term programmes. As part of this wider offer, 18 foundational AI courses aligned to the Skills England framework are spotlighted through the AI Skills Boost programme, with courses ranging from around 20 minutes to three weeks in duration.

The AI Skills Boost programme is delivered through a partnership model involving 32 industry and public sector organisations. The AI Skills Hub directs users to training hosted on partner platforms and partners report course completion data to the Department in aggregate rather than at individual course level. As a result, the Department cannot provide a breakdown on the distribution of course completions by duration. The Department is currently working with industry partners to review what data is collected to monitor the benefits of the programme.

Ceramics: Government assistance

David Williams: [34585]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, for an update on the delivery of the Government’s £120 million support package for the UK ceramics sector.

David Williams: [34588]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what steps his Department is taking to help ensure that smaller ceramics manufacturers are able to access support through the £120 million support scheme.

Blair McDougall:
Department for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade (BIST) officials are currently designing the Ceramics Industry Support Scheme in close collaboration with the ceramics sector. BIST officials intend to provide further information around application guidance and likely scheme eligibility towards the end of this year, with applications likely opening in early 2027. BIST officials have engaged extensively, including with smaller ceramics manufacturers, to ensure the scheme will be accessible for a wide range of sub-sectors.

Conditions of Employment: Regulation

Joe Robertson: [35812]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what assessment his Department has made of the use of offshoring by multinational companies to circumvent protections under the Transfer of Undertakings (Protection of Employment) Regulations 2006.

Kate Dearden:
The Government is committed to ensuring employees are appropriately protected when businesses change ownership or services transfer between employers through the TUPE regulations. The application of these protections depends on the circumstances of the individual transfer, including the relevant territorial requirements.

The Department has not undertaken a specific assessment of the extent to which multinational companies may use offshoring arrangements to circumvent TUPE protections, but the Government is currently analysing evidence from a Call for Evidence to better understand how TUPE operates in practice and identify opportunities to make improvements. The evidence received will inform future policy development.

Joe Robertson: [35813]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what assessment his Department has made of whether the definition of redundancy in section 139 of the Employment Rights Act 1996 remains adequate where the work continues but is relocated to an overseas jurisdiction.

Joe Robertson: [35814]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what steps his Department is taking to strengthen the enforcement of employment rights for workers affected by the offshoring of their roles.

Kate Dearden:
Offshoring of roles are commercial matters for individual businesses, but when employees are made redundant because their jobs are moved overseas, they must be collectively consulted if the redundancies meet collective redundancy obligations in UK law.

The government is introducing an organisation wide threshold alongside the single establishment test, so employees will benefit from stronger collective redundancy protections.

We have also doubled the protective award from 90 to 180 day's pay when employers ignore their obligations.

However, the department does not currently plan to carry out a specific assessment of the definition of redundancy in section 139 of the Employment Rights Act 1996.

Cooperatives: Regulation

Josh Newbury: [35241]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what steps his Department is taking to tackle regulatory barriers to the creation of new co-operatives.

Blair McDougall:
The Government is committed to reducing regulatory barriers to establishing and growing co-operatives. We will shortly publish our response to the call for evidence on business support for co-operatives and non-financial mutuals, which will set out our approach to easing regulatory barriers more generally.

In September, the Department published a consultation on modernising corporate reporting, including considering how reporting requirements can be made more proportionate and better suited to member-owned businesses.

Separately, the Law Commission is reviewing co-operative and community benefit society law, including provisions on share capital and external investment, and is expected to report in early 2027.

Corporate Governance: Human Rights

John McDonnell: [34878]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what alternative, proactive and binding measures he will put in place to help protect human rights in the context of the Modernising Corporate Reporting consultation.

Blair McDougall:
The Modernising Corporate Reporting (MCR) consultation proposes refocusing the Annual Report to provide financially material information to investors and creditors. Proposed changes in the consultation do not alter the legal framework protecting human rights. The Government expects all companies to respect human rights throughout their operations and supply chains, in line with the OECD Guidelines for Responsible Business Conduct and the UN Guiding Principles on Human Rights.

Corporate Governance: Meetings

Graham Leadbitter: [34985]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, with reference to the consultation entitled Modernising Corporate Reporting to support long-term economic growth, published 7 September 2026, what consideration has been made regarding Annual General Meetings moving to online only and the potential impact on attendance and scrutiny of corporate leadership.

Blair McDougall:
The government has committed to clarifying the law in relation to fully virtual Annual General Meetings (AGMs). Officials are engaging with investors and business across the country on the practicalities of this and a full assessment is being undertaken as part of the Modernising Corporate Reporting programme. This includes consulting on safeguards that should accompany the change, including how shareholder rights relating to attendance and the ability to challenge company directors are protected. This will ensure that fully virtual meetings only take place where shareholders agree, preserving the option for physical or hybrid attendance where it is shareholders' preferred format.

Corporate Governance: Public Consultation

Mr Joshua Reynolds: [35996]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what assessment his Department has made of the potential impact of its consultation entitled Modernising Corporate Reporting to Support Long-term Economic Growth on the work of the Small Business Regulatory Taskforce.

Blair McDougall:
The Modernising Corporate Reporting consultation and the Small Business Regulatory Taskforce are complementary, both contributing to the Government's wider objective of reducing regulatory burdens on business. The consultation is seeking evidence on the costs, benefits and practical impacts of potential reforms including for SMEs.

As consultation proposals are developed, the Government will consider their impacts on business and undertake appropriate assessment before implementation. This will ensure that reforms are evidence-based and proportionate while supporting the Government's wider regulatory reform objectives.

Data Centres: Regulation

Stuart Anderson: [34792]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what regulatory guardrails are being placed on commercial providers operating critical data centres in the UK.

Kanishka Narayan:
The Government recognises the critical role that commercially operated data centres play in supporting our economy, public services and national security. Through the Cyber Security and Resilience Bill, qualifying data centres will be brought within the Network and Information Systems regulatory framework, requiring operators to take appropriate and proportionate measures to manage risks to their network and information systems and strengthening incident-reporting arrangements.

Export Controls: Dual Use Goods and Technologies

Stuart Anderson: [34781]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what export control measures are being tightened to prevent the leakage of sensitive dual-use technologies to hostile actors.

Blair McDougall:
We keep our controls under review to ensure they keep pace with evolving risks arising from export and transfer of sensitive dual-use technologies.

In 2022, we made significant updates to our Military End-Use Control, making it more effective to counter these threats. We are also working with our international partners and have jointly introduced controls on emerging technology, for example items related to quantum computing and semiconductors.

We will continue to review our measures to strike the right balance between restricting access to sensitive technologies to protect national security, and facilitating legitimate exports to support sovereign innovation and growth.

Fireworks: Public Consultation

Abtisam Mohamed: [34992]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, when his Department intends to publish its response to the consultation on Fireworks and pyrotechnics in the UK; and whether he plans to bring forward legislation in light of the consultation's findings.

Kate Dearden:
The Government is currently reviewing responses to the consultation which closed on 7 October 2026 and will publish the Government response in due course. The consultation sought views on targeted reforms to fireworks and pyrotechnics legislation. Over 140,000 responses were received. The evidence provided by members of the public, businesses, charities, enforcement bodies and other stakeholders is being carefully considered and will inform decisions on whether legislative changes are required.

Insolvency

Lara Bird: [35117]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what assessment he has made of the adequacy of the insolvency framework in providing protection to purchasers who have paid deposits for properties that have not yet been completed when the developer enters administration.

Blair McDougall:
The insolvency framework does not provide specific protections for purchasers of uncompleted properties. An administrator is under a statutory duty to assess the company's assets and liabilities and must act in the interests of creditors as a whole. The treatment of any purchaser's claim will depend on the circumstances of the case, including any contractual arrangements. Once assets have been realised and claims agreed, any remaining funds will be distributed according to the order of priority set out in legislation.

Insolvency: Company Investigations

Lara Bird: [35115]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, when amounts are owed between companies within the same property development group, what mechanisms exist to ensure that potentially recoverable funds or assets are adequately investigated and pursued for the benefit of creditors.

Blair McDougall:
Where a company enters administration or liquidation, the insolvency practitioner acting as office-holder is responsible for identifying and dealing with the company's assets, including any amounts due from other companies.

Office-holders have wide powers to secure company property and seek information and, where appropriate, pursue recovery action. Where relevant legal thresholds are met, they may also seek to overturn certain transactions made prior to the insolvency proceedings that were not to the benefit of all of the creditors, so that assets may be restored for the benefit of the insolvent estate and its creditors.

Lara Bird: [35118]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, whether he is considering the potential merits of changes to insolvency or consumer-protection legislation to provide greater protection to purchasers of off-plan residential property, including greater protection for deposits.

Blair McDougall:
The Government keeps insolvency legislation under regular review to ensure that it continues to provide appropriate protection for businesses and consumers. There are existing safeguards when a developer becomes subject to insolvency proceedings, including powers to investigate directors' conduct with particular attention paid to deposits accepted when developers are unable to fulfil their obligations. Where

misconduct is identified, and it is in the public interest to do so, enforcement action may follow to disqualify the directors from acting in the management of a company for a period of between 2 and 15 years.

Insolvency: Fees and Charges

Lara Bird: [35119]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what oversight mechanisms are in place governing the fees and expenses charged by insolvency practitioners in large property administrations involving hundreds of individual purchasers.

Blair McDougall:
Insolvency practitioners must follow statutory requirements and regulatory guidance on how their remuneration must be reported. The requirements seek to ensure that fees are a fair and reasonable reflection of the work undertaken while appointed.

Insolvency practitioners are subject to a robust regulatory regime, where they are monitored by Recognised Professional Bodies, who are themselves subject to oversight regulation by the Secretary of State.

Creditors are given opportunities to question fees and challenge them, with the court being the ultimate arbiter if disputes cannot be resolved.

Lara Bird: [35121]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, whether he plans to introduce improved rights for purchasers in large property administrations to establish (a) representative creditor committees and (b) equivalent mechanisms to scrutinise administrator decisions, fees, asset recoveries and investigations.

Blair McDougall:
There are no plans to introduce improved rights as the insolvency framework already contains robust safeguards to ensure that administrators, who are authorised insolvency practitioners, are subject to appropriate oversight and scrutiny to ensure transparency and accountability. Administrators must provide creditors with regular progress reports, and seek their approval for their initial proposals as well as their remuneration and expenses. Creditors must also be invited to establish a creditors' committee to represent their interests and assist the administrator in the administration, and may request further information about an office-holder's remuneration and expenses.

Insolvency: Regulation

Lara Bird: [35122]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, whether he plans to review the adequacy of the regulatory and insolvency framework in providing protection for consumers purchasing off-plan property from developers operating through multiple connected companies.

Blair McDougall:
The Government is currently considering responses to its recently concluded Corporate Civil Enforcement Reforms consultation.

The regulatory and insolvency framework balances the interests of consumers, employees, businesses and other creditors. Duties of company directors are set out in legislation, and they are expected to comply with company and insolvency law and uphold the highest standards of corporate governance.

The recent consultation included proposals to modernise corporate enforcement, such as automatic disqualification of directors where companies are wound up by the court on public interest grounds, and director restrictions to tackle misconduct more quickly and prevent escalation.

Jaguar Land Rover: Supply Chains

Wendy Morton: [35314]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what assessment his Department has made of the adequacy of Government financial support available to small and medium-sized businesses in Jaguar Land Rover's supply chain affected by production disruption.

Blair McDougall:
Last year, Government backed Jaguar Land Rover with a partial guarantee for a commercial loan of £1.5bn through UK Export Finance, to help JLR unlock commercial financing and ensure liquidity while operations were restored following a cyber-attack.

We are working with industry to strengthen the resilience of the UK automotive supply chain and since the cyber-attack we have introduced a new supply chain programme. The DRIVE35 funded Suppliers Readiness and Transformation Programme, delivered in partnership with the Northeast and West Midlands Metro Mayors, has allocated up to £50 million per region to support locally critical components and capabilities.

Members: Correspondence

Sir Christopher Chope: [34998]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, pursuant to the Answer of 14 July 2026 to Question 17298 on Members: Correspondence, when he plans to respond to the correspondence referred in that answer.

Blair McDougall:
A response was issued to the Honourable Member very recently. The Department for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade aims to respond to correspondence in 15 working days. Regrettably, due to an administrative error the Honourable Member's correspondence was not processed within this timeframe. I apologise to the Honourable Member for this delay, which falls short of the standard expected.

Motor Vehicles: Imports

Esther McVey: [35449]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what assessment has been made on the impact of Chinese vehicle imports on the UK automotive industry.

Blair McDougall:
We recognise the increase in Chinese automotive imports and continue to engage closely with UK automotive manufacturers to understand the impact on their interests. The UK will tailor any approach to the needs of our domestic industry. Any response will reflect the continued importance of maintaining the sector's competitiveness and be proportionate and evidence based.

Motor Vehicles: Manufacturing Industries

Alison Griffiths: [34162]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, how many automotive manufacturers and suppliers are expected to receive support under the British Industrial Competitiveness Scheme; and when that support will become available.

Rebecca Smith: [34384]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what assessment he has made of the difference in industrial energy costs between UK automotive manufacturers and their principal international competitors.

Rebecca Smith: [34387]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what assessment he has made of the difference in industrial energy costs between UK automotive manufacturers and their principal international competitors.

Blair McDougall:
The Government recognises the impact that high energy costs are having on the automotive sector. Through the launch of the British Industrial Competitiveness Scheme (BICS) the Government is committed to helping eligible businesses, including many from the automotive sector, to reduce their electricity costs to bring them more into line with other European economies.

Applications for BICS are now open until the 30 th November 2026. If approved, a business will begin to receive exemptions from April 2027. They will also receive an additional payment in 2027 to cover costs approximately equivalent to an extra year's benefit.

Wendy Morton: [34215]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what assessment his Department has made of the potential impact of Government-backed financial support for Jaguar Land Rover on small and medium-sized businesses in its supply chain.

Blair McDougall:
Last year, Government backed Jaguar Land Rover with a partial guarantee for a commercial loan of £1.5bn through UK Export Finance, to help JLR unlock commercial financing and ensure liquidity while operations were restored following a cyber-attack.

We continue to work with industry to strengthen the resilience of the UK automotive supply chain. As part of this, the DRIVE35-funded Suppliers Readiness and Transformation Programme, delivered in partnership with the North-East and West Midlands Metro Mayors, has allocated up to £50 million per region to support locally critical components and capabilities.

Wendy Morton: **[35315]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what steps his Department is taking to help small and medium-sized automotive suppliers in the West Midlands diversify their customer base.

Blair McDougall:
Our modern Industrial Strategy launched DRIVE35, the largest government investment in the automotive industry of the post-war era.

Through DRIVE35, we are working with Mayoral Strategic Authorities, including the West Midlands, to strengthen the UK's automotive manufacturing base and build competitive industrial clusters and resilient regional supply chains.

The DRIVE35 Supplier Readiness and Transformation (SRT) programme has invested up to £100 million in the North East and West Midlands to accelerate supply-chain growth and EV readiness. It offers grants to help West Midlands automotive suppliers scale, diversify and build critical EV supply-chain capacity.

Esther McVey: **[35450]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, whether he believes there may be a need to introduce measures to support domestic automotive manufacturers.

Blair McDougall:
The UK automotive sector has a proud history and is facing global headwinds. This government has already introduced major measures to support their success, through delivery of the Modern Industrial Strategy, including the £4bn DRIVE35 programme of capital and R&D funding, securing tariff-cutting trade deals with the US and India, bringing down industrial energy costs, stimulating EV demand through the Electric Car Grant, and consulting on the ZEV Mandate. Bentley, McLaren and Nissan secured investments of over £1 billion just last month. JLR have recently launched two iconic Solihull-made EV models. We are creating the right business environment for companies to invest – and working closely with industry.

Music: Competition

John Slinger: [31012]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, whether his department considered asking the Competition and Markets Authority to investigate the consolidation of independent music distributors by major record companies based overseas.

Kate Dearden:
As the UK's independent competition authority, the Competition and Markets Authority ("CMA") investigates mergers that meet certain jurisdictional tests based on UK turnover or market share, as set out in the Enterprise Act 2002. The government has ensured that the CMA has significant powers and expertise to investigate the benefits and risks of mergers in relation to competition.

Research and Science: Finance

Freddie van Mierlo: [35868]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, with reference to his oral contribution in response to the hon. Member for Henley and Thame during oral questions on 15 October 2026, how much funding has been diverted to defence spending from the former Department for Science, Innovation and Technology budget; and which programmes have been impacted.

Kate Dearden:
Departments have been asked to contribute 1p in every £1 of their capital budgets to help fund the Defence Investment Plan.

BIST is assessing how best to deliver this contribution while continuing to support key priorities, including for programmes previously delivered by the Department for Science, Innovation & Technology. Decisions regarding individual programmes are still being carefully considered, and further details will be set out in due course.

Semiconductors: Research

Stuart Anderson: [34784]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what funding has been dedicated to sovereign semiconductor research and fabrication security.

Kanishka Narayan:
The Government is supporting sovereign semiconductor research and fabrication through a range of targeted investments as part of the UK's Modern Industrial Strategy. This includes over £1.1 billion through the UK AI Hardware Plan and £718 million for semiconductor, advanced connectivity technologies and cyber research via UKRI up to 2030. The Government has also supported domestic fabrication capability, including a £60 million National Wealth Fund investment in Pragmatic Semiconductor, support through the Automotive Transformation Fund for Vishay's £250 million investment in Newport, and the Ministry of Defence's acquisition of the

facility now operating as Octric Semiconductor. These investments strengthen UK sovereign research, commercialisation, resilience and manufacturing capability.

Shipping: Antarctic

Ben Obese-Jecty: [35656]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, on what date the RRS Sir David Attenborough is due to deploy to the South Atlantic for the 2026/27 Antarctic season.

Chris McDonald:
The Royal Research Ship (RRS) Sir David Attenborough departed the UK on 21 October 2026 to begin its deployment for the 2026-27 Antarctic Season.

Following a refuelling stop in Plymouth, the vessel is scheduled to call at Montevideo, Uruguay, on 10 November 2026 before next arriving at the British Antarctic Survey's Signy Research Station in the South Orkney Islands on 20 November 2026.

Trade Remedies: Turkey

Sarah Champion: [34745]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, what assessment his Department has made of the potential merits of implementing trade remedies on imports of glass packaging from Turkey.

Blair McDougall:
On 5 March 2026 the Trade Remedies Authority (TRA) opened a subsidy investigation on glass containers from Turkey.

The TRA submits evidence-based determinations to the Secretary of State, inclusive of an assessment of whether a measure would be in the UK’s economic interest. Where the TRA recommends a measure, the Secretary of State considers the evidence alongside relevant matters in the public interest before taking a decision.

The TRA is an independent arms-length body and as such it would not be appropriate to comment further. All TRA recommendations are published on its public file at the appropriate time.

UK Trade with EU

Mike Wood: [35463]

To ask the Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, with reference to the policy paper entitled Explanatory Memorandum on a UK/EU Withdrawal Agreement or Trade And Cooperation Agreement Governance Document, COM(2025)804, whether the UK will be required to dynamically align with the EU State Aid rules of (a) Climate, Energy and Environmental Aid Guidelines and (b) Clean Industrial State Aid Framework.

Blair McDougall:
The UK and EU have agreed to work towards UK participation in the EU's Internal Electricity Market. As set out in the Common Understanding published in December 2025 following exploratory talks, this includes applying State aid rules to aid that specifically targets the electricity sector or has a particular material effect on the electricity market. The precise terms of an Electricity Agreement, including the relevant State aid rules that will apply to aid in scope of an agreement, remain subject to negotiation. The Government will not provide a running commentary on those negotiations.

CABINET OFFICE

Artificial Intelligence: China

Dr Ben Spencer: [28819]

To ask the Minister for the Cabinet Office, whether open weight models from China are being procured for use by government departments.

Kanishka Narayan:
Departments are responsible for their own decisions on the technology they procure and use under established commercial frameworks, including AI models. As this procurement is managed at department level, information on the specific AI models used by individual departments is not held centrally by the Cabinet Office.

Government has robust processes for assessing the security, technical and commercial implications of technology before it is approved for use. Where appropriate, departments engage with the Government Digital Service, Government Cyber Unit and the National Cyber Security Centre as part of this assurance.

Cabinet Office: Written Questions

Dr Ben Spencer: [34343]

To ask the Minister for the Cabinet Office, when she intends to answer the named day question 28819; and if she will publish statistics on the performance of the Cabinet Office in responding to written questions on time a) before and b) after summer 2026 reshuffle.

Kanishka Narayan:
I refer the Hon. Member to the answer I gave on 22 October to Question UIN 28819. Departmental performance in responding to written questions on time will be scrutinised by the Procedure Committee in the usual way.

Dr Ben Spencer: [36088]

To ask the Minister for the Cabinet Office, pursuant to the overdue responses to Named Day Question 28819 and follow up Question 34343, for what reason has a response not yet been published; and what steps she is taking to ensure a response is provided without further delay.

Kanishka Narayan:
I refer the Hon. Member to the answer I gave on 22 October to Question UIN 28819. I apologise for the delay in responding. Following the Machinery of Government changes in July, it took longer than expected to confirm where the information requested was held.

Civil Servants: Conflict of Interests

Mike Wood: [20575]

To ask the Minister for the Cabinet Office, what steps were taken to avoid conflicts of interest for ISC civil servants in relation to reviewing redactions to the response to the Humble Address on Lord Mandelson.

Mark Ferguson:
I refer the Hon Member to the Government's statement and release of information on 1 June 2026 in response to the Humble Address and in particular to the Methodology section. Any papers deemed prejudicial to national security or international relations were referred to the ISC, and it was for the members of the committee alone to consider these.

Conflict of Interests

Mike Wood: [28756]

To ask the Minister for the Cabinet Office, pursuant to the Answer of 8 September 2026 to Question 16936, on Conflicts of Interest, what is her Department's current policy, prior to the Home Office review, on whether a ban on engagement includes (a) social contact, (b) party political contact and (c) electronic contact through non-corporate channels.

Mark Ferguson:
Our policy on engagement with the Muslim Council of Britain has not changed. This includes any contact in an official capacity.

Any official contact with outside organisations must follow the guidance on use of non-corporate communications channels.

Party political contact with outside organisations is a matter for political parties.

Department for Transport: Public Relations

Mike Wood: [26574]

To ask the Minister for the Cabinet Office, pursuant to the answer of 28 August 2026 to Question 17510 on Department for Transport: Public Relations, whether the public affairs consultancy contracts held by the Arm's Length Bodies of the Department for Transport were approved by her Department.

Mark Ferguson:
Under the Advertising, marketing and communications spending process, the Government Communication Service does not give approval for expenditure below £100,000.

No 10 North: Doors

Ben Obese-Jecty: [27070]

To ask the Minister for the Cabinet Office, with reference to FOI2026/14032, what assessment she has made of the value for money of spending £978.87 on moving a replica No.10 door from London to Manchester.

Mark Ferguson:
No10 North is a working centre of government driving the Prime Minister's devolution agenda and bringing decision-makers closer to local communities. The door referenced was created as an art installation as part of the GREAT campaign in 2015.

Standard of Living

Hannah Spencer: [30242]

To ask the Minister for the Cabinet Office, what assessment she has made of the potential implications for her policies of the report by Trussell entitled Living Costs in Context: Voices from the frontline, published on 8 September 2026.

Mark Ferguson:
The Government welcomes the Trussell report “Living Costs in Context: Voices from the frontline” and their continued work on food poverty in the UK. We agree with the report's primary conclusion that the cost of daily essentials are too high for too many people. The Cost of Living Taskforce is focussed on addressing the structural issues driving up the cost of everyday living.

DEFENCE

Air Force: Military Bases

Ben Obese-Jecty: [34690]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, what assessment has he made of the potential merits of a requirement for hardened aircraft shelters at all UK RAF bases which conduct flight operations.

Louise Sandher-Jones:
A future requirement for Hardened Aircraft Shelters (HAS) across UK Royal Air Force Bases has been identified.

Armed Forces: Deployment

Stuart Anderson: [34344]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, how the UK’s overseas military footprint is being organised to meet regional deterrence goals.

Louise Sandher-Jones:
The Strategic Defence Review put NATO First at the heart of UK defence policy, reflecting the growing threat from Russia and the need for European Allies to take greater responsibility for our collective security. We are therefore prioritising our military contribution where it can have the greatest deterrent effect, while retaining the flexibility to respond to emerging threats.

The Global Integrated Plan is the Department's mechanism for cohering Defence activity across regions, ensuring military activity is aligned with the Government's highest priorities. This mechanism regularly reviews our global military footprint against evolving security challenges.

The UK leads NATO's Forward Land Forces in Estonia, contributes to NATO Air Policing on the Eastern Flank and to maritime security in the Baltic, while increasing our presence and activity in the High North. We continually assess our force posture against the evolving threat and requirement to ensure UK forces remain positioned to deter, defend and respond wherever required.

Boxer Vehicles: Procurement

Ben Obese-Jecty: [36201]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, pursuant to the answer of 4 June 2021, to question 10208 on Boxer Vehicles: Procurement, if he can provide an updated breakdown of the 623 Boxer by a) MIV variant, b) Build Configuration and c) role, as at today.

Luke Pollard:
I refer the hon. Member to the answer I gave on 18 December 2025 to Question 100025, which set out the number of Mechanised Infantry Vehicle (MIV) Boxers contracted for by variant. This information remains extant. As the Boxer programme has developed, build configuration and variant have become effectively interchangeable, with all 623 MIV Boxer vehicles being delivered to a common build standard. Consequently, a separate breakdown by build configuration is no longer relevant.

The Department keeps under review its approach to the disclosure of information, taking account of a range of factors. An updated breakdown by role could pose a risk to operational security and, therefore, I am unable to provide this information.

Cybersecurity: Hybrid Warfare

Stuart Anderson: [34797]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, what doctrine governs the deployment of active cyber measures in response to hybrid attacks on allies.

Louise Sandher-Jones:
The UK is taking coordinated action with NATO Allies and other international partners to counter the growing threat from hostile state hybrid activity and increase our collective resilience. The Government has a range of levers available to deter and

respond to such activity, including cyber capabilities. Decisions on the use of cyber capabilities are taken through national decision-making arrangements on a case-by-case basis, with any activity conducted in accordance with international law.

Defence: Artificial Intelligence

Ben Obese-Jecty: [36262]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, what funding has been allocated to the Digital Targeting Web for a) 2026/27, b) 2027/28 and c) 2028 onwards.

Luke Pollard:
As set out in the Defence Investment Plan, the Ministry of Defence intends to invest up to £1.8 billion into the Digital Targeting Web over the next four years.

As part of this funding, £266 million has been allocated for 2026-27; £352 million for 2027-28; and £1213 million for 2028-29 to 2029-30.

The Department is midway through its annual strategic balance of investment process, the Strategic Planning Cycle 2027. As part of this process, the Digital Targeting Web's funding profile between 2027-28 - 2029-30 is currently being refined. It is anticipated that the Digital Targeting Web’s financial profile will be confirmed by the end of the financial year.

Defence: Finance

Ben Obese-Jecty: [34894]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, pursuant to the answer of 14 October 2026, to question 29718 on Defence: Finance, whether he has identified the £300 million of assets to be sold in 2027/28 in order to fund his contribution to the Defence Investment Plan in that financial year.

Luke Pollard:
The Ministry of Defence has a target to deliver £400 million from asset efficiencies over a three year period from 2027-28 to 2029-30.

The Department has carried out a strategic review of its assets to identify opportunities to dispose of surplus assets and submitted these to HMT.

Defence: Skilled Workers

Stuart Anderson: [34359]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, what steps are being taken to help address skills shortages and engineering deficits within the domestic defence workforce.

Luke Pollard:
Addressing critical skills shortages is key to ensuring the UK defence sector has the workforce required now and in the future. The £182 million Defence Industry Skills package is strengthening the pipeline into defence careers and expanding training in strategically important disciplines, including engineering.

This Government is proud to have invested in skills for the first time as part of the Defence Industrial Strategy. This includes £50 million for five Defence Technical Excellence Colleges (DTECs) in England, which will equip students aged 16 and above with the technical skills required for critical defence roles. We also intend to launch two DTECs in Scotland, one in Wales, and we are working with the Northern Ireland Executive on similar skills initiatives as part of the NI Defence Growth Deal.

Defence: Telecommunications

Ben Obese-Jecty: [27307]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, what progress has he made in securing sovereign UK capability to develop high-bandwidth, platform-to-platform and ground-to-space links.

Luke Pollard:
The Ministry of Defence continues to invest in sovereign and assured communications capabilities, including through the SKYNET 6 programme and the modernisation of Defence's satellite communications infrastructure.

SKYNET 6 will deliver the next generation of military satellite communications, providing increased capacity, resilience and secure global connectivity. Defence is also exploring emerging technologies to support higher-bandwidth links between satellites and ground infrastructure, alongside allied and commercial capabilities where appropriate.

Detailed information on the technical characteristics and development of military communications capabilities is not routinely disclosed where doing so could prejudice operational security. Defence continues to develop and assess technologies that improve the capacity, resilience and security of communications across the Integrated Force.

This approach will ensure the UK retains the sovereign capability and freedom of action required to meet current and future operational demands.

Lithuania and Poland: Military Aid

Jim Shannon: [34635]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, what steps he is taking to support Poland and Lithuania in preparations for a potential Russian attack and help NATO protect the West.

Louise Sandher-Jones:
The UK stands ready to defend every inch of Allied territory, with NATO remaining the cornerstone of the UK's defence and security. This is reflected in our commitment to reach NATO's defence spending target of 3.5% of GDP by 2035. Article 5 of the North Atlantic Treaty makes clear that an armed attack against one NATO Ally is considered an attack against the entire NATO Alliance.

As the third-largest cash spender on defence in NATO, the UK contributes significantly towards the security of NATO's eastern flank, which includes Poland and

Lithuania. This is demonstrated through rotational air policing, troop deployments, and joint exercises, including maritime surveillance in the Baltic region. NATO is a defensive alliance and does not seek confrontation with Russia, but Russia should understand that any attack on a NATO ally would be a grave miscalculation.

Manufacturing Industries: Government Assistance

Stuart Anderson: [34774]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, whether financial incentives are being offered to rebuild the domestic defence manufacturing and industrial base.

Luke Pollard:
The Ministry of Defence is taking action to strengthen the UK's defence industrial base through targeted investment in skills, innovation, regional growth and supply chains. Through the Defence Industrial Strategy and Defence Investment Plan, the Ministry of Defence has committed £250 million to five Defence Growth Deals across the UK and £182 million to a defence-industry skills package. In addition, the forthcoming Defence Finance and Investment Strategy will support greater private investment into defence and dual-use businesses.

Military Bases: Scotland

Graham Leadbitter: [36153]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, pursuant to the answer of 6 October 2026 to Question 21505, how much of the £470 million investment to improve the security of critical military sites across the UK will be allocated to Scottish military sites.

Luke Pollard:
Defence has already invested in surveillance and counter-drone capabilities and is working to extend Restricted Airspace protections around Defence sites. The Defence Investment Plan (DIP) provides an additional £470 million over four years to enhance site protection and reduce legacy underspending. Plans for investing this allocation from the DIP are still in development and we cannot comment further on the specifics.

National Cyber Force

Stuart Anderson: [34794]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, how the National Cyber Force (NCF) is scaling its operations to counter state-backed threat actors operating below the threshold of war.

Louise Sandher-Jones:
The Ministry of Defence does not comment on operational matters as disclosure of such detail could undermine operational and national security.

Nuclear Weapons: Finance

Ben Obese-Jecty: [22946]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, with reference to recommendation 35 of the 2025 Strategic Defence Review, what progress he has made in developing mechanisms for enhanced parliamentary scrutiny to provide confidence that funding from the public purse is being spent wisely in pursuit of the nation's highest defence priority.

Ben Obese-Jecty: [36566]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, by what date will he respond to Question 22946 on Nuclear Weapons: Finance.

Luke Pollard:
The Government will establish a new Commons-only Committee to conduct scrutiny of Defence Nuclear Enterprise expenditure and programmes, subject to the approval of the House of Commons. The new Committee will have a tightly focused remit and will consider relevant reports from the National Audit Office.

The Government is working with Parliament to set up the new, non-statutory Committee and in due course will bring forward a motion to establish the Committee under the Standing Orders.

Roll-on Roll-off Ships: Procurement

Ben Obese-Jecty: [34691]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, whether he has completed the strategic Outline Case for the Strategic Sealift Future (SSL-F) programme.

Luke Pollard:
The Strategic Outline Case for the Strategic Sealift - Future programme is intended to be completed this financial year.

Russia: National Security

Jim Shannon: [34641]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, what steps he is taking to work with the USA to reduce Russian threat in both our home territories.

Louise Sandher-Jones:
As our closest defence and security partner, we engage and collaborate with the US regularly on a range of issues. We know Russia is conducting a campaign of hybrid attacks and sabotage across Europe. The UK does not seek confrontation with Russia, but we will continue to deter and contest activity that threatens Euro-Atlantic security.

Type 45 Destroyers: Lasers

Stuart Anderson: [34772]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, by what date DragonFire will be fitted on Royal Navy Type 45 Destroyers.

Luke Pollard:
I refer the hon. Member to the response to Question 17420:

https://questions-statements.parliament.uk/written-questions/detail/2026-07-09/17420

Warships: Decommissioning

Andrew Rosindell: [34886]

To ask the Secretary of State for Defence, how many warships have been a) taken out of operational service b) sold or c) scrapped in every year since 2010.

Luke Pollard:
Since 2010, 33 Royal Navy warships have been taken out of operational service. Of these, 8 have been sold, 15 have been recycled and 10 are pending disposal.

As vessels may be withdrawn from service in one year and sold or scrapped in a later year, these categories are not mutually exclusive, and the figures should not be aggregated.

As set out in the Defence Investment Plan, this Government is investing in new frigates, amphibious ships, new submarines and new standardised vessels alongside a new Hybrid Navy of uncrewed and autonomous systems to increase our Navy's lethality and deterrence.

DIGITAL, CULTURE, MEDIA AND SPORT

Broadband: North East Somerset and Hanham

Dan Norris: [32363]

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, what progress his Department has made on extending gigabit capable broadband coverage in North East Somerset and Hanham constituency.

Ian Murray:
Around 88% of premises in North East Somerset and Hanham can access a gigabit-capable broadband connection (Ofcom Connected Nations, Spring 2026).

To extend this further, more than 1,130 premises in the constituency have been included in Project Gigabit cross-regional contracts being delivered by Openreach. Approximately 270 of these premises can now access a gigabit-capable connection, with further delivery continuing under the contracts up until 2030.

In addition, over 2,620 premises in the constituency have benefited from completed Gigabit Broadband Voucher Scheme projects, helping to extend gigabit-capable broadband coverage in harder-to-reach areas.

We are also continuously monitoring suppliers' commercial rollout plans and data to identify areas that may be at risk of missing out on gigabit-capable broadband. Where such areas are identified and meet the relevant criteria, we work with suppliers to consider bringing premises into existing or future Project Gigabit contracts, helping to ensure as many premises as possible can benefit from gigabit-capable connectivity.

BT Group: TalkTalk Group

James Wild: [34174]

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, with reference to the Public Interest Intervention Notice she issued on 5 October, if she will make an assessment of whether the time for the Competition and Markets Authority to investigate and report was adequate.

James Wild: [34176]

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, with reference to the Public Interest Intervention Notice she issued on 5 October 2026, what alternative options to ensure continuity of service for customers were considered.

James Wild: [34260]

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, further to the Public Interest Intervention Notice issued on 5 October 2026, whether she has had discussions with the Competition and Markets Authority on potential structural remedies, including the separation or divestment of PlatformX Communications and TalkTalk's consumer business in the event that competition concerns are identified.

Ian Murray:
An open bidding process for TalkTalk resulted in no deal being reached. Following that process, BT agreed to buy the business out of administration. This was a commercial transaction in which the Government was not involved.

The Secretary of State issued a Public Interest Intervention Notice (PIIN), to enable consideration of public interest issues alongside any competition concerns the CMA may raise in their Report. See the PIIN for further detail.

Given the Secretary of State's quasi-judicial role in the process, it would not be appropriate to comment further while it is ongoing.

Digital Technology: Recycling

Alex Brewer: [35380]

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, what assessment she has made of the potential impact of refurbished digital devices on reducing digital

exclusion; and what steps her Department is taking to improve access to and awareness of such devices.

Vicky Foxcroft:
The Government recognises that secure, suitable digital devices are essential for accessing services and participating in digital life.

Through the Digital Inclusion Action Plan, we have already donated more than 29,000 devices through signatories to our IT Reuse for Good Charter and our multi-departmental device donation pilot. Our pilot is helping us understand how government devices can be effectively reused, informing wider work with councils, charities, community groups and businesses to develop sustainable approaches to donation, lending and reuse.

Extracurricular Activities: West Midlands

Wendy Morton: [34216]

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, with reference to the Enrichment Expansion programme area list published on 25 September 2026, if her Department will publish the scores and rankings used to assess (a) Walsall, (b) Birmingham and (c) Sandwell for inclusion in the programme; and for what reasons Walsall was not selected.

Vicky Foxcroft:
DCMS is committed to making a difference in the places that need it the most, through investing to build social and community cohesion and to enhance opportunity where outcomes are poorest.

Evidence points clearly to economic and social outcomes being systematically worse in places where both deprivation and community need is highest; places experiencing ‘double disadvantage’. For this reason, across our programmes that aim to improve social and community outcomes, we will look to implement a tailored focus on targeting these ‘double disadvantage’ places – to ensure that our funding is concentrated in the communities where we can make the biggest difference. DCMS’ approach to place targeting is publicly available.

The Enrichment Expansion Programme (EEP), a DCMS-funded programme delivered in strategic partnership with DfE, will invest £22.5 million across 3 years to support up to 400 secondary schools to provide a youth led, tailored enrichment offer and help them meet the Enrichment Framework benchmarks.

In order to select local authorities to participate in the programme, lower-layer super output areas (LSOAs) were identified as being in the most deprived 20% nationally on both the Income Deprivation Affecting Children Index (IDACI) and the Community Needs Index (CNI). In this instance IDACI serves a similar purpose to the Indices of Multiple Deprivation (IMD) used in the DCMS wide approach but focuses in particular on deprivation impacting young people. LSOAs meeting both criteria were classified as experiencing double disadvantage. The proportion of double-disadvantaged LSOAs within each lower-tier local authority was then calculated, and local authorities

were ranked on this basis, with a minimum number of three areas represented across all nine regions.

Additionally, areas were included to align with DfE's Mission North East and Mission Coastal. The Place Missions will bring expert support into classrooms and new opportunities beyond the school gates for children in the North East, Hastings and Scarborough.

To ensure each school within the programme receives tailored support from the programme, we intend to group schools into clusters of 5-8 according to geographic proximity. Resultantly, we selected 54 clusters across 59 areas to accommodate 400 schools. Walsall did not rank highly enough to be selected as eligible for the programme. It was also not in scope for clustering given the number of eligible schools within neighbouring eligible areas.

Internet: Safety

Anneliese Dodds: **[34834]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, what assessment she has made of the effectiveness of the Online Safety Act 2023 in protecting children from harmful gendered content, including misogynistic content and harmful stereotypes, where that content is recommended or amplified by social media platforms' algorithmic systems.

Anneliese Dodds: **[34835]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, what data her Department holds on the extent to which children are recommended or exposed to misogynistic, anti-feminist or other harmful gendered content by social media platforms.

Ian Murray:
The Online Safety Act requires platforms to address algorithmic risks, including promotion of illegal content and content harmful to children, including hateful misogynistic content.

We expect companies to implement Ofcom's recommended measures for making platforms safer for women and girls, including deprioritising harmful content in recommender algorithms and de-monetising content promoting misogynistic abuse.

Ofcom undertakes and publishes research into online harms, including misogynistic content, which the Department draws on alongside external evidence.

Anneliese Dodds: **[34836]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, what assessment she has made of Ofcom's progress in implementing the remaining duties under the Online Safety Act 2023, and whether those measures will adequately protect children from exposure to harmful gendered content online.

Ian Murray:
The Online Safety Act 2023 requires in-scope services to proactively tackle the most harmful illegal content, much of which disproportionately affects women and girls.

Services must also protect children from harmful content, including misogynistic content. The Government has called on all platforms to implement the measures recommended in Ofcom's guidance, A safer life online for women and girls.

Ofcom has pushed a roadmap setting out the remaining duties to be implemented under the Act. The Government is keeping the regulatory framework under review and will take whatever steps are needed to keep children safe online.

Online Dating: Safety

Adam Dance: **[33462]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, what steps she is taking with (a) online dating platforms, (b) law enforcement agencies and (c) safeguarding organisations to develop (i) stronger and (ii) more consistent protections for dating app users.

Ian Murray:
Ofcom's guidance, 'A safer online for women and girls', sets out measures that companies, including dating platforms, can take to reduce online misogynistic abuse, harassment, stalking and image based sexual abuse. We expect platforms to implement this guidance as well as complying with their safety duties.

Under the Domestic Violence Disclosure Scheme (Clare's Law), the police have the power to disclose information to a victim or potential victim of domestic abuse, about their partner or ex-partner's abusive or violent offending. The Government is exploring how this could be extended to other forms of VAWG, including its use within online dating platforms.

Private Investigators: Regulation

Kevin Hollinrake: **[R] [30422]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, what (i) advice and (ii) guidance has been produced by the Information Commissioner on the use of private investigators, including (a) requirements for data protection registration and (b) their processing of personal data; and whether they are encouraged by the ICO to adopt the ABI code of conduct issued under Article 40 of UK GDPR.

Kevin Hollinrake: **[32049]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, what guidance the Information Commissioner has provided on whether individuals who hire private investigators are required to register with the ICO as a data controller; and whether private investigators who are sole traders are required to register.

Stephanie Peacock:
Under the Data Protection (Charges and Information) Regulations 2018, organisations, including sole traders, that process personal data are required to pay a data protection fee to the Information Commission unless an exemption applies. The Information Commission (ICO) provides guidance and an online assessment tool to

help individuals and organisations determine whether they are required to pay the fee.

The ICO is required to assess ("provide an opinion"), approve, and publish UK GDPR codes of conduct which meet article 40 requirements. The Association of British Investigators' UK GDPR Code of Conduct for Investigative and Litigation Support Services ' is approved and published by the ICO and is intended to help members apply the law and demonstrate compliance with relevant data protection requirements. The code is a voluntary one and includes advice, guidance, and practical examples in relation to:

- the roles and responsibilities of code members when acting as controllers, joint controllers or processors;
- Data Protection Impact Assessments;
- identification of the lawful basis for processing personal data; legitimate interests assessments; and
- consent to share when tracing and locating individuals in certain cases.

SSAIB has been accredited as a monitoring body by the ICO and will be responsible for the monitoring of the ABI code of conduct.

The ICO does take the opportunity to support relevant communications on this, eg on social media, trade press, speaking at ABI UK Investigator conferences etc. They encourage all organisations to voluntarily sign up to a UK GDPR Code of Conduct in their sector, but responsibility for the primary promotion of UK GDPR codes following publication is usually undertaken by the Code owner.

Streaming: Regulation

John Slinger: **[31013]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, whether her department is considering measures to require music streaming services such as Spotify and music video services such as YouTube to provide transparency information on how recommendation algorithms work, in the context of US media indexing in other English speaking markets.

Ian Murray:
The Government is committed to ensuring the UK music sector remains globally competitive and resilient against international market pressures. My department regularly engages with major streaming and video platforms, including Spotify and YouTube, to monitor market trends. While there are currently no plans to introduce algorithmic transparency requirements, we keep digital music markets under continuous review to support a fair and thriving environment for UK creators.

John Slinger: **[32222]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, whether her department has considered legislating or amending the Online Safety Act (Section 162)

so that Ofcom could require music streaming services and music video services to provide to independent researchers with information about how their algorithms select music for users and to assess whether it provides a level playing field.

Ian Murray:
DCMS has no current plans to amend Section 162 of the Online Safety Act (OSA). DCMS has committed to consult to establish the framework for researchers to access data held by digital platforms under section 154A. The Act sets out that the data be for the purposes of 'independent research into online safety matters', which is defined as anything relating to Ofcom's online safety functions. This does not include algorithms to select music for users.

Telecommunications: Supported Housing

James MacCleary: [35189]

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, what assessment her department has made of the potential impact of homecare telecommunications in the event of a power cut.

Ian Murray:
The Government is committed to ensuring that any risks from the industry-led migration from the Public Switched Telephone Network (PSTN) to Voice over Internet Protocol (VoIP) are mitigated for everyone. Over 95% of customers have already been migrated.

In November 2024 and March 2026, the Government secured additional safeguards from the telecoms industry. These include the provision of free battery back-ups for vulnerable customers, including telecare users, to ensure access to emergency services for at least one hour in a power outage. Many communication providers have gone further, providing battery back-ups with 4-7 hours of battery life.

Telemedicine: Voice over Internet Protocol

Imogen Walker: [35206]

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, what steps she is taking to help protect residents in Hamilton and Clyde Valley constituency who rely on telecare devices during the digital landline switchover.

Ian Murray:
The Government is committed to ensuring that any risks from the industry-led migration from the Public Switched Telephone Network (PSTN) to Voice over Internet Protocol (VoIP) are mitigated for everyone. Over 95% of customers have already been migrated.

In November 2024 and March 2026, the industry agreed safeguards with Government to protect consumers, in particular vulnerable people and telecare users, during the PSTN migration to modern digital networks. These include providing vulnerable, including telecare, customers with the offer of a free engineer visit as well as a battery back-up solution for use in the event of a power outage.

Young Futures Hubs: Walsall

Wendy Morton: [35330]

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, with reference to the Young Futures Hubs expansion announced on 15 September 2026, whether Walsall Council was invited to submit an expression of interest; whether an expression of interest was received; and whether the Department will publish its assessment of Walsall during the selection process.

Vicky Foxcroft:
Walsall Council was not shortlisted to submit an Expression of Interest (EOI) to the Young Futures Hubs and Transformation Programme on this occasion, however they may be eligible for future funding from the Youth Matters: Your National Youth Strategy commitments.

The methodology used to shortlist Local Authorities used a combination of indicators relating to crime, deprivation and community need and mental health. This targeted the programme's core goals: improving mental health and wellbeing, increasing opportunities, and reducing vulnerability to crime. The top 50 ranked local authorities were invited to submit an EOI to the Young Futures Hubs and Transformation programme.

Further information on the eligibility criteria, methodology and Expression of Interest process has been published on GOV.UK.

While Walsall was not eligible for this targeted funding, the wider Young Futures programme has been committed to sharing the learnings from the programme to support all LAs to improve the youth services.

Young People: Disadvantaged

Anna Sabine: [33143]

To ask the Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport, what steps her Department is taking to support collaboration between youth services, employers, skills providers and local authorities to help improve outcomes for young people at risk of becoming not in education, employment or training.

Vicky Foxcroft:
Youth Matters outlines an ambitious plan to support young people to learn and get into good jobs, and is backed by over £500 million of funding from DCMS for fun things to do outside of school, support when and where young people need it, more safe spaces and access to trusted adults. This investment in youth services will help young people develop soft skills such as peer connections, relationships, personal development and increase their confidence, and can help young people access the right opportunities for them.

We have committed to launch 50 Young Futures Hubs by the end of this Parliament, bringing mental health and wellbeing support, careers guidance and positive activities into one place to prevent young people from becoming NEET (not in employment,

education or training). We have worked closely with the Department for Work and Pensions to develop this programme and link to Youth Hubs services where appropriate, and this complements the broader Youth Guarantee to give every young person the chance to earn or learn.

£10 million also will be invested to expand the access young people have to trusted adults and help young people build the confidence, skills and experience to be ready for work, delivered in partnership with the King's Trust (subject to a business case), and our Enrichment Expansion Programme will support up to 400 schools to provide a youth-voice led, tailored enrichment offer supporting their development and essential life skills. We will also provide support for the training and employment of 1000 new youth workers to help reduce the risk of unemployment.

EDUCATION

Breakfast Clubs

Dan Norris: [35929]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what provisions are in place to help ensure children who arrive by bus at school are able to arrive in time to benefit from free breakfast club provision.

Paul Waugh:
This government is committed to delivering a free breakfast club in every state-funded school with primary-aged pupils, including special schools and alternative provision. Over 2,700 schools are now delivering clubs, reaching around 680,000 children.

Schools and local authorities are working together to help pupils using home-to-school transport access free breakfast clubs.

Where transport timings prevent a pupil from attending, schools are encouraged to work with their local authority to find out if it is possible to adjust timings or find a suitable alternative arrangement.

Expert advisers are available to help schools build on existing childcare provision and use programme flexibilities so that pupils and families do not miss out.

Childminding: Regulation

Dan Norris: [35170]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what assessment her Department has made of the potential impact of current Ofsted inspection requirements and regulation on the retention of childminders offering mixed age care.

Dan Norris: [35173]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what steps her Department is taking to ensure that regulatory and inspection frameworks for early years settings do not disincentivise childminders from offering care to children of mixed ages within the setting.

Dan Norris: [35175]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what assessment her Department has made of the potential impact of reduced availability of mixed age childminding provision on parents with more than one child.

Paul Waugh:
Childminders are an essential part of the early education and childcare system, providing flexible, high-quality and affordable provision. The department is working with the sector to expand the number of childminders and make it easier to operate, including through increased funding rates and flexibilities to work, with more time working from non-domestic premises.

The department recognises concerns raised by the sector regarding wellbeing and we know there is still more to be done. We know that children thrive when they are cared for by confident, well-trained educators. This means attracting, training and keeping great staff, as well as making sure they are valued and supported throughout their careers, with more support from day one. The department has also introduced measures intended to support the childminding sector and increase childcare availability, including regulatory flexibilities and other reforms aimed at making childminding more attractive and sustainable.

Childminders can provide care for children over five years old, requiring registration on the General Childcare Register (GCR). For providers who are solely registered on the GCR, Ofsted inspections are a compliance check to make sure providers are meeting the ongoing requirements for registration. These inspections are unlike other Ofsted inspections, which focus on quality and standards of provision. Inspectors check at inspection that a provider complies with the requirements of registration.

The department sets the standards and statutory requirements that all early years providers in England must meet. Ofsted is an independent non-ministerial government department and holds responsibility for inspection and operational impact as the regulator for early years provision.

Children in Care and Care Leavers: Supported Housing

Rebecca Smith: [35906]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, if she will publish the number of 16 and 17-year-old looked-after children and care leavers (a) awaiting suitable supported accommodation, (b) in temporary accommodation while waiting for supported accommodation, (c) placed outside their home authority because no suitable local placement was available and (d) living in accommodation assessed as unsuitable for each local authority.

Josh MacAlister:
The available information relates to 17 and 18-year-old care leavers and whether their accommodation is deemed suitable or unsuitable by local authority. This is published in the annual statistical release which can be found at: https://explore-education-statistics.service.gov.uk/find-statistics/children-looked-after-in-england-including-adoptions/2025.

The latest information relating to the reporting year ending 31 March 2025 can be found at: https://explore-education-statistics.service.gov.uk/data-tables/permalink/a794424e-8e83-46a0-4c69-08df251b5373.

The department does not hold information centrally on the number of looked after children and care leavers (a) awaiting suitable supported accommodation, (b) in temporary accommodation whilst waiting for supported accommodation or (c) placed outside their home authority because no suitable local placements were available.

Children in Care: Free School Meals

Mrs Sharon Hodgson: **[35849]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what assessment she has made of the impact of the ending of transitional protections for free school meals on 31 August 2026 on looked-after children.

Paul Waugh:
The department has significantly expanded access to free school meals (FSM), introducing new eligibility criteria applying to all children in households receiving Universal Credit, which took effect from the start of this school year. This means that half a million more children will be able to receive free and nutritious lunchtime meals each day, after accounting for the ending of transitional protections. This approach ensures support is targeted at children in the lowest-income households, including looked after children.

The department has considered the impact of ending transitional protections as part of its reforms to FSM. However, it is not possible to identify looked after children who were previously receiving FSM but are no longer eligible following the end of transitional protections.

Children in Care: Supported Housing

Rebecca Smith: **[35902]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, how many supported accommodation registration applications are currently awaiting allocation to an Ofsted inspector, and how many are allocated but awaiting determination.

Rebecca Smith: **[35903]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, how many outstanding supported accommodation registration applications have been awaiting determination for (a) fewer

than six months, (b) six to 12 months and (c) more than 12 months; and what the median and longest waiting times are.

Rebecca Smith: [35905]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, if she will publish the number of (a) outstanding applications proposing premises for supported accommodation, (b) existing accommodation places available for supported accommodation and (c) applications for supported accommodation outstanding for more than 12 months for each local authority with children's social care responsibilities.

Josh MacAlister:
These are matters for His Majesty's Chief Inspector, Sir Martyn Oliver. I have asked him to write to the hon. Member for South West Devon and a copy of his reply will be placed in the Libraries of both Houses.

Rebecca Smith: [35907]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what interim measures and additional funding are available to local authorities when suitable supported accommodation cannot be secured; and how many young people are being supported through each measure.

Rebecca Smith: [35909]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what estimate her Department has made of the number of supported accommodation places that are ready to open but unavailable because the provider's Ofsted registration remains undetermined.

Rebecca Smith: [35910]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, whether additional staffing and resources have been provided to Ofsted to process supported accommodation applications; and by what date the backlog will be cleared.

Josh MacAlister:
Local authorities are responsible for ensuring they have sufficiency in their area. The government is providing £560 million to refurbish and expand children's home placements. To enable the supported accommodation reforms, £123 million was provided to local authorities between 2023 and 2025. This has been incorporated into the Revenue Support Grant for 2026/27 to support local authorities in meeting their statutory duties, which includes supported accommodation.

No specific funding is given to local authorities where Supported Accommodation cannot be secured. As of 31 March 2026, there were 370 ongoing applications from supported accommodation providers, down from 616 in 2025. While registered providers have capacity for a total of 24,700 places, only 7,520 looked after children live in supported accommodation.

The department does not hold information regarding the number of placements ready to be offered by providers who are awaiting registration. While Ofsted has introduced a prioritisation policy for new children's home applications, no such policy currently applies to supported accommodation, although this remains under review.

Programme funding from the department has enabled Ofsted to continue its registration and inspection activities to support compliance with regulatory requirements. It can take several months for Ofsted to process and come to a decision on an application, with timescales sometimes affected by factors outside of Ofsted's control, such as incomplete applications.

Children: ICT

Adam Dance: **[35719]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what steps she is taking to ensure guidance for parents and carers on under-5s screen use reaches parents and carers in Yeovil constituency.

Paul Waugh:
The England-wide Best Start in Life campaign is actively raising awareness of the under-5s screen-time guidance and driving parents and carers to practical advice to help families develop healthy screen habits. Paid advertising as part of the national campaign, including social media and search activity, signposts families directly to the guidance, including those in Yeovil. This activity has driven significant engagement with the guidance. Between 27 March and 7 April, the guidance was the most-viewed page on the Best Start in Life website and is currently (as of 20 October) the third most viewed page. A range of supportive, practical communications materials are also available, including downloadable resources, such as an infographic, digital screens and social media assets, which trusted partners and local services can use to promote the guidance through their own channels and networks. Best Start Family Hubs are also being equipped with dedicated resources to support sessions and direct conversations with parents and carers in their communities. The CBeebies Parenting Hub provides a further trusted route to reach families, signposting parents to Best Start in Life guidance alongside complementary BBC screen-time advice and resources.

Educational Visits: Fees and Charges

Mike Wood: **[35179]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what is the policy of the Government on institutions charging higher prices for children from independent schools than for state schools for school visits.

Paul Waugh:
Pricing decisions are for individual organisations. The department encourages individual organisations to consider how their arrangements support fair and inclusive access for children.

Engineering: Apprentices and Vocational Education

Wendy Morton: [35313]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what steps her Department is taking to strengthen engagement between schools, colleges, universities and engineering businesses of all sizes in the West Midlands to improve awareness of technical education and apprenticeship opportunities.

Josh MacAlister:
The government is committed to ensuring that young people understand the full range of apprenticeship and technical education (ATE) opportunities available, working with employers to strengthen engagement and develop the skills businesses need.

The Careers & Enterprise Company's (CEC) national network of 44 Career Hubs bring together schools, colleges and employers, using local data and insight to identify barriers to young people progressing into ATE pathways and target support locally.

In the West Midlands, through the Boosting Skills Pathways Fund, Career Hubs are working with local employers in priority sectors, including engineering and advanced manufacturing, alongside schools, colleges and training providers, to develop employer-led outreach and increase young people's awareness and uptake of ATE opportunities, including work experience.

Through its Employer Standards, the CEC also encourages employers of all sizes to work with local schools and colleges so young people have information about careers pathways before key transition points.

Erasmus+ Programme

Mike Wood: [35582]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, pursuant to the answer of 7 September 2026, to Question 20870, on Erasmus+ Programme, whether the counting and definition of 100,000 participants from UK beneficiary organisations will include EU students studying at a UK-based educational institution in receipt of a grant agreement.

Josh MacAlister:
The estimation of 100,000 participants includes all eligible students studying at a UK beneficiary organisation. Participant eligibility is set out on page 55 of the Erasmus+ Programme Guide, available at: https://erasmus-plus.ec.europa.eu/sites/default/files/2025-11/programme-guide-2026_en.pdf.

GCSE: Vocational Education

Dr Simon Opher: [34806]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what steps her Department is taking to ensure that electively home-educated children will be able to access the proposed

Vocational GCSEs as private candidates, including any practical, controlled or non-exam assessment required as part of those qualifications.

Georgia Gould:
As with existing GCSEs and other formal qualifications, electively home-educated children seeking to take a vocational GCSE as a private candidate would be expected to enter through an approved examination centre.

Any practical, controlled or non-exam assessment forming part of the qualification would need to be completed through that same centre.

Logistics: Vocational Guidance

Mr Paul Foster: [35199]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what steps her Department is taking to promote careers in the logistics sector in (a) schools and (b) further education colleges.

Josh MacAlister:
The government wants every young person to understand their career opportunities. Statutory careers guidance expects schools and further education colleges to draw on labour market information and provide employer encounters and workplace experiences, supporting informed choices.

Careers hubs connect schools and colleges with employers and sector bodies. All 11 secondary schools in South Ribble are part of the Lancashire Careers Hub. Penwortham Priory Academy has worked with Leyland Trucks, helping pupils on an engineering pathway understand careers in the sector. Penwortham Girls' High School has undertaken modern work experience with Eddie Stobart.

Learning from the Logistics Beacon, developed by Leicester and Leicestershire Careers Hub and Generation Logistics, is available to other areas nationally through curriculum related resources for key stages 3 to 5. The model demonstrates how careers hubs can work with employers to respond to local priority sectors.

Together, this activity supports progression into technical education, apprenticeships and skilled employment.

Members: Correspondence

Andrew Griffith: [35767]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, when she plans to respond to the letters of 3 July and 30 July.

Georgia Gould:
I can confirm that a response to the correspondence of 3 and 30 July 2026 from the hon. Member for Arundel and South Downs was sent on 20 October 2026.

Schools: Admissions

Preet Kaur Gill: [34750]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what assessment she has made of the potential impact of the movements of families housed in temporary accommodation during 2024 and 2025 on schools' numbers and transience in schools' populations.

Josh MacAlister:
The department does not specifically collect data on how the movements of families housed in temporary accommodation affect pupil numbers. However, it collects pupil forecasts from local authorities through the school capacity survey. These forecasts draw on local knowledge of birth rates, housing developments and migration, and are published on GOV.UK at: https://explore-education-statistics.service.gov.uk/find-statistics/school-capacity/2024-25.

Local authorities have a statutory duty to secure sufficient school places. The department monitors the pupil forecast and school capacity data they submit and regularly engages with them to review plans for creating additional places where needed.

The department also provides capital funding through the basic need grant to support local authorities to provide mainstream school places, based on the data. We have announced over £2.5 billion to support the creation of places needed between May 2024 and September 2028, including over £103 million for Birmingham City Council. Basic need allocations are published on GOV.UK at: https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/basic-need-allocations.

Schools: Hydrocortisone

Jonathan Davies: [34860]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what assessment she has made of the potential merits of updating departmental guidance for schools to mandate emergency hydrocortisone IM injection training in schools for pupils with Congenital Adrenal Hyperplasia.

Georgia Gould:
Schools, colleges and early years providers have responsibilities to keep children and young people safe and to ensure that those with disabilities, which may arise from a medical condition, are not discriminated against by provisions, practice or criteria.

Schools are not responsible for clinical healthcare tasks. Healthcare professionals are responsible for determining whether it is safe and appropriate for a healthcare task to be delivered by staff in schools and other education settings, and what training and competency assessment may be required.

The department works closely with the Department for Health and Social Care to produce guidance on clinical healthcare in schools.

Skilled Workers: Manufacturing Industries

David Chadwick: [33879]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what steps the Department is taking to address skills shortages in the manufacturing sector.

Josh MacAlister:
The government is addressing skills shortages in manufacturing through reforms to technical education, apprenticeships and higher technical skills training. We are strengthening pathways into manufacturing careers through T Levels, Higher Technical Qualifications (HTQs), the Lifelong Learning Entitlement and apprenticeships, helping people gain the skills employers need.

Engineering and Manufacturing T Levels support young people to progress into skilled employment, higher technical education and apprenticeships, while recent changes to industry placements provide greater flexibility for employers to participate.

We are transforming the apprenticeships levy into a new Growth and Skills Levy in England to give employers greater flexibility to invest in workforce training. In addition, we have announced a £182 million Engineering Skills Package to support skills development in priority sectors, including manufacturing, which includes 4 Technical Excellence Colleges specialising in advanced manufacturing. We continue to work with Skills England, providers and employers to ensure training provision meets evolving sector needs.

Social Workers: Conduct

Zöe Franklin: [35015]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, whether she will introduce statutory time limits for fitness-to-practise and cause-for-concern investigations by Social Work England.

Josh MacAlister:
The government does not currently propose statutory time limits for individual cases, as its immediate priority is ensuring Social Work England delivers sustained improvements to the timeliness and effectiveness of the process.

The department recognises the importance of resolving fitness to practise cases promptly, both to protect the public and provide timely outcomes for social workers. Social Work England is the independent regulator responsible for operating fitness to practise processes.

The Independent Review of Social Work Professional Regulation identified fitness to practise as a priority for improvement. In response, the government has asked Social Work England to deliver a comprehensive, end-to-end strategic improvement plan, including revised forecasts and timeliness performance measures. The department is strengthening its oversight and monitoring progress closely.

Zöe Franklin: [35016]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what steps her Department is taking in response to the recommendations of the Dame Annie Hudson review of social work professional regulation to reduce delays in the handling of fitness-to-practise and cause-for-concern cases by Social Work England; and what target timeframe has been set for the resolution of such cases.

Josh MacAlister:
The Independent Review of Social Work Professional Regulation, led by Dame Annie Hudson, identified the need for sustained improvement in Social Work England's fitness to practise function. The government accepted the review's recommendations and has made improving timeliness and effectiveness a key priority.

Social Work England is expected to produce a robust, externally supported, end-to-end Fitness to Practise Strategic Improvement Plan, with clear milestones and performance measures to drive sustained improvement and address the issues identified by the review.

The department has strengthened its oversight of Social Work England's performance and is closely monitoring progress. Should sufficient and sustained improvement not be demonstrated, the government will consider what further action may be appropriate.

Special Educational Needs: Transport

Tom Gordon: [35309]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, whether she plans to commit to making transport provision for 16 to 19-year-old students with special educational needs and disabilities a statutory duty.

Tom Gordon: [35360]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what assessment her Department has made of variations between local authorities in the eligibility criteria and level of transport support available to 16 to 19-year-olds with SEND.

Tom Gordon: [35362]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what assessment her Department has made of the potential impact of post-16 transport provision on participation in education and training among young people with special educational needs and disabilities.

Tom Gordon: [35363]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what assessment her Department has made of the financial impact on families of disabled young people when the costs of post-16 transport are not met by local authorities, including the impact on parental employment.

Tom Gordon: [35365]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what data her Department holds on the number and proportion of students with special educational needs and disabilities who receive 16 to 19 Bursary Fund support towards transport costs.

Tom Gordon: [35375]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what progress the Government has made in addressing the Public Accounts Committee's concerns about the "cliff edge" in transport provision for young people with special educational needs and disabilities when they move into post-16 education.

Paul Waugh:
The department recognises that transport can enable young people with special educational needs and disabilities (SEND) to participate in education and training, and that transport arrangements and costs vary between local areas. Local authorities are not under a general duty to provide free post-16 transport. However, they must make arrangements they consider necessary to facilitate attendance and publish these in annual transport policy statements.

The government does not plan to introduce a universal statutory entitlement. Instead, we are considering targeted options to improve awareness of available support, promote independent travel and improve access where transport is a barrier. This work responds to concerns such as the Public Accounts Committee's findings about the post-16 "cliff edge", as well as the effects of transport provision on participation, families and affordability.

The 16 to 19 bursary fund may be used to meet essential participation costs, including travel, with institutions assessing individual need. The department does not hold data identifying the number or proportion of students with SEND whose bursary awards are used specifically for transport costs.

Student Loans Company: Contracts

Euan Stainbank: [33714]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, if she will publish all direct awards provided by the Student Loans Company under s41 of the Procurement Act 2023.

Josh MacAlister:
All direct awards are routinely published on Contracts Finder, available at: https://www.gov.uk/contracts-finder and the Find a Tender Service, available at: https://www.find-tender.service.gov.uk/Search.

Euan Stainbank: [33715]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, whether Capgemini have been contracted to support the development of the Student Loans Company Target Operating Model.

Josh MacAlister:
Capgemini have been contracted to support the Student Loan Company's (SLC) in the development of their new Target Operating Model, developing a number of design options to underpin SLC's organisation-wide transformation programme, Enable. A competitive procurement was carried out via Crown Commercial Services (now GCA) Management Consultancy Framework (MCF3) – Lot 3.

SLC received 15 Expressions of Interest, 7 suppliers submitted an Ethical Walls statement and 6 bids were received. This award was published on 6 June 2025.

Further information is available at:
https://www.contractsfinder.service.gov.uk/notice/ddbd7657-3f27-40ea-8860-0b7ac30fee1d?origin=SearchResults&p=1.

Students: Grants

Jim Shannon: **[33617]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, if she will take steps to ensure an increased gradual tapering, as household income increases, of the non-repayable maintenance grant, to help support students from families marginally above an income threshold.

Josh MacAlister:
Education is a devolved matter, and the response outlines the information for England only.

The new maintenance grants are a targeted measure designed to provide additional support to eligible students from the lowest-income households without increasing their debt. They will be introduced for new and continuing students studying subjects aligned with the Industrial Strategy and skills needs from the 2028/29 academic year.

Like other means-tested elements of the student finance system, eligibility criteria are required to ensure support is targeted effectively. Students with household incomes at or below the minimum means-testing threshold of £25,000 will receive the highest level of support, with grant entitlement tapering as household income increases towards the upper threshold at £30,000. Students with household incomes above this level will not be eligible for a maintenance grant.

Students at all levels of household income will continue to benefit from the government's commitment to increase maintenance loans every year in line with forecast inflation.

Students: Loans

Abtisam Mohamed: **[33809]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what assessment she has made of the impact on students and graduates of using the Retail Prices Index (RPI) in student finance calculations; and whether she will consider adopting the Consumer Prices Index (CPI), which is generally lower than RPI, to better reflect inflation pressures faced by students.

Josh MacAlister:
Decisions on student loan repayment arrangements must be considered alongside wider fiscal priorities, the long-term sustainability of the higher education (HE) funding system and value for money for taxpayers. The department has already taken decisive action against inflationary pressures by capping the maximum interest rates on Plan 2 and Plan 3 loans at 6% for the 2026/27 academic year, protecting borrowers from inflation shocks.

The Office for National Statistics has confirmed that it will bring the methods and data sources used to calculate the Consumer Prices Index, including owner occupiers' housing costs, into the Retail Prices Index from February 2030. The government will continue to consider the appropriate treatment of inflation measures within the student finance system as part of its ongoing consideration of HE funding and student support arrangements.

Ruth Cadbury: [34805]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, whether her department has any plans to A.) cancel B.) pause the accumulation of interest on student loan debts when an individual is unable to work due to ill health.

Josh MacAlister:
As repayments are income-contingent, borrowers earning below the relevant repayment threshold make no repayments. For borrowers with undergraduate loans who earn no income, interest accrues at Retail Price Index, so the balance does not increase in real terms.

Student loans may also be cancelled where a borrower is permanently unfit for work because of a disability and meets the relevant eligibility and evidence requirements. At the end of the loan term, any outstanding debt, including interest accrued, is written off. The government continues to look for opportunities to improve the student finance system as part of its ongoing consideration of higher education funding.

Vocational Education: Specific Learning Difficulties

Adam Dance: [24302]

To ask the Secretary of State for Education, what assessment she has made of the potential merits of (a) collecting and (b) publishing data on outcomes for students with Specific Learning Disabilities taking level 3 qualifications.

Josh MacAlister:
The department currently collects and publishes data on the attainment, participation and progression of learners with special educational needs and disabilities (SEND), including qualification achievement, progression to level 2 and level 3, further education participation, destinations into education, employment and apprenticeships, as well as not in employment, education or training and longer-term outcomes. Statistics identify the number of learners with education, health and care plans, special educational needs (SEN) support and those with no identified SEN.

Collecting data on outcomes for students with SEND helps the department to understand their experiences, identify attainment gaps, target support more effectively, and evaluate whether policies and interventions are working.

Publishing this data adds transparency and accountability, supports research and helps encourage improvement across the sector.

ENERGY SECURITY AND NET ZERO

Bus Services: Fares

Greg Smith: [35531]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, pursuant to the Answer of 14 October 2026 to Question 30018 on Bus Services: Fares, which (a) programmes and (b) budgets within her Department will be reprioritised to fund the £454 million allocated to reducing bus fares, including funding for the devolved administrations; and how much funding will be reallocated from each.

Michael Shanks:
Savings are a small part of DESNZ's overall budget, which saw a significant uplift at Spending Review. We will set out further detail this autumn.

Carbon Capture and Storage

Matthew Patrick: [36178]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, on what criteria a decision is made about approving a Development Consent Order (DCO) for privately developed carbon capture projects.

Martin McCluskey:
The criteria for DCO decisions for all carbon capture projects are set out in the Energy National Policy Statements (EN-1: Energy, and EN-2: Natural Gas Electricity Generating Infrastructure). EN-1 establishes an urgent need for carbon capture and storage infrastructure as part of the energy mix and provides specific policy for the assessment of DCO applications.

EN-2 sets out the assessment provisions that are applied to any gas fired power station with carbon capture. A project must demonstrate technically feasible plans for the carbon capture plant and assess its environmental effects, including the arrangements for the transport and storage of the captured carbon.

Carbon Dioxide: Pipelines

Matthew Patrick: [36176]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, whether her Department provides guidance on the minimum safe separation distances between carbon dioxide pipelines and residential areas.

Martin McCluskey:
DESNZ does not prescribe a single minimum safe separation distance between carbon dioxide pipelines and residential areas. The safety of CO_2 pipelines is considered through the relevant regulatory and planning frameworks, taking account of the circumstances and risks associated with individual projects.

The Health and Safety Executive (HSE) is the national regulator for workplace health and safety and regulates the health and safety aspects of CCUS operations within its remit, including CO_2 pipelines.

DESNZ and HSE are also involved in the joint industry Project Skylark, which is examining the safe operation of CO_2 pipelines and contributing to the evidence base for future regulatory and operational decision-making.

Carbon Emissions: Housing

Sarah Dyke: [35852]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, whether she would consider the potential merits of providing a proportion of the resources being made available under the Warm Homes Plan to fund research into addressing the challenges for individuals in rural communities to decarbonise their homes.

Martin McCluskey:
Through the Warm Homes Plan, we will put communities at the centre of delivery, devolving funding so regional and local government can accelerate home and building upgrades according to their needs.

The Government does recognise the particular challenges for rural areas and is currently undertaking specific research to improve understanding of the costs and practicalities of decarbonising more complex housing archetypes. Results will be available soon and will help inform future policy decisions.

In the meantime, the Government is already taking action, recently increasing the grant amount available for heat pump installations through the Boiler Upgrade Scheme to £9,000 for homes heated by oil or LPG.

Real-world trials have shown that heat pumps work well across different property types. This is reflected in strong uptake in rural areas, with 50% of BUS grants awarded to rural properties and 39% to homes off the gas grid.

Energy Bills Rebate

Charlie Maynard: [34636]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, whether the financial resources of an unrelated co-tenant has any bearing on a vulnerable individual's entitlement to energy bill assistance.

Ms Polly Billington:
The Warm Home Discount provides eligible low-income households with a £150 rebate on their electricity bill. In England and Wales, eligible households must receive

Pension Credit, Universal Credit, Housing Benefit or income-related Employment and Support Allowance and they (or their partner) must be named on the electricity account. The financial resources of an unrelated co-tenant are not taken into account. Eligibility rules for other Government support schemes may differ from those for the Warm Home Discount, and entitlement is determined in accordance with the specific criteria established for each scheme.

Energy Company Obligation

Ian Lavery: [34858]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, whether eligibility under the health route of the Electricity and Gas (Energy Company Obligation) Order 2022 is intended to provide support for medically vulnerable households that do not meet the standard benefits criteria.

Martin McCluskey:
ECO4 Flex Route 3 supports medically vulnerable households not meeting standard benefits criteria, but does not disapply the property requirements. Article 19(1)(e) cross-refers to articles 13 and 14 while omitting only their household-eligibility requirement. Accordingly, owner-occupied homes must have a pre-project SAP band D to G and private-rented homes E to G. Band C homes are outside the scheme. This targets finite support at the least energy-efficient homes, where improvements can deliver the greatest heating-cost reductions and benefits. Equality impacts were considered in accordance with the Public Sector Equality Duty when ECO4 was designed. Eligibility for the scheme, which closes on 31 December 2026, does not guarantee installation of measures.

Ian Lavery: [34859]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what assessment her Department has made of the potential impact of excluding homes with an EPC rating of C from ECO4 Flex support where the household otherwise satisfies the Article 19 health route on disabled and medically vulnerable households.

Martin McCluskey:
ECO4 Flex Route 3 supports medically vulnerable households not meeting standard benefits criteria, but does not disapply the property requirements. Article 19(1)(e) cross-refers to articles 13 and 14 while omitting only their household-eligibility requirement. Accordingly, owner-occupied homes must have a pre-project SAP band D to G and private-rented homes E to G. Band C homes are outside the scheme. This targets finite support at the least energy-efficient homes, where improvements can deliver the greatest heating-cost reductions and benefits. Equality impacts were considered in accordance with the Public Sector Equality Duty when ECO4 was designed. Eligibility for the scheme, which closes on 31 December 2026, does not guarantee installation of measures.

Ian Lavery: [34861]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, whether her Department has undertaken an Equality Act assessment of the effect of ECO4 Flex eligibility criteria on households containing disabled persons whose health is adversely affected by living in a cold home.

Martin McCluskey:
ECO4 Flex Route 3 supports medically vulnerable households not meeting standard benefits criteria, but does not disapply the property requirements. Article 19(1)(e) cross-refers to articles 13 and 14 while omitting only their household-eligibility requirement. Accordingly, owner-occupied homes must have a pre-project SAP band D to G and private-rented homes E to G. Band C homes are outside the scheme. This targets finite support at the least energy-efficient homes, where improvements can deliver the greatest heating-cost reductions and benefits. Equality impacts were considered in accordance with the Public Sector Equality Duty when ECO4 was designed. Eligibility for the scheme, which closes on 31 December 2026, does not guarantee installation of measures.

Ian Lavery: [34864]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what evidence was used to determine that households qualifying under the Article 19 health route should remain excluded from ECO4 Flex assistance where the property has an EPC rating of C.

Martin McCluskey:
ECO4 Flex Route 3 supports medically vulnerable households not meeting standard benefits criteria, but does not disapply the property requirements. Article 19(1)(e) cross-refers to articles 13 and 14 while omitting only their household-eligibility requirement. Accordingly, owner-occupied homes must have a pre-project SAP band D to G and private-rented homes E to G. Band C homes are outside the scheme. This targets finite support at the least energy-efficient homes, where improvements can deliver the greatest heating-cost reductions and benefits. Equality impacts were considered in accordance with the Public Sector Equality Duty when ECO4 was designed. Eligibility for the scheme, which closes on 31 December 2026, does not guarantee installation of measures.

Ian Lavery: [34865]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, if she will review the operation of the EPC eligibility criteria within ECO4 Flex where a local authority has accepted a referral under Article 19 on the basis of a medically certified health condition.

Martin McCluskey:
ECO4 Flex Route 3 supports medically vulnerable households not meeting standard benefits criteria, but does not disapply the property requirements. Article 19(1)(e) cross-refers to articles 13 and 14 while omitting only their household-eligibility requirement. Accordingly, owner-occupied homes must have a pre-project SAP band D to G and private-rented homes E to G. Band C homes are outside the scheme.

This targets finite support at the least energy-efficient homes, where improvements can deliver the greatest heating-cost reductions and benefits. Equality impacts were considered in accordance with the Public Sector Equality Duty when ECO4 was designed. Eligibility for the scheme, which closes on 31 December 2026, does not guarantee installation of measures.

Ian Lavery: [34869]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what is her policy on whether, under the Article 19 health route, households containing a person whose health is worsened by a cold home should be excluded because the property has an EPC rating of C.

Martin McCluskey:
ECO4 Flex Route 3 supports medically vulnerable households not meeting standard benefits criteria, but does not disapply the property requirements. Article 19(1)(e) cross-refers to articles 13 and 14 while omitting only their household-eligibility requirement. Accordingly, owner-occupied homes must have a pre-project SAP band D to G and private-rented homes E to G. Band C homes are outside the scheme. This targets finite support at the least energy-efficient homes, where improvements can deliver the greatest heating-cost reductions and benefits. Equality impacts were considered in accordance with the Public Sector Equality Duty when ECO4 was designed. Eligibility for the scheme, which closes on 31 December 2026, does not guarantee installation of measures.

Energy: Debts

Mr Lee Dillon: [34837]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what progress her Department has made towards implementing the Debt Relief Scheme for eligible energy customers who accrued debt between 1 April 2022 and 31 March 2024.

Ms Polly Billington:
The Government is working with Ofgem, which is considering a range of options to reduce energy debt. It is important that any intervention provides effective and fair support, is deliverable, and does not impose disproportionate costs on other consumers. The Government and Ofgem are therefore undertaking further work to develop the best approach to tackling both the stock of existing energy debt and the flow of new debt.

Energy: Prices

Sarah Dyke: [35851]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what progress her Department is making in developing policies that will offer rural residents who are off the gas grid similar levels of protection from energy price rises to those available to households who are on the gas grid.

Ms Polly Billington:
This Government is determined to ensure that consumers in rural communities who are reliant on heating oil are treated fairly and better protected, including during times of international volatility.

The CMA found that recent increases in heating oil prices were largely driven by higher wholesale costs rather than a lack of competition or excessive profits.

The Government published its formal response to the CMA heating oil report on 13 October, confirming it will take forward proposals to introduce stronger regulations for the first time, and agreeing with the CMA that we will not be replicating the gas and electricity price cap. Instead, we will focus on a programme of reform to strengthening consumer protections.

A Written Ministerial Statement can be found here: Written statements - Written questions, answers and statements - UK Parliament

The full response can be found here: Government response to the CMA heating oil market study - GOV.UK

Fuel Oil

Dr Luke Evans: **[34949]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, with reference to the Government's response to the Competition and Markets Authority's heating oil market study, what her planned timescale is for enacting each of the recommendations of the study.

Ms Polly Billington:
The government has confirmed that it plans to strengthen regulations in the market for the first time, making sure households who use heating oil are treated fairly.

Next steps will include extensive stakeholder engagement. We will work with those recommended by the CMA in their final report, including the Scottish Government and Northern Irish Executive (where heating oil and consumer protection and advocacy is either fully or partially devolved), and relevant regulators including Ofgem and the Utility Regulator.

We'll also work with industry and consumer bodies such as, but not limited to, UKIFDA and the Northern Ireland Oil Federation. This engagement will help build the evidence base needed to develop the right options for stronger regulations.

This will take time, and it's important we get it right, to ensure the best outcomes for consumers.

In the meantime, we will also work across relevant government departments and with industry to strengthen consumer protection measures in the Codes of Conduct, and consider minimum order volumes, access to smaller deliveries and payment plans as well as whether further action is needed to support price transparency. We will look at whether any of the existing rules and guidance on minimum order volumes is unnecessarily restricting consumers' options, and assess the coverage, accessibility

and reliance of existing price transparency provisions. This will determine whether, and what, government intervention is required.

We will set out more detail on the approach to taking forward the recommendations as soon as possible.

Dr Luke Evans: [34950]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, with reference to the Government's response to the Competition and Markets Authority's heating oil market study, what specific steps she will take to build a robust evidence base and ensure the right legislative framework when considering an appropriate regulatory regime for the heating oil market.

Ms Polly Billington:
The government has confirmed that it plans to strengthen regulations in the market for the first time, making sure households who use heating oil are treated fairly.

Next steps will include extensive stakeholder engagement. We will work with those recommended by the CMA in their final report, including the Scottish Government and Northern Irish Executive (where heating oil and consumer protection and advocacy is either fully or partially devolved), and relevant regulators including Ofgem and the Utility Regulator.

We'll also work with industry and consumer bodies such as, but not limited to, UKIFDA and the Northern Ireland Oil Federation. This engagement will help build the evidence base needed to develop the right options for stronger regulations.

This will take time, and it's important we get it right, to ensure the best outcomes for consumers.

In the meantime, we will also work across relevant government departments and with industry to strengthen consumer protection measures in the Codes of Conduct, and consider minimum order volumes, access to smaller deliveries and payment plans as well as whether further action is needed to support price transparency. We will look at whether any of the existing rules and guidance on minimum order volumes is unnecessarily restricting consumers' options, and assess the coverage, accessibility and reliance of existing price transparency provisions. This will determine whether, and what, government intervention is required.

We will set out more detail on the approach to taking forward the recommendations as soon as possible.

Dr Luke Evans: [34951]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, with reference to the Government's response to the Competition and Markets Authority's heating oil market study, what stakeholders she will engage with when considering an appropriate regulatory regime for the heating oil market.

Ms Polly Billington:
The government has confirmed that it plans to strengthen regulations in the market for the first time, making sure households who use heating oil are treated fairly.

Next steps will include extensive stakeholder engagement. We will work with those recommended by the CMA in their final report, including the Scottish Government and Northern Irish Executive (where heating oil and consumer protection and advocacy is either fully or partially devolved), and relevant regulators including Ofgem and the Utility Regulator.

We'll also work with industry and consumer bodies such as, but not limited to, UKIFDA and the Northern Ireland Oil Federation. This engagement will help build the evidence base needed to develop the right options for stronger regulations.

This will take time, and it's important we get it right, to ensure the best outcomes for consumers.

In the meantime, we will also work across relevant government departments and with industry to strengthen consumer protection measures in the Codes of Conduct, and consider minimum order volumes, access to smaller deliveries and payment plans as well as whether further action is needed to support price transparency. We will look at whether any of the existing rules and guidance on minimum order volumes is unnecessarily restricting consumers' options, and assess the coverage, accessibility and reliance of existing price transparency provisions. This will determine whether, and what, government intervention is required.

We will set out more detail on the approach to taking forward the recommendations as soon as possible.

Dr Luke Evans: **[34952]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, with reference to the Government's response to the Competition and Markets Authority's heating oil market study, what the terms of reference are for the Government's commitment to look at the relevant rules and industry guidance in relation to retail price spikes and minimum order volumes.

Ms Polly Billington:
The government has confirmed that it plans to strengthen regulations in the market for the first time, making sure households who use heating oil are treated fairly.

Next steps will include extensive stakeholder engagement. We will work with those recommended by the CMA in their final report, including the Scottish Government and Northern Irish Executive (where heating oil and consumer protection and advocacy is either fully or partially devolved), and relevant regulators including Ofgem and the Utility Regulator.

We'll also work with industry and consumer bodies such as, but not limited to, UKIFDA and the Northern Ireland Oil Federation. This engagement will help build the evidence base needed to develop the right options for stronger regulations.

This will take time, and it’s important we get it right, to ensure the best outcomes for consumers.

In the meantime, we will also work across relevant government departments and with industry to strengthen consumer protection measures in the Codes of Conduct, and consider minimum order volumes, access to smaller deliveries and payment plans as well as whether further action is needed to support price transparency. We will look at whether any of the existing rules and guidance on minimum order volumes is unnecessarily restricting consumers’ options, and assess the coverage, accessibility and reliance of existing price transparency provisions. This will determine whether, and what, government intervention is required.

We will set out more detail on the approach to taking forward the recommendations as soon as possible.

Dr Luke Evans: **[34954]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, with reference to the Government's response to the Competition and Markets Authority's heating oil market study, what the terms of reference are for the Government's further assessment of the current provision of price transparency.

Ms Polly Billington:
The government has confirmed that it plans to strengthen regulations in the market for the first time, making sure households who use heating oil are treated fairly.

Next steps will include extensive stakeholder engagement. We will work with those recommended by the CMA in their final report, including the Scottish Government and Northern Irish Executive (where heating oil and consumer protection and advocacy is either fully or partially devolved), and relevant regulators including Ofgem and the Utility Regulator.

We’ll also work with industry and consumer bodies such as, but not limited to, UKIFDA and the Northern Ireland Oil Federation. This engagement will help build the evidence base needed to develop the right options for stronger regulations.

This will take time, and it’s important we get it right, to ensure the best outcomes for consumers.

In the meantime, we will also work across relevant government departments and with industry to strengthen consumer protection measures in the Codes of Conduct, and consider minimum order volumes, access to smaller deliveries and payment plans as well as whether further action is needed to support price transparency. We will look at whether any of the existing rules and guidance on minimum order volumes is unnecessarily restricting consumers’ options, and assess the coverage, accessibility and reliance of existing price transparency provisions. This will determine whether, and what, government intervention is required.

We will set out more detail on the approach to taking forward the recommendations as soon as possible.

Dr Luke Evans: [34955]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what steps she is taking to ensure off-grid households reliant on heating oil are sufficiently supported and protected ahead of winter 2026-27.

Ms Polly Billington:
The Government recognises the particular challenges faced by households in rural and remote areas that are not connected to the electricity grid. Many of these households rely on heating oil and LPG as their primary source of heating.

This year, the Government announced £53 million of support for low-income households that use any fuel for domestic heating, cooking or lighting, helping to address rising energy costs.

For those considering alternatives to oil heating, the Government is supporting the installation of low-carbon heating through the Boiler Upgrade Scheme, for eligible households in England and Wales. A time-limited higher grant of £9,000 is available for eligible off-gas-grid properties replacing oil or LPG heating systems, helping households and small businesses most exposed to volatile fossil fuel prices to switch to low-carbon heating. The Government is regulating the heat oil sector for the first time.

In addition, the Government published its formal response to the CMA heating oil report on 13 October, and plans to strengthen regulations in the market for the first time, making sure households who use heating oil are treated fairly.

Heat Pumps and Motor Vehicles: Carbon Emissions

Dr Scott Arthur: [34946]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, whether her Department has made an assessment of the potential impact of changes to statutory adoption trajectories for zero-emission vehicles and heat pumps on a) future electricity system costs, and b) average household energy bills.

Michael Shanks:
The government is committed to delivering the transition to zero emission vehicles and low carbon heating in a way that supports an efficient electricity system and is affordable for consumers and businesses. As part of wider analysis of the future electricity system and consumer bills, the Department assesses the implications of electrification, including any changes in projected demand from electric vehicles and heat pumps. This analysis considers infrastructure requirements, the potential for flexible technologies and interactions across the wider energy system, and informs both policy development and electricity system planning. The government will keep this under review as policies develop.

Heat Pumps: Housing

Josh Newbury: [34727]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what estimate her Department has made of the proportion of off-grid homes which are suitable for a hydronic heat pump.

Martin McCluskey:
A home's suitability for a heat pump depends on several factors such as sufficient internal and external space, peak current draw of the grid connection, and the home's peak heat loss.

Evidence suggests the vast majority of GB homes have sufficient insulation and electricity connections to install a heat pump, considering developments like heat pumps operating with higher flow temperatures enabling installation in less well insulated homes.

We have commissioned research on understanding different approaches to decarbonising complex housing archetypes, including alternative low carbon heating solutions, and expect it to be published in due course.

Heating: Housing

Josh Newbury: [34728]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what progress her Department has made on decarbonising heating in off-grid homes.

Martin McCluskey:
The Government is making strong progress in supporting off-gas-grid homes to switch to cleaner heating.

In response to the Middle East situation, the Government increased grants available for heat pump installations to up to £9,000 for homes currently heated by oil or LPG.

In total the Boiler Upgrade Scheme has supported over 90,000 installations across England and Wales, with 49% of funding delivered to rural areas and 38% to off-grid areas. The average cost of a heat pump installation has fallen by 11% in real terms since the Scheme launched in 2022.

The Warm Homes: Local Grant is also supporting low-income households living in EPC D-G homes, both on and off the gas grid, with energy performance improvements and low-carbon heating.

Hydrogen: Storage and Transport

Graham Stuart: [35787]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, whether the £500 million for a regional hydrogen transport and storage network announced at the Spending Review remains committed.

Martin McCluskey:
Hydrogen can help reindustrialise Britain by cutting emissions from heavy industry and providing clean power, helping to maintain our manufacturing base, and create new clean energy industries and skilled jobs in our industrial heartlands.

Transport and storage infrastructure can help unlock the full system benefits of hydrogen.

Government is continuing to work at pace to identify transport and storage requirements to inform the scope, scale and timing of government support for transport and storage infrastructure. More detail on funding will be available following the Autumn Budget on October 28 th .

Graham Stuart: **[35789]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what assessment her Department has made of the potential impact of the time taken to confirm hydrogen transport and storage funding on private investment in hydrogen production.

Martin McCluskey:
Hydrogen can help reindustrialise Britain by cutting emissions from heavy industry and providing clean power, helping to maintain our manufacturing base, and create new clean energy industries and skilled jobs in our industrial heartlands.

We understand the importance of providing clarity to businesses across the hydrogen sector and we are regularly engaging with industry to understand their proposals relating to hydrogen infrastructure.

We recognise the importance of maintaining momentum on hydrogen development and are committed to accelerating progress where possible.

Microgeneration: Housing

Mr Andrew Snowden: **[35809]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what assessment her Department has made of the impact of the absence of MCS certification on the sale of residential properties, mortgage lending, conveyancing and insurance decisions where alternative evidence of compliance with relevant safety and regulatory requirements is available.

Michael Shanks:
The Department has not made an assessment of the impact of the absence of MCS certification on the sale of residential properties, mortgage lending, conveyancing and insurance decisions.

MCS certification is required for access to Government grant funding, where applicable, and is not mandated otherwise. It provides assurance that an installation was designed, installed and commissioned to MCS standards by an MCS-certified installer.

Requirements relating to property transactions, lending and insurance will depend on the circumstances of the property and the requirements of the relevant conveyancer, lender or insurer.

Radioactive Waste: North Atlantic Ocean

Peter Lamb: [34714]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what assessment her Department has made of recent scientific research into the condition and environmental impact of radioactive waste barrels dumped in the North-East Atlantic.

Michael Shanks:
The disposal of radioactive waste in the sea was banned globally in 1993. The UK had already ceased disposal at sea voluntarily under the 1972 London Convention.

The first Nuclear Ocean Dump Site Survey and Monitoring (NODSSUM) international mission in 2025 mapped the locations of containers on the seafloor. The expedition found no significant environmental contamination.

The current NODSSUM project focuses on collecting samples of sediment and biota around some of the containers, to determine the levels of radionuclides that might have been released from the low-level radioactive waste to the surrounding marine environment.

The Department has not yet carried out an assessment of current NODSSUM expedition because the analysis of samples is still ongoing by researchers of the project.

Solar Power: Business Premises

Dr Peter Prinsley: [34737]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what steps she is taking to encourage the retrofitting of solar photovoltaic panels on existing commercial and industrial rooftops; what financial incentives are available to businesses to support such installations; and what assessment she has made of the potential merits of increased rooftop solar generation to reduce demand for ground-mounted solar developments on agricultural land.

Michael Shanks:
The Solar Roadmap published last year set out actions for Government and industry, including for commercial solar.

Since 2022 there has been a business rates exemption for plant and machinery used in connection with onsite renewable generation. The exemption applies from until 31 March 2035.

The Annual Investment Allowance is permanently set at £1 million which gives 100% tax relief to businesses on plant and machinery investments.

The Government does not take a prescriptive approach to the proportion of future rooftop and ground-mounted solar. Both forms of deployment will be needed to meet our clean power ambitions.

Solar Power: Housing

Mr Andrew Snowden: [35807]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what routes are available to owners of existing solar photovoltaic systems without MCS certification to obtain independent inspections, maintenance services, accreditation or recognition by suitably qualified and competent installers.

Michael Shanks:
MCS certification is not a prerequisite for consumers to access inspection and maintenance services.

Where chosen, MCS certification provides assurance across the full design, installation and commissioning process. A post-installation inspection alone cannot demonstrate that all applicable requirements were met throughout that process, and MCS therefore does not permit retrospective certification.

Mr Andrew Snowden: [35808]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, whether her Department considers it acceptable that homeowners may be unable to obtain maintenance, upgrades or the installation of battery storage for existing solar photovoltaic systems solely because those systems do not hold MCS certification.

Michael Shanks:
MCS certification is not a prerequisite for consumers to access inspection and maintenance services.

Where chosen, MCS certification provides assurance across the full design, installation and commissioning process. A post-installation inspection alone cannot demonstrate that all applicable requirements were met throughout that process, and MCS therefore does not permit retrospective certification.

The certification of battery storage by MCS does not require a pre-exiting solar PV system to be certified.

Mr Andrew Snowden: [35810]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, whether her Department will consider introducing a post-installation inspection and accreditation scheme for existing solar photovoltaic systems, enabling competent installers to assess and certify installations without automatically assuming liability for work previously undertaken by other installers.

Michael Shanks:
The Department does not plan to introduce a scheme for post-installation inspection and accreditation. MCS certification provides assurance across the full design,

installation and commissioning process. Post-installation inspection alone cannot demonstrate that all applicable requirements were met, and MCS therefore does not permit retrospective certification.

Mr Andrew Snowden: [35811]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what assessment her Department has made of the public interest objectives served by requiring MCS certification for the subsequent inspection, accreditation or market recognition of an existing solar photovoltaic system where that system can demonstrate compliance with applicable electrical safety requirements, Building Regulations and Distribution Network Operator connection requirements.

Michael Shanks:
The Department has not made an assessment of post-installation inspection and accreditation requirements. MCS certification is required for access to Government grant funding, where applicable, and is not mandated otherwise.

MCS certification provides assurance across the full design, installation and commissioning process. Post-installation inspection alone cannot demonstrate that all applicable requirements were met, and MCS therefore does not permit retrospective certification.

Wind Power: Irish Sea

Mr Andrew Snowden: [31757]

To ask the Secretary of State for Energy Security and Net Zero, what statutory compensation schemes the developers of the Morgan and Morecambe windfarm cabling corridor are required to offer residents affected by their construction works; and what voluntary schemes her Department sought during the planning process.

Michael Shanks:
Although both projects were consented together, different requirements apply to each. There is no compensation scheme for the Morgan project. For the Morecambe project compensation is payable for blight and the grant of Compulsory Acquisition and Temporary Possession powers.

The Government recognises that communities housing clean energy infrastructure should benefit from doing so, and is exploring introducing mandatory community benefits for low-carbon technologies. The offshore wind industry has well-established voluntary community benefit schemes for coastal communities. However, community benefits are not legally material to the planning decision and cannot be considered when deciding whether to grant consent for a project.

ENVIRONMENT, FOOD AND RURAL AFFAIRS

Agriculture: Government Assistance

James Cartlidge: [31661]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what financial support is available to farmers affected by increased input costs and adverse weather conditions.

Stephen Morgan:
Defra has committed £173 million in funding for 2026/2027 to improve productivity, trial new technologies and drive innovation in the agricultural sector to improve productivity, trial new technologies and drive innovation in the agricultural sector. This includes up to £70 £123 million available for Farming Innovation Programme (FIP) innovation grants.

In August, the Government announced a package of support for framers affected by adverse weather. This package included temporary adjustments to Environmental Land Management agreements, extra funding for the Sustainable Farming Incentive 2026 Window 2, and action and funding to make it easier to build reservoirs. Further details can be found at our Farming Blog: https://defrafarming.blog.gov.uk/2026/08/15/new-drought-support-for-farmers/.

Agriculture: UK Trade with EU

Kim Leadbeater: [35953]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what recent progress her Department has made on a sanitary and phytosanitary agreement with the European Union.

Stephen Morgan:
Negotiations with the European Union on a sanitary and phytosanitary agreement are at an advanced stage. This Government remains committed to concluding the agreement ahead of the next UK-EU Summit on 20 November.

Aluminium: Prices

Tessa Munt: [35109]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, with reference to her Department's monthly market overview of aluminium prices for local authorities referred to in the debate of 1 September 2026, where that overview is published and on what date publication began.

Emma Hardy:
The Defra funded WRAP (Waste and Resources Action Programme) and MRW (Materials Recycling World) have published a Material Recycling Weekly price report for over fifteen years. This is a weekly publication that users can access free of charge.

Animal Welfare: Licensing

Dan Norris: [35148]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, whether she plans to extend the Animal Welfare (Licensing of Activities Involving Animals) (England) Regulations 2018 to cover pet sitters who care for animals in the owner's home and commercial dog walkers.

Stephen Morgan:
Anyone responsible for an animal, including pet sitters and dog walkers, is required to comply with the Animal Welfare Act. The Act places a duty of care on those responsible for animals and provides authorities with powers to investigate and take action where welfare standards have not been met.

The Canine and Feline Sector Group (CFSG) has published guidance to assist commercial dog walkers in ensuring the welfare of animals in their care.

Biodiversity and Environment Protection

Chris Hinchliff: [35552]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what assessment she has made of the contribution that National Lottery funding has made and will make toward delivery of targets under the Environment Act 2021, the Environmental Improvement Plan, and the Global Biodiversity Framework.

Jenny Riddell-Carpenter:
The Environmental Improvement Plan is a cross-government plan. We will be working with DCMS/National Lottery to capture their contributions.

Birds: Farms

Josh Newbury: [34722]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what steps her Department is taking to promote farming practices which create and preserve habitats for farmland birds.

Stephen Morgan:
Through Environmental Land Management schemes, Defra supports farming practices that provide food and habitats for farmland birds. Sustainable Farming Incentive actions include winter bird food on arable and horticultural land, while Countryside Stewardship Higher Tier supports targeted habitat and species management.

Carbon Capture and Storage: River Dee and Wirral

Matthew Patrick: [36180]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what guidance Natural England and the Environment Agency have issued to privately developed carbon

capture projects such as Peak Clusters on protecting wildlife and designated habitats on the Wirral and Dee Estuary.

Jenny Riddell-Carpenter:
Natural England has provided formal advice through the Environmental Impact Assessment scoping consultation. This identified several matters requiring further consideration, including gaps and inaccuracies in the assessment of designated sites, missing protected species survey data, including for natterjack toads on the Wirral, and the need for a more robust assessment of air quality, landscape and habitat impacts. Natural England also advised on the need for detailed agricultural land classification information.

On Wirral, Natural England has raised concerns regarding the marine ecology assessment, the adequacy of protected species surveys, and potential impacts on protected habitats and bird features.

Natural England will continue to engage with the applicant and provide evidence-based advice as the proposals develop, with the aim of securing appropriate protection for the natural environment.

The Environment Agency published carbon capture guidance and is developing its evidence and regulatory approach to understand and manage potential impacts from carbon capture developments.

Department for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs: Communication

Charlie Dewhirst: [24063]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what was the outturn spending by the department on communications, marketing and advertising in (a) 2024-25 and (b) 2025-26.

Emma Hardy:

	24–25	25–26
Total	£1,759,440	£1,179,377

Department for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs: Equality

Mike Wood: [32432]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, pursuant to the answer of 10 September 2026, to Question 21087, on DEFRA: Equality, and of 9 July 2026, to Question 15238, on Ofwat: Equality, what were the titles of each of the short virtual EDI events that were undertaken by Cultural Calendar Club through Powered by Diversity.

Emma Hardy:
2024

- Your exceptional autistic colleagues
- National infertility awareness week
- Living on the borderline (Borderline Personality Disorder)
- Word Culture Day: Cultural Agility
- Global Day of Parents: Why we need to challenge gender stereotypes from birth
- Women's Health Needs Focus Period
- Pride: The Other Parent
- Managing Dad: Understanding the modern-day father at work
- Gender Equality: Through tackling fatherhood forfeits
- Net Zero Week
- National Grief Awareness Week: Grief/Work Balance
- We smell fear: Negativity bias and how to overcome it
- World Narcolepsy Day: This is narcolepsy
- Black History Month: Unveiling the intersectionality blind spot
- Facial Pain Awareness Month: My life with trigeminal Neuralgia
- Baby Loss Awareness Week: Help break the taboo around baby loss
- World Stroke Day: The day stroke changed my life
- Anti-Bullying Week
- International Day of Disabled Persons: Equality v Equity

2025

- World Religion Day: Religion and LGBT+
- Race Equality Week: Tokenism vs True Representation
- Endometriosis Awareness Month
- International Women's Day
- LGBTQ+ Fostering and Adoption Week
- British Sign Language Masterclass

To be clear, all sessions were online.

Exclusive Economic Zone

Pippa Heylings: **[35001]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what assessment she has made with Cabinet colleagues of the level of the contribution of the UK Exclusive

Economic Zone in Europe on (a) economic growth, (b) energy security, (c) food security and (d) coastal security.

Stephen Morgan:
Government recognises the significant contribution of the UK Exclusive Economic Zone to economic growth, energy security, food security and coastal resilience, supporting key sectors including fisheries, offshore renewables and other marine industries.

The natural capital accounts define the extent of the UK marine area using the UK's Exclusive Economic Zone boundary and estimate that the annual measurable value of natural capital services provided by the UK Marine and coastal margins habitats was approximately £43 billion in 2022, with an estimated asset value of £272 billion.

Further information on the value of marine and coastal margin ecosystem services relating to a) economic value, b) oil, gas and renewable energy provisioning, c) fish provisioning and d) health and tourism recreation can be found in Table 3 of the**Marine and coastal margins natural capital accounts, UK: 2025 (ONS)**

Fires

Paul Davies: [901656]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what steps she is taking with Cabinet colleagues to improve wildfire mitigation.

Jenny Riddell-Carpenter:
Wildfires are already more frequent and more severe because of climate change. The science is clear that wildfire risk will continue to increase, and that we need to act now to increase our resilience.

Tomorrow, the Government will convene a wildfire summit focused on the core components of wildfire mitigation from response to landscape resilience. The summit will bring together the fire and rescue services, and the owners and managers of the landscapes most at risk from wildfire.

Flood Control

Olly Glover: [901653]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what steps she is taking to support the Environment Agency in preventing flooding.

Emma Hardy:
We are investing at least a record £10.5 billion until 2036 – the largest flood programme in history. Our record investment will benefit nearly 900,000 properties.

Additionally, this year we are spending £1.4 billion on over 600 flood schemes, protecting communities in every corner of the country.

Fly-tipping: Private Property

Callum Anderson: [33079]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what assessment she has made of the effectiveness of measures to prevent and prosecute fly-tipping on private land in rural communities.

Emma Hardy:
This Government recognises the significant impact of fly-tipping on private land within rural communities. Through the Waste Crime Action Plan, we are working with partners to strengthen prevention, enforcement and prosecution activity, including exploring affordable insurance options to help landowners meet the costs of waste clearance.

Food Supply

Sean Woodcock: [901651]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what steps she is taking to help improve food security.

Stephen Morgan:
Food security is national security. That is why we are working across Government to make sure food supply is built into our emergency preparedness, and why we have set up the Food Preparedness Group, which brings Government, industry and civil society together to plan for acute and catastrophic risks to our food system.

Dr Sam Rushworth: [901657]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what steps she is taking to help improve access to affordable food.

Stephen Morgan:
This Government is committed to ensuring everyone can access healthy, affordable food. That is why I announced the Good Food Neighbourhoods programme last month. This £10 million fund will support those communities in greatest need, to access healthier, more affordable food – giving people the room to breathe on the cost of living.

Food: Waste

Nesil Caliskan: [36132]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what assessment she has made of the potential merits of a public food waste reporting requirement for large businesses in reducing food prices through increased supply chain efficiency.

Nesil Caliskan: [36133]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, when she plans to respond further to the 2023 consultation on food waste reporting.

Emma Hardy:
The Government recognises the importance of improving food waste data to help reduce food waste and improve resource efficiency. The Department is engaging with industry to improve reporting and data quality, while considering a range of policy options. Potential reporting requirements for larger businesses, including mandatory reporting, remain under consideration.

Forests

Josh Newbury: [35090]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what steps her Department is taking to support the Forestry Commission to achieve its target of improving the semi-natural score of plantation in ancient woodland sites by at least one class by 2044.

Jenny Riddell-Carpenter:
Defra is providing support to expand training, monitoring, and on-the-ground restoration work. Targeted Defra funding of £5.9m for 2026–2029 is accelerating PAWS restoration on the Public Forest Estate, with progress closely monitored and a target to work towards doubling the recent restoration rate.

Josh Newbury: [35298]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what recent assessment her Department has made of the progress the Forestry Commission has made towards achieving its target of improving the semi-natural score of plantation in ancient woodland sites by at least one class by 2044.

Jenny Riddell-Carpenter:
Progress towards the target is assessed annually through Forestry England's semi-natural scoring of plantations on ancient woodland sites (PAWS), which is reported in Forestry England's Natural Capital Accounts. Between April 2024 and April 2026, 337 hectares moved out of semi-natural score 4 and 303 hectares moved into semi-natural score 1, demonstrating progress towards the 2044 target of improving the semi-natural score of PAWS by at least one class.

Hunting: Regulation

Perran Moon: [35407]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what indication she has of the timescale for publishing the Government's response to the consultation on the prohibition of trail hunting in England and Wales; and whether she plans to publish that response before the end of 2026.

Jenny Riddell-Carpenter:
On 18 June, Defra closed its consultation seeking views on how best to deliver an effective and enforceable ban on trail hunting in England and Wales. The consultation received 184,000 responses. Defra plans to publish a summary of responses as soon as possible.

Livestock Worrying

Alex Mayer: [33706]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, how many times Bedfordshire, Cambridgeshire and Hertfordshire police forces have exercised their powers to seize dogs under the Dogs (Protection of Livestock) (Amendment) Act 2025 since those powers came into force, broken down by police force area.

Stephen Morgan:
Defra does not hold central data on how police forces exercise such powers. Under the Dogs (Protection of Livestock) (Amendment) Act 2025, police forces are required to keep a register of all dogs seized under section 2(1), where the dog is suspected of attacking or worrying livestock and no owner or person in charge is present.

National Parks: Hill Farming

Kevin Hollinrake: [31247]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what assessment her Department has made of the potential impact on the viability of upland livestock farms of requiring consent under the Environmental Impact Assessment (Agriculture) (England) (No. 2) Regulations 2006 for reseeding and liming of grassland in National Parks.

Stephen Morgan:
The agricultural EIA regulations are primarily intended to protect uncultivated and semi-natural land, including priority habitats, from agricultural intensification. The performance and impact of the regulations were most recently examined in the 2023 Post Implementation Review where the Ag EIA was found to have met their objectives in part and have had a generally positive effect overall when triggered.

Oilseed Rape: Pollinators

Rupert Lowe: [34225]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what assessment she has made of the reduction in the area of oilseed rape cultivated in England since 2013 on the availability of nectar and pollen resources for pollinators.

Jenny Riddell-Carpenter:
As part of our Environmental Improvement Plan, we will publish a new Pollinator Action Plan, which will set out key actions to support pollinators in England.

Poultry: Animal Welfare

John McDonnell: [36134]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what progress her Department is making on phasing out cages for laying hens.

John McDonnell: [36135]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, when a decision is expected regarding phasing out cages for laying hens, following her department's consultation which closed on the 9th March 2026.

Stephen Morgan:
The Government is currently analysing the responses to the consultation, and a formal response is expected to be published this year.

Public Sector: Climate Change and Temperature

Lillian Jones: [35138]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what steps her Department is taking to ensure that (a) the NHS and (b) other public services are resilient to extreme heat and the impacts of climate change.

Jenny Riddell-Carpenter:
The Government is committed to strengthening the resilience of the NHS and other public services to extreme heat and the wider impacts of climate change. Further details of the action being taken are set out in the Secretary of State's letter to the Environmental Audit Committee of 14 July 2026: committees.parliament.uk/publications/54314/documents/301804/default/ .

Squirrels: Pest Control

Mr Gregory Campbell: [35857]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what funding has been made available to assist with the UK Squirrel Accord supporting research into immunocontraception.

Jenny Riddell-Carpenter:
Defra provides ongoing funding for the laboratory facilities used in the UK Squirrel Accord research. Defra and the Forestry Commission also provide wider support to the UK Squirrel Accord, including funding towards its Director post.

United Utilities: Investment Income

Ian Byrne: [35824]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, whether her department has modelled the potential impact on (a) customer bills and (b) infrastructure investment of retaining within the North West water system sums currently used by United Utilities for shareholder distributions.

Emma Hardy:
I refer the Hon Member to PQ 32257 that was published on 19 th October in response to Tom Hayes MP.

Waste: Crime

Andrew Rosindell: [34456]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, if she has made an assessment of the effectiveness of the Waste Crime Action Plan.

Emma Hardy:
Defra is working with the EA to strengthen monitoring and evaluation of the Government's waste crime measures as they are developed and delivered. This includes improving the waste crime performance scorecard and developing an evaluation method for the Waste Crime Action Plan measures and the Prime Minister's recent crackdown on criminal gangs.

Water Companies

Nadia Whittome: [901655]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what assessment she has made of the potential merits of taking water utilities into public ownership.

Emma Hardy:
The water industry has not worked for people or the environment for far too long. That is why, in our strengthened Water Bill, we will remove the Thatcher-era restrictions on public ownership in water companies.

This Government will keep all options on the table and will ensure clear consequences for water companies who are failing the communities they serve.

Charlie Maynard: [901658]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, if she will commission an independent feasibility study into alternative ownership models for water companies.

Emma Hardy:
The Government is considering a range of options to improve how the water sector serves customers and the environment. We will set out plans for stronger public control and wider sector reform in our 10-year plan later this year.

Water Companies: Inspections

Barry Gardiner: [36065]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, pursuant to the answer of 19 October 2026 to WPQ 34448, what type of sites were inspected for the 6,130 carried out at sites other than wastewater treatment works.

Emma Hardy:
6,130 inspections were carried out at water-company-operated sewage pumping stations and combined sewer overflows. These are permitted wastewater assets within sewerage networks. Inspections assess whether sites comply with

environmental permit conditions and may also follow reported pollution incidents or evidence of environmental impact at an asset or its outfall.

Water Companies: Nationalisation

Ian Byrne: [35822]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, whether her Department has undertaken an assessment of the potential costs and benefits of United Utilities Water Limited being operated under (a) public ownership, (b) not-for-profit ownership and (c) its existing ownership model; and if she will publish any such assessment.

Ian Byrne: [35823]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, whether she has considered the feasibility of establishing a publicly owned regional water corporation to provide water and sewerage services in North West England.

Ian Byrne: [35826]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, whether her department has undertaken an assessment of the fiscal implications of bringing a regional water and sewerage company into public ownership; and what methodology HM Treasury would use to assess the acquisition value of such a company.

Ian Byrne: [35827]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, whether his department has made an assessment of the treatment of existing water company debt under a model in which a water and sewerage undertaking is transferred into public ownership.

Emma Hardy:
I refer the Hon Member to the answer provided on 14 October 2026 to PQ UIN 33485.

Water Supply

Alex Mayer: [35961]

To ask the Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs, what steps her Department is taking to secure public water supplies in areas experiencing drought in winter 2026-27.

Emma Hardy:
The Government works with EA and water companies ensuring they take actions required to secure water supplies, including fixing more leaks quickly, optimising and moving water around their networks and holding them accountable if they delay drought plan actions. National Drought Group meets weekly ensuring coordinated action across affected sectors.

FOREIGN, COMMONWEALTH AND DEVELOPMENT OFFICE

Chinese Embassy

Alicia Kearns: [36248]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, whether his Department has made any requests to interview any diplomats from the People's Republic of China following allegations embassy staff pointed taser and stun guns at protestors on 3rd July 2026.

Chris Elmore:
The Metropolitan Police are actively investigating this matter. As the investigation remains ongoing, it would be inappropriate to comment further or speculate on the outcome. However, the Government is clear that any attempt by a foreign state to coerce, intimidate, harass or harm individuals on UK soil will not be tolerated.

Colobmia: Peace Negotiations

Ben Coleman: [34848]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what assessment he has made of the potential impact of proposed reforms relating to Colombia's Special Jurisdiction for Peace and proposed budget allocations on the implementation of the 2016 Peace Agreement, judicial independence and victims' rights.

Ben Coleman: [34851]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what discussions his Department has had with the Government of Colombia and international partners regarding proposed changes to the remit of the United Nations Verification Mission in Colombia; and what role the UK intends to play in supporting continued independent monitoring of peace-agreement implementation.

Ben Coleman: [34852]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what recent assessment his Department has made of the adequacy of security guarantees and protections for communities and victims involved in the implementation of Colombia's Peace Agreement.

Chris Elmore:
The UK remains a leading international advocate of Colombia's 2016 Peace Agreement. As penholder on Colombia at the UN Security Council, we continue to support the work of the UN Verification Mission and engage regularly with the Government of Colombia and international partners on peace process issues. Since 2016, the UK has committed over £80 million to support implementation of the Agreement, including transitional justice, reintegration and the protection of conflict-affected communities. The UK continues to support transitional justice mechanisms established under the Agreement and emphasises the importance of victims' rights and the independence of these institutions. We remain committed to supporting

independent monitoring of implementation through the UN Verification Mission and we support the new international verification mechanism for the Special Jurisdiction for Peace (JEP) sanctions. We are concerned by continuing violence affecting communities, victims, social leaders and former combatants, and regularly encourage Colombian authorities to strengthen protection measures, improve security guarantees and tackle the root causes of violence.

Cuba: Humanitarian Situation

Tim Roca: [35139]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what diplomatic steps his Department is taking to tackle (a) the deteriorating humanitarian situation in Cuba, and (b) the impact of US sanctions on food, fuel and medicine supplies and the effect of prolonged power blackouts on Cuban citizens.

Chris Elmore:
The UK remains concerned about the serious humanitarian situation in Cuba, particularly shortages of fuel, food and essential medicines. Fuel shortages are disrupting essential services and constraining the delivery of humanitarian assistance. The UK supports humanitarian relief through international and multilateral partners including the World Food Programme, United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) and the UN Central Emergency Response Fund. We continue to engage with international partners and assess what further practical support may be possible, while balancing competing humanitarian priorities globally.

The UK has consistently opposed the longstanding US embargo against Cuba, including through our voting position at the UN. We consider the embargo harmful to the Cuban people and counterproductive. Recent US measures affecting fuel supplies, finance and economic activity have compounded humanitarian pressures. Cuba's current challenges cannot, however, be explained by sanctions alone. Sustainable improvement also requires domestic economic reform.

Development Aid

James McMurdock: [35347]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, with reference to his Department's press release entitled UK calls for fundamental reset of global financial system for developing countries, published on 14 October 2026, what additional financial commitments his Department plans to make.

James McMurdock: [35348]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, with reference to his Department's press release entitled UK calls for fundamental reset of global financial system for developing countries, published on 14 October 2026, what estimate he has made of the cost to the public purse of implementing the proposals in that press release during the next five financial years.

Kirsty McNeill:
Any expenditure will be agreed through normal departmental business planning processes and managed within the Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office's Spending Review settlement.

James McMurdock: [35350]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, with reference to his Department's press release entitled UK calls for fundamental reset of global financial system for developing countries, published on 14 October 2026, what comparative assessment his Department has made of the value for money of contributing to multilateral development banks and other foreign aid channels in delivering the proposed reforms.

Kirsty McNeill:
The Multilateral development banks (MDBs) are leading development actors and a central part of the UK's international development toolkit, allowing us to achieve a level of scale and impact that is not possible through our bilateral programmes alone. The MDBs' financial model allows them to leverage shareholder capital, borrowing at low rates from international capital markets using their strong credit ratings and on-lending many multiples of the initial capital to countries at favourable rates. This offers strong value for money for the UK taxpayer. For example, in the case of the lending arm of the World Bank, £1 in capital from a shareholder such as the UK can enable up to £10 of additional lending to middle income countries over ten years.

James McMurdock: [35355]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, with reference to his Department's press release entitled UK calls for fundamental reset of global financial system for developing countries, published on 14 October 2026, what proportion of private capital mobilised through UK-supported development finance has been (a) invested in commercially sustainable projects and (b) required ongoing public subsidy and financial guarantees.

Kirsty McNeill:
Scaling up private capital mobilisation is essential for delivering the Government's priorities on inclusive growth and climate. UK-supported development finance seeks to mobilise private capital into investments which are commercially sustainable, or have a pathway towards commercial sustainability. His Majesty's Government development finance instruments seek to crowd in private investment that would not otherwise occur, whilst ensuring we avoid distorting markets.

Development Aid: Loans

James McMurdock: [35351]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, with reference to his Department's press release entitled UK calls for fundamental reset of global financial system for developing countries, published on 14 October 2026, what assessment his Department has made of the financial risks to the UK arising from the

proposals to lengthen repayment terms, reduce interest rates and provide for debt restructuring for developing countries through multilateral development banks.

James McMurdock: [35352]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, with reference to his Department's press release entitled UK calls for fundamental reset of global financial system for developing countries, published on 14 October 2026, if he will set out the safeguards that will be applied to ensure that debt relief and aid contributions are accompanied by sustainable public finances in the recipient country and transparent reporting on the use of funds.

James McMurdock: [35356]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, with reference to his Department's press release entitled UK calls for fundamental reset of global financial system for developing countries, published on 14 October 2026, what assessment his Department has made of the risk of fraud, corruption or diversion of funds under the proposed expansion of development finance.

Kirsty McNeill:
Reducing high debt service costs will create more fiscal space and allow partner countries to scale public investment. The government will also work in partnership with developing countries to support them to raise more domestic revenues, improving the efficiency of public spending, and tackling waste, corruption, and illicit flows. Delivery is managed through staff in the UK and overseas, the oversight of UK Delegations to the Multilateral Development Banks and established programme management processes.

Development Aid: Women

Alice Macdonald: [35213]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, with reference to paragraph 51 of his Department's document entitled UK International Strategic Framework on Women and Girls, published on 20 May 2026, what his planned timetable is for completing the delivery plan; and what steps his Department plans to take to report publicly on its implementation.

Kirsty McNeill:
Work is underway across the Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office (FCDO) to implement the UK International Strategic Framework on Women and Girls and put in place arrangements to monitor progress and establish governance mechanisms. As set out in the Framework, rigorous reporting and governance will monitor delivery against our goals on women and girls and support transparency and accountability.

Inter Mediate

Mike Wood: [34903]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, whether (a) Ministerial and (b) Permanent Secretary meetings with Inter Mediate are redacted from gov.uk transparency returns.

Uma Kumaran:
The Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office publishes details of Ministers' and senior officials' external meetings in accordance with the Government's transparency requirements. Previous publications show meetings between Inter Mediate and the Minister for Multilateral and Human Rights on 23 March 2026, in Haiti; and with the previous Minister for International Development Baroness Chapman of Darlington on 2 July 2025, in Haiti. Meeting information can be withheld under specific circumstances, but there are no records of exemptions being used for meetings with Inter Mediate.

Mike Wood: [34904]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, further to Conflict Resolution Department (CRD) Conflict Resolution Programme, IATI Identifier: GB-GOV-1-400035, Transaction reference GB-GOV-1-400035-403, for what reason there was a negative payment to Inter Mediate of £-368,297 on 23 February 2026.

Uma Kumaran:
The transaction identified in DevTracker is an internal correction. No negative payment was transacted.

Olly Robbins

Dr Neil Shastri-Hurst: [35911]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what the cost was of settling the legal action arising out of the dismissal of Sir Olly Robbins broken down into (a) legal costs incurred and (b) compensation paid.

Uma Kumaran:
The Department does not publish details of individual human resources (HR) cases.

Russia: Religious Freedom

Sir Desmond Swayne: [36009]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what assessment he has made of the implications for his policies of reports that Russia is restricting the peaceful religious activities of Jehovah’s Witnesses and Protestant Christian organisations.

Uma Kumaran:
The UK remains committed to championing freedom of religion or belief (FoRB) for all. No one should live in fear because of what they do or do not believe in. The UK

Special Envoy for FoRB, David Smith MP, plays a critical role in this. Reports of restrictions on peaceful religious activity reinforce the importance of this commitment.

The Government regularly condemns the Kremlin's dire domestic human rights record in international fora. The UK will continue to call on the Russian Government to uphold its international commitments on FoRB, and to end its persecution of religious minorities, including Jehovah's Witnesses and protestant communities.

Russia: Sanctions

Jim Shannon: [34634]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what steps he is taking to persuade the EU to renew sanctions on Russian billionaires.

Uma Kumaran:
We continue to work closely with the EU and other international partners to increase economic pressure on Russia. It is for the EU to comment on their sanctions decisions.

As the Prime Minister has made clear, the UK is committed to further sanctions on Russia. To date, the UK has sanctioned over 3,500 individuals, entities and ships under our Russia sanctions regime, of which over 3,300 were imposed since the full-scale invasion in 2022 and 500 imposed in 2026 alone.

Scotland: Diplomatic Relations

Harriet Cross: [36074]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what guidance his Department has issued on international engagement by devolved administrations under Schedule 5 of the Scotland Act 1998; and what assessment he has made of trends in the level of activities of the Scottish Government’s international hubs.

Uma Kumaran:
The Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office (FCDO) regularly issues detailed guidance on international engagement by Devolved Governments, including to our Embassies and High Commissions, to ensure that the UK Government's reservation on foreign affairs is protected. The FCDO monitors international activity undertaken by the Devolved Governments, including the Scottish Government. The majority of Scottish Government overseas staff are located on the FCDO platform, enabling close working and co-operation.

Security: International Cooperation

Stuart Anderson: [35334]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what steps he is taking to support human rights and democratic values in the context of strategic security partnerships.

Chris Elmore:
The Government promotes human rights, democratic values and the rule of law through its strategic security partnerships. Through these partnerships the UK strengthens oversight, promotes accountability, and encourages responsible contracting.

The UK supports international initiatives, including the Voluntary Principles on Security and Human Rights and the International Code of Conduct Association for Private Security Providers, to improve standards in security provision and reduce the risk of human rights abuses. The UK also works through multilateral and regional security fora, including the United Nations, the G7 and the Organization for Security and Co-operation in Europe, to promote human rights, democratic values and the rule of law internationally.

Shipping: Russia

Ben Obese-Jecty: [34689]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what assessment has his Department made of the potential impact of interdicting Russian shadow fleet vessels transiting the English Channel carrying diesel bound for the United States on international relations with the United States.

Uma Kumaran:
I refer the Hon Member to the answer given to question 33975 on 15 October.

South America: Diplomatic Relations

Ben Coleman: [34857]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what recent assessment his Department has made of the potential impact of South America on the UK's long-term diplomatic, economic and strategic interests.

Chris Elmore:
The UK Government recognises the growing importance of South America to the UK's long-term diplomatic, economic and strategic interests. The region offers significant opportunities for UK growth and economic security, including through trade, investment, critical minerals, clean energy and resilient supply chains. It is also central to tackling shared challenges including serious and organised crime, climate change and biodiversity loss. We are therefore strengthening partnerships across the region while working with partners on trade and investment, critical minerals, climate and nature, regional security and the rules-based international system. Our engagement is focused on areas where the UK can add distinctive value and advance our long-term prosperity, security and global influence.

Sudan: Chemical Weapons

Anneliese Dodds: [34862]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what assessment he has made of the potential impact on the quality of evidence relating to the alleged use of chemical weapons at the Al Jaili oil refinery of a delay to the examination of that evidence by the Organisation for the Prohibition of Chemical Weapons.

Anneliese Dodds: [34867]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what assessment he has made of the progress of the investigation by the Sudanese Armed Forces into the use of chemical weapons.

Anneliese Dodds: [34868]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what assessment he has made of the adequacy of the Sudanese Armed Forces' investigation into chemical weapons use.

Anneliese Dodds: [34870]

To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs, what discussions he has had with his US counterpart concerning the Organisation for the Prohibition of Chemical Weapons' role in relation to potential chemical weapons use in Sudan.

Kirsty McNeill:
I refer the Rt Hon. Member to the response provided to Question HL3376 on 6 October 2026. As we set out in our national statement at the 113th Executive Council of the Organisation for the Prohibition of Chemical Weapons (OPCW) on 6 October, we note with particular concern reports of chemical weapon use in Sudan and continue to call for the completion of a thorough, transparent, impartial and credible national investigation and for its findings to be shared with the OPCW as soon as possible.

HEALTH AND SOCIAL CARE

Autism: Children

Max Wilkinson: [35242]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what steps her Department is taking to help reduce waiting times for autism diagnostic assessments for primary school-aged children.

Alison McGovern:
The independent review into the prevalence and support for mental health conditions, attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (ADHD), and autism, led by Professor Peter Fonagy, was published on 9 October, providing analysis and recommendations across a wide range of issues relating to the current provision of services in this area.

The Government issued an initial response on the day of publication, available at the link below, but we will set out the full action we are taking in response to the review recommendations in our new Mental Health Strategy to be published later this year, which will be relevant to the issues raised by the Hon Member:

https://www.gov.uk/government/news/government-pledges-earlier-support-to-tackle-mental-health-crises

The Government remains fully committed to developing and publishing a revised cross-Government autism strategy in line with the Autism Act 2009. We will engage on the development of the revised autism strategy, including on whether the scope of the autism strategy should be extended to cover ADHD.

Autism: Diagnosis

Sarah Hall: [35580]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what assessment her Department has made of the potential impact of formal minimum wait times for autism assessments by some Integrated Care Boards (ICBs) in England.

Alison McGovern:
The independent review into the prevalence and support for mental health conditions, attention deficit hyperactivity disorder, and autism, led by Professor Peter Fonagy, was published on 9 October, providing analysis and recommendations across a wide range of issues, including delays in securing autism assessments.

The Government issued an initial response on the day of publication, available at the link below, but we will set out the full action we are taking in response to the review recommendations in our new Mental Health Strategy to be published later this year, which will be relevant to the issues raised by the Hon Member.

https://www.gov.uk/government/news/government-pledges-earlier-support-to-tackle-mental-health-crises

Autism: Mental Health Services

Max Wilkinson: [35249]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what assessment she has made of the extent of commissioning gaps in specialist autism mental health services across Integrated Care Systems.

Max Wilkinson: [35250]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, whether her Department plans to introduce national standards for autism-informed mental health care.

Max Wilkinson: [35251]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what assessment her Department has made of the adequacy of current NHS crisis response provision for patients experiencing acute mental health crises.

Alison McGovern:
The Independent Review into the prevalence and support for mental health conditions, attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (ADHD), and autism, led by Professor Peter Fonagy, was published on 9 October, providing analysis and recommendations across a wide range of issues, including the current provision of services in relation to autism and mental health.

The Government issued an initial response on the day of publication, available at the link below, but we will set out the full action we are taking in response to the review recommendations in our new Mental Health Strategy, to be published later this year. The Government also remains fully committed to developing and publishing a revised cross-Government autism strategy in line with the Autism Act 2009. We will engage on the development of the revised autism strategy, including on whether the scope of the autism strategy should be extended to cover ADHD.

https://www.gov.uk/government/news/government-pledges-earlier-support-to-tackle-mental-health-crises

The Government recently announced a major expansion of mental health support within the community, with £187 million allocated for 100 community mental health centres, and £156 million for 59 mental health emergency departments.

In addition, people of all ages experiencing a mental health crisis can access support through NHS 111 by selecting the mental health option. This provides access to mental health support and advice, including for children and young people, and can help people access appropriate local services when they need urgent support.

Brain: Tumours

Claire Young: **[35804]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what steps are being taken to reduce the time taken for promising brain tumour treatments to progress from laboratory research to clinical trials.

Mr James Frith:
I refer the Hon Member to the press release issued on the GOV.UK website on 14 October 2026, available at the link below, which provides the latest update on the action the Government is taking in this area:

https://www.gov.uk/government/news/brain-cancer-patients-to-see-faster-development-of-new-treatments

Health Services

Deirdre Costigan: **[34698]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what steps he is taking to help ensure that people can access care locally.

Alison McGovern:
The 10-Year Health Plan sets out an agenda for change, to deliver on the three big shifts needed to move healthcare from hospital to the community, from analogue to digital, and from sickness to prevention.

To achieve these shifts, we want to ensure that people can access high-quality adult social care when they need it, alongside support in the community that keeps people independent and prevents needs from escalating. That is why the Prime Minister has set out his vision for a National Care Service, providing free personal care for older people, which will sit alongside our National Health Service.

Local authorities are responsible for assessing individuals' care and support needs and, where eligible, for meeting those needs. Where individuals do not meet the eligibility threshold, they can get support from their local authority in making their own arrangements for care services, as set out in the Care Act 2014.

Nadia Whittome: **[36107]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what steps her Department is taking to ensure NHS staff consistently apply NHS Continuing Healthcare eligibility criteria and that eligible patients are identified and assessed promptly.

Alison McGovern:
Further to the answer provided on 14 September in response to Question 25150, NHS England has developed and published a comprehensive set of NHS Continuing Healthcare online learning resources for staff, to support consistency across integrated care boards when making decisions about NHS Continuing Healthcare eligibility.

Hospices: Finance

Dan Norris: **[35693]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what assessment she has made of the adequacy of statutory funding for adult hospices and what steps she is taking to ensure the long-term financial sustainability of the hospice sector.

Dan Norris: **[35694]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what estimate she has made of the number of commissioned hospice in-patient beds that are unavailable because of funding pressures and what can be done to get these beds back in use.

Alison McGovern:
The data requested is not centrally held, but on the wider issue raised, I refer the Hon Member to the answer provided on 13 July in response to Question 16185, which sets out the steps that the Government is taking to support hospices throughout England.

Hospices: Lincolnshire

Sir John Hayes: [35684]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what steps she is taking to ensure adult hospices are sustainably funded in (a) South Holland and the Deepings constituency and (b) Lincolnshire.

Alison McGovern:
I refer the Hon Member to the answer provided on 13 July in response to Question 16185, which sets out the steps that the Government is taking to support hospices throughout England.

Maternity Services

Sean Woodcock: [34701]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what steps she is taking to improve health outcomes in maternal and neonatal care.

Becky Gittins: [34702]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what steps she is taking to improve health outcomes in maternal and neonatal care.

Alison McGovern:
I refer the Hon. Members to the answer provided by my Rt Hon. Friend, the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, in the last session of departmental oral questions on 20 October, which is available at the following link:

https://hansard.parliament.uk/commons/2026-10-20/debates/D882B880-691C-4A64-B39E-4E161A42C231/OralAnswersToQuestions

Mr Lee Dillon: [34813]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, in the context of the recommendations of the Independent National Maternity and Neonatal Investigation published in June 2026, what progress the National Maternity and Neonatal Taskforce has made towards developing a national action plan, including measures to address racial inequalities in maternal outcomes.

Mr Lee Dillon: [34978]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what progress her Department has made towards setting a target to close the Black and Asian maternal mortality gap.

Mr Lee Dillon: [35272]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, whether her Department has considered the potential merits of routinely publishing maternity outcomes by ethnicity at NHS trust level to support the identification of and action on racial inequalities in maternity care.

Alison McGovern:
The National Maternity and Neonatal Taskforce is currently considering a wide range of evidence and proposals to inform its development of the Maternity and Neonatal Action Plan, and in her response to the debate on Baby Loss Awareness Week on 12 October, my Rt Hon. Friend, the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, who is chairing the taskforce, made clear that inequalities in maternal mortality related to ethnicity would be a key focus for its work, and that the action plan will be published before the end of the year.

Me/CFS: Health Services

Tessa Munt: [35793]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, when her Department plans to publish an updated implementation timetable for the outstanding commitments in the ME/CFS Final Delivery Plan, following the progress update issued on 9 October 2026.

Mr James Frith:
The Department continues to work with NHS England and other partners to deliver the remaining commitments in the myalgic encephalomyelitis/chronic fatigue syndrome (ME/CFS) final delivery plan. Progress on research-related actions will be reported on annually, to the ME/CFS Final Delivery Plan Stakeholder Engagement Group. The Department will provide updates on other actions as appropriate.

Mental Health Services: Reviews

Adam Dance: [35628]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what provisions she plans to put in place to ensure that recommendations from the final report of the Independent review into mental health conditions, ADHD and autism will be (a) integrated and (b) funded within the next 12-24 months.

Adam Dance: [35630]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what steps she is taking to ensure a cross-departmental approach to the implementation of the recommendations of the final report of the Independent Review into Mental Health Conditions, ADHD and Autism.

Adam Dance: [35762]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, when she plans to publish a timetable for implementing the recommendations of the Independent Review into Mental Health Conditions, ADHD and Autism.

Alison McGovern:
The Government issued an initial response to the independent review on the day of publication, available at the link below, but we will set out the full action we are taking in response to the review recommendations in our new Mental Health Strategy to be published later this year:

https://www.gov.uk/government/news/government-pledges-earlier-support-to-tackle-mental-health-crises

NHS: Disability

Graeme Downie: [33134]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what medical positions in the NHS require mandatory participation or engagement with disabled people or families to improve understanding.

Karin Smyth:
There are no specific medical positions for which participation or engagement with disabled people or families is mandated nationally as a condition of practice. Employers are responsible for ensuring that staff have the knowledge and skills required for their roles, and professional standards and training requirements for doctors are set by the General Medical Council and relevant royal colleges.

NHS: Negligence

Jim Shannon: [34136]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what steps she is taking to help reduce levels of NHS negligence in relation to injuries to babies, in the context of levels of NHS payouts last year.

Alison McGovern:
The Maternity and Neonatal Taskforce is currently considering a wide range of evidence and proposals to inform its development of the Maternity and Neonatal Action Plan, with a particular focus on how to avoid preventable injuries to mothers and babies, informed by the recommendations that the Baroness Amos investigation, the Donna Ockenden reviews, and Lady Justice Thirlwall's inquiry have already made in this area.

Alongside this, we are implementing a programme to reduce avoidable brain injury in childbirth by improving care in two high-risk areas: recognising and responding to foetal deterioration during labour; and managing impacted foetal head during caesarean section.

NHS: Staff

Paul Davies: [35183]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, for an update on the date of publication of the NHS workforce plan.

Karin Smyth:
The Government has committed to introduce a new 10 Year NHS Workforce Plan to complement the 10-Year Health Plan for England, and we will keep Parliament updated on the timetable for publication of that plan in the normal way.

Nottingham University Hospitals NHS Trust: Reorganisation

James Naish: [35607]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, whether her Department has assessed the potential impact of the University of Nottingham's Future Nottingham restructuring programme on NHS clinical service delivery, including the number of clinical academic posts at risk, the clinical sessions provided by those postholders to Nottingham University Hospitals NHS Trust and the arrangements for ensuring continuity of NHS services.

Karin Smyth:
No such assessment has been made by the Department. Decisions about recruitment are a matter for individual employers, who manage this at a local level to ensure they have the staff they need to deliver safe and effective care .

Papyrus UK: Telephone Services

David Smith: [31073]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what assessment her Department has made of the impact of the closure of Papyrus and its HOPELINE247 suicide-prevention service on rural young people and their families; and what discussions her Department has had with the organisations involved on the protection or transfer of the expertise and infrastructure previously provided by HOPELINE247.

Alison McGovern:
I refer the Hon Member to the answer I gave on 21 September in response to Question 29148.

David Smith: [35639]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what assessment her Department has made of the impact of the closure of Papyrus and its HOPELINE247 suicide-prevention service on rural young people and their families; and what discussions her Department has had with the organisations involved on the protection or transfer of the expertise and infrastructure previously provided by HOPELINE247.

Alison McGovern:
[Holding answer 22 October 2026]: I refer the Hon Member to the answer given on 21 September in response to Question 29148.

Pregnancy: Mental Health Services

Shivani Raja: [34662]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what steps she is taking to expand perinatal mental health provision.

Shivani Raja: [34663]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what assessment she has made of the adequacy of mental health support services available to women who have experienced pregnancy loss.

Alison McGovern:
The Maternity and Neonatal Taskforce is considering a wide range of issues to inform the development of the maternity and neonatal action plan, including the mental health support available for women who have experienced pregnancy loss. In her response to the Commons debate on Baby Loss on 12 October, my Rt. Hon. Friend, the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, agreed that this issue would be a key focus for the Taskforce's work, and will also be considered as part of our upcoming Mental Health Strategy.

Royal United Hospital: Maternity Services

Dan Norris: [34953]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what steps she is taking to improve maternity and neonatal care at the Royal United Hospitals Bath.

Alison McGovern:
The Royal United Hospitals Bath NHS Foundation Trust is working to the requirements of NHS England's Maternity and Neonatal 10-Point Plan (10PP) and has undertaken a multidisciplinary baseline assessment confirming that core safety and governance arrangements are in place. An improvement plan is being developed to address the outstanding requirements of the 10PP.

The trust is also reviewing its maternity and neonatal services against the Thirlwall Inquiry findings. Seven early actions have been identified, with named leads, clear milestones, and established governance oversight. The trust board will review the local Thirlwall assurance position in December 2026, including any further action required.

In addition, the trust is strengthening the analysis of outcomes and experiences by ethnicity and deprivation, preparing to participate in NHS England's Perinatal Equity and Anti-Discrimination Programme from January 2027, and working to implement the Maternal Care Bundle by March 2027.

Social Security Benefits: Uprating

Cat Eccles: [33147]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, why there is a delay between the annual uplift to Direct Payments rates taking effect on 1 April and the uprated rates being reflected in payments to recipients; what the average length of that delay has been in each of the last five years; and what steps he is taking to ensure that recipients receive the full benefit of annual uplifts promptly.

Alison McGovern:
A direct payment is one way in which a person may receive their personal budget. Under the Care Act 2014, a personal budget must be sufficient to meet a person's eligible care and support needs. There is no annual uprating process for personal budgets or in effect, direct payments. It is for local authorities to review and revise personal budgets where changes in costs or circumstances affect their sufficiency. The Department does not collect data on the time taken by local authorities to make such revisions and therefore does not hold information on the average length of any delay. This responsibility rests with individual local authorities.

Social Services

Andrew Rosindell: [35840]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, whether the value of a person's home will be taken into account in any assessment of charges under the proposed National Care Service.

Alison McGovern:
The Government is determined to create a National Care Service for everyone who needs it and we are bringing forward the timeline of Baroness Casey's Independent Commission as the basis for that crucial reform. We are also determined to deliver a broad-based political and public consensus on these proposals, and the Hon Member would be welcome to share his views and proposals to Baroness Casey over the coming months.

Social Services: Staff

Sagal Abdi-Wali: [34700]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what steps she is taking take to support the social care workforce.

Alison McGovern:
I refer my Hon Friend to the oral statement I made to the House on 15 October setting out the action the Government is taking to reform the social care system, including better supporting the social care workforce.

Visual Impairment: Rehabilitation

Cat Smith: [35110]

To ask the Secretary of State for Health and Social Care, what steps her Department is taking to improve access to vision rehabilitation services in Lancashire and across England.

Alison McGovern:
I refer the Hon Member to the answer provided on 30 June in response to Question 13055.

HOME OFFICE

Animal Experiments

Sarah Russell: [35451]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, with reference to the Annual statistics of scientific procedures on living animals, Great Britain 2025, published in July 2026, what assessment she has made of the 2.54 million scientific procedures involving living animals which were carried out in Great Britain in 2025.

Sarah Jones:
The Government has a strategy to reduce the use of animals in science. The direction of travel is clear: to accelerate replacement, reduction and refinement while maintaining protections for human and animal health and the environment.

The 2.54 million scientific procedures carried out in 2025 represent a reduction of around 3.8% from 2.64 million in 2024 and the lowest annual total recorded under the Animals (Scientific Procedures) Act 1986. The Government nevertheless recognises that the figure remains significant. The aggregate total must also be understood alongside the purpose, species and severity of procedures, and the distinction between experimental procedures and the breeding of genetically altered animals.

Under the statutory principles of replacement, reduction and refinement, a scientifically satisfactory non-animal method must be used wherever possible; the number of animals must be reduced to a minimum without compromising the objectives of the programme; and methods must be refined to eliminate or reduce pain, suffering, distress and lasting harm.

In November 2025, the Government published its Replacing Animals in Science strategy, backed by £75 million, to accelerate the development, validation and uptake of alternative methods and work towards replacing animal use in all but exceptional circumstances. The 2025 figures reinforce the case for sustained delivery of that strategy. Where suitable alternatives do not yet exist, well-justified and appropriately designed animal research may continue under the rigorous requirements of ASPA to protect human and animal health and the environment.

Asylum

Dr Neil Shastri-Hurst: [33707]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, with reference to her Department's publication entitled Understanding behaviours and expectations in the UK: a guide for asylum seekers, published on 19 August 2026, the total number of copies of the publication that have been distributed to date; and the total cost of producing and publishing the publication to date.

Anna Turley:
No physical materials have been printed, ordered or distributed and therefore no distribution costs have been incurred.

The total cost of the development of the posters and the leaflets was £21,635.

Asylum: MOD Bicester

Calum Miller: [35797]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, what assessment her Department has made of the potential impact of the proposed asylum accommodation at Site A at MoD Bicester on residents in surrounding communities, in relation to the relevant provisions of the National Planning Policy Framework on crime and the fear of crime.

Anna Turley:
No final decision has been taken on the future use of MOD Bicester Site A.

Suitability assessments are ongoing and will consider a range of factors including safety, security, operational deliverability, planning requirements, and the impact on local services and communities. This work is informed by engagement with Thames Valley Police and other statutory partners. Relevant planning considerations, including crime and the fear of crime, would be considered through the appropriate planning processes.

If the site is taken forward, it would have security permanently on site supported by CCTV and appropriate access-control arrangements.

The Home Office would continue working closely with police and local partners to assess risks and help protect the safety and wellbeing of local communities, staff and those accommodated on site.

Cycling: Road Traffic Offences

Mr Richard Holden: [34736]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, how much City of London police spend per year on the cycling sin-bin strategy.

Sarah Jones:
The Home Office does not hold information on the City of London Police annual spend on the cycling sin-bin strategy. Decisions on the allocation of police resources and expenditure are operational matters for individual police forces, who are best placed to determine their local requirements.

Defending Democracy Taskforce

Mr Gregory Campbell: [36110]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, pursuant to the answer of 19 October 2026 to Question 34739, on how many occasions officials from the Northern Ireland Executive attended in (a) 2024 and (b) 2025.

Dan Jarvis:
We do not comment on the attendance of officials at individual Taskforce meetings, however officials from the Northern Ireland Executive are not standing members of the Taskforce.

Officials from the Taskforce and member departments such as the Joint Election Security Preparedness Unit regularly engage with the Northern Ireland Executive on relevant topics. The Taskforce will continue to do so as we approach the Northern Ireland Assembly Elections next year.

Domestic Abuse: Women

Catherine West: [35409]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, what progress is being made to combat non-physical abuse such as coercive and controlling behaviour as part of our mission to end violence against women and girls.

Satvir Kaur:
Controlling or coercive behaviour (CCB) is an insidious form of domestic abuse, and we recognise the long-term emotional and psychological distress it can cause.

'Freedom from violence and abuse: a cross government strategy to build a safer society for women and girls', sets out a range of commitments to improve the response to CCB, including:

- Updating the Controlling or Coercive Behaviour Statutory Guidance to reflect the latest policy and practice. This will further strengthen the understanding of CCB by frontline agencies, such as the police;
- Investing £13.9 million this year into the National Centre for VAWG and Public Protection to strengthen the police response to VAWG crimes, including CCB; and
- Rolling out Domestic Abuse Protection Orders to all police forces and courts across England and Wales. These cover all forms of domestic abuse, including CCB, and can impose tougher restrictions on perpetrators.

Foreign Influence Registration Scheme: Annual Reports

Mr Gregory Campbell: [35854]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, when does she expect to publish the first annual report of the Foreign Influence Registration Scheme.

Dan Jarvis:
We are currently preparing the FIRS annual report for publication, and it will be laid in Parliament as soon as practicable. The report will set out, among other things, the number of registrations, the number of information notices issued, the number of persons charged with an offence and the number of persons convicted of an offence.

Harassment: Victims

Mr Tanmanjeet Singh Dhesi: [36247]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, what recent steps her Department has taken to ensure that police forces notify victims of stalking and harassment offences when a suspect is released on bail.

Mr Tanmanjeet Singh Dhesi: [36252]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, what recent steps she has taken to help ensure that police forces notify victims of any bail conditions imposed on a suspect that are in place for the victim's safety.

Sarah Jones:
We know the devastating impact that crime can have on a victim, and how stalking and harassment can leave victims living in fear going about their day-to-day lives. That is why the Government recognises the importance of victims being kept informed about developments in their case.

The police are required to notify victims of bail conditions by requirements in the Victims' Code (the Code). The Code sets out the minimum level of service that victims of crime in England and Wales are entitled to receive from criminal justice agencies, including the police. It includes a number of statutory rights which require victims to be kept informed of key developments in their case, including being told about any bail conditions imposed on a suspect and any subsequent changes to those conditions.

Decisions on the management of individual investigations are operational matters for police forces. The College of Policing's Authorised Professional Practice on victim and witness care also states that victims should be kept informed at all stages of an investigation and they should be told when a suspect is released under investigation, charged, or released on bail. In addition, the Police, Crime, Sentencing and Courts Act 2022 strengthened the pre-charge bail framework by introducing a duty to seek victims' views when imposing or varying bail conditions, to ensure that those conditions better protect all victims.

Home Office: Development Aid

David Taylor: [32742]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, how much Official Development Assistance was spent from the Home Office budget in each of the 2024/25 and 2025/26 fiscal years; and how much of each amount was reported in the 2024 and 2025 calendar ODA statistics.

Sarah Jones:
For 2024/25 the fiscal year spend was £2266m

For 2025/26 the fiscal year spend was £2203m

For 2024 the calendar year spend was £2390m

For 2025 the calendar year spend was £2064m

Home Office: Public Expenditure

Ben Obese-Jecty: [34938]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, with reference to The Defence Investment Plan Funding explainer, published on 30 June 2026, if she can confirm whether her department is required to contribute to the funding laid out under line 5, “Reduce departmental capital budgets by one per cent”.

Sarah Jones:
Yes - The Home Office is required to contribute to the funding laid out under line 5 of the Defence Investment Plan explainer.

Departments have been asked to contribute 1p in every £1 of their capital budgets to fund this Government’s Defence Investment Plan, helping keep the country safe in an increasingly volatile world.

Immigration: Human Rights

Blake Stephenson: [36067]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, whether she has made an estimate of the number of sponsor human rights claims (a) overall and (b) that will result in appeals under clause 17 of the Immigration and Asylum Bill in each of the first three years after commencement.

Anna Turley:
It is not possible to estimate the number of sponsor human rights claims made in the first three years after commencement as applicants currently apply for entry clearance in their own right and can raise Article 8 grounds as part of that application, or at appeal.

These reforms do not create new rights and entitlements or make it easier for overseas family members to enter the UK. Sponsors will still need to meet a high threshold by showing that refusal of entry would result in a breach of their Article 8 rights.

Every Article 8 case is different and must be decided on its own facts. These reforms are designed to support more consistent decisions, but it is not possible to predict the outcome of individual cases and therefore how many sponsor human rights claims will result in an appeal.

Instead, we will monitor the impact of the reforms by looking at indicators like grant rates, refusal rates, appeal outcomes and the reasons that appeals succeed, to ensure the policy is working as intended.

Blake Stephenson: [36068]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, how many of the Article 8 cases sampled for the impact assessment for the Immigration and Asylum Bill involved family

life with a person outside the core cohabiting family as defined in clause 18; and if she will publish the sample methodology.

Anna Turley:
There was no data collected on ‘core cohabiting families’ as part of the Article 8 case sample, which was used in the Impact Assessment for the Immigration and Asylum Bill. Details of the sample methodology are published in the impact assessment in Annex 3.

Immigration: Syria

Nadia Whittome: [35876]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, what steps her Department is taking to improve the processing times of indefinite leave to remain applications for Syrian nationals.

Jo White:
Applications for indefinite leave to remain are considered within 6 months of their submission where possible in accordance with published customer service standards, which are available here Settlement: customer service standards - GOV.UK

If an application is assessed to be complex and will take longer, for example supporting documents need to be verified, an individual needs to attend an interview or because of an individual’s personal circumstances, the individual will be contacted and notified of this.

Additional resource has been deployed to focus on these applications, and the Home Office is working at pace to ensure that the number of outstanding applications and waiting times decrease.

Independent Immigration Appeals Authority: Costs

Blake Stephenson: [36064]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, what estimate she has made of the (a) set-up and (b) annual running costs of the Independent Immigration Appeals Authority in each of its first five financial years.

Anna Turley:
Detailed plans for the new authority are being developed, including costs. As currently set out in the Asylum & Immigration Bill (schedule 2, paragraph 11), once the IIAA is operational, it will publish its annual report and accounts as soon as reasonably practicable after the end of each financial year.

Joint Security and Resilience Centre : Finance

Stuart Anderson: [35304]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, what resources have been provided to the Joint Security and Resilience Centre (JSaRC) to support public-private execution of the National Security Strategy 2025.

Dan Jarvis:
The Joint Security and Resilience Centre (JSaRC) acts as a convening and engagement mechanism for the security industry that supports delivery of the National Security Strategy 2025.

JSaRC is staffed by 15 full-time equivalent civil servants, supported part-time by three secondees from industry. Its budget for 2026 to 2027 is £1,748,476.

These resources enable JSaRC to provide the secretariat for the Security and Resilience Growth Partnership board and to run the annual Security & Policing Exhibition.

Members: Correspondence

Steve Darling: [36244]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, when her department plans to respond to the Member for Torbay's correspondence from the 28 of July, reference SD19201.

Sarah Jones:
The correspondence dated 28 July was accepted for response by the Ministry of Justice, who have responsibility for the Early Release Scheme, on 30 July.

National Crime Agency

Phil Brickell: [34809]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, how many accreditations did the National Crime Agency's Proceeds of Crime Centre grant to a) financial investigators and b) financial Intelligence officers in financial years 2024-25 and 2025-26.

Phil Brickell: [34810]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, what was the total number of a) accredited financial investigators and b) accredited financial intelligence officers registered with the National Crime Agency's Proceeds of Crime Centre and holding public sector roles in each of the last 5 years from 2021-22 through to 2025-26.

Sarah Jones:

Financial Year No. of Financial Investigators (FIs) Trained No. of Financial Intelligence Officers (FIOs) Trained2024/2025 282911 2025/2026 340855 The data provided represents the total number of individuals trained as FIs and FIOs by the Proceeds of Crime Centre in the years 2024-2025 and 2025-2026. Once training is successfully completed the officer is able to exercise relevant POCA powers as an FI and undertake the role of an FIO.

Police: Rural Areas

Stuart Anderson: [34773]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, what assessment she has made of the adequacy of the police funding formula in meeting the needs of rural police forces.

Sarah Jones:
The majority of public funding for police forces in England and Wales is provided by the Home Office and is agreed by the House of Commons on an annual basis at the police funding settlement. Each year the Home Office produces a Police Grant Report which is published and voted on by Parliament and contains grant funding allocations for the following year to be paid out under the Police Act 1996. The funding formula used for distributing Home Office Police Main Grant divides funds between different activities that the police undertake. A portion of total funding is also distributed according to population sparsity, to address the specific needs of rural forces. A copy of the most recent Grant Report for 2026-27 has been placed in the Libraries of both Houses and can be found online:

https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6979db5b316fd8f8015520ad/E03528744_-_HC_1638_-_Police_Grant_Report_2026-27_BOOKMARKED.pdf

The Police Reform White Paper confirmed that we will review the formula once the implementation of police reform is underway so that the new formula reflects the new police force structures.

Reviewing the funding formula is an opportunity to review and update the factors that drive relative demand on modern police budgets for all forces – whether rural, urban or a blend of the two. Next steps of this review will be set out after the Independent Review of structures has reported.

Undocumented Migrants: English Channel

Mr Lee Dillon: [34818]

To ask the Secretary of State for the Home Department, what recent discussions she has had with her European counterparts about strengthening cooperation to prevent small boat crossings in the English Channel.

Anna Turley:
The Government is working with European partners to strengthen collective efforts to deter illegal migration and prevent dangerous Channel crossings, most notably with France. The UK maintains regular engagement with the French Government at all levels on illegal migration and border security.

HOUSING, COMMUNITIES AND LOCAL GOVERNMENT

Buildings: Safety

Tulip Siddiq: [29959]

To ask the Secretary of State for Housing, Communities and Local Government, if she will set a date by when she will issue the necessary Regulations under s.111 of the Building Safety Act 2022 and insert subsection 30E of s.112 into the Landlord and Tenant Act 1985, to provide life-safety support to Directors of higher-risk buildings by allowing the appointment of a paid director for a building safety purpose.

Florence Eshalomi:
The Government has carefully considered the consultation responses on Building Safety Directors alongside experience of operating the new building safety regime. The Government's position on the commencement of the Building Safety Director provisions, including regulations under section 111 of the Building Safety Act 2022 and the related provisions under section 112, will be set out in the forthcoming response to the consultation.

Paul Holmes: [30075]

To ask the Secretary of State for Housing, Communities and Local Government whether, whether Viva Midco Limited (parent company of Avant Homes) remains a member of the Responsible Actors Scheme.

Florence Eshalomi:
Yes, Viva Midco Limited, parent company of Avant Homes, remains a member of the Responsible Actors Scheme. The names of Scheme members are listed on gov.uk.

Charlie Dewhirst: [31033]

To ask the Secretary of State for Housing, Communities and Local Government, in relation to higher-risk buildings as defined by the Building Safety Act 2022, what assessment her Department has made to identify systemic hazards linked to the risk of structural failure and the potential impact on different structural typologies of higher-risk buildings.

Florence Eshalomi:
The Building Safety Act 2022 introduced a new regime for occupied higher-risk buildings, overseen by the Building Safety Regulator (BSR). Accountable Persons are required to assess, manage and report building safety risks, including those relating to structural failure.

The BSR, keeps the safety of buildings under review in accordance with its statutory duty set out in Section 5 of the Building Safety Act 2022. As part of this work, BSR assesses emerging evidence relating to potential structural safety risks. The BSR works with the sector to understand the extent and implications of these risks.

There is no comprehensive data set to inform assessment of severity of structural safety risks in buildings. The BSR is undertaking research to better understand how to strengthen the collection and use of structural safety data in the future. BSR is alert

to the risk of deterioration in structural condition posed by our ageing building stock. The BSR and MHCLG are working together to determine if more needs to be done to ensure building structures are appropriately reviewed, maintained and managed throughout their lifecycle.

Business Rates: Pilot Schemes

David Simmonds: [30011]

To ask the Secretary of State for Housing, Communities and Local Government, in which mayoral combined authorities 100% business rate retention pilots are operating; from what date the pilots commenced; and what the tier split is between the combined authority and the local councils in each case.

Jim McMahon:
The government has committed to giving mayors a share of business rates from April 2027, more will be set out in the fiscal devolution roadmap this autumn.

In 2026-27 the following 100% business rates (BR) retention pilots are operating - Cornwall Council, Greater Manchester Combined Authority area, Liverpool City Region Combined Authority area, West Midlands Combined Authority area and the West of England Combined Authority area.

All of these 100% BR retention pilots commenced from 2017-18.

Details of how business rates are allocated across each region are included on pages 26 and 27 of the 2026-27 Local Government Finance, which is published here The Local Government Finance Report (England) 2026-27.

It should be noted that the precise calculation of business rates revenues retained locally will also be impacted by other parts of the business rates retention system such as top ups and tariffs, levy and safety net payments, and revenues from local pooling arrangements.

Fires: Conferences

Sir Julian Smith: [31605]

To ask the Secretary of State for Housing, Communities and Local Government, what steps she is taking with the Department for the Environment, Food and Rural Affairs to convene the forthcoming National Wildfire Summit; and if she will provide an update on when the summit will take place.

Florence Eshalomi:
Planning for the upcoming Wildfire summit is underway, and is being taken forward in collaboration with relevant departments and partners, including the Department for the Environment. Invites went out to partners and it is due to take place on Friday 23rd October in Merseyside.

Fires: Lincolnshire

Sir John Hayes: [34256]

To ask the Secretary of State for Housing, Communities and Local Government, what steps she is taking to help reduce housefires in Lincolnshire.

Florence Eshalomi:
The government's Fire Kills national advertising campaign provides clear, practical advice to help residents prevent fires in their homes and respond safely if a fire occurs. This year focuses on the need to have sufficient smoke alarms in the home. The campaign supports fire and rescue services, including Lincolnshire, to deliver their statutory duty to promote fire safety through local fire prevention activity.

MHCLG supports work with the National Fire Chiefs Council to provide a nationally consistent approach to Home Fire Safety Visits across services, tailoring each intervention to the individuals within a particular home. This is augmented with a free online home fire safety check tool, which provides people with fire safety advice tailored to their household and property.

Housing: Standards

Vikki Slade: [34648]

To ask the Secretary of State for Housing, Communities and Local Government, who is accountable if structural faults are identified in a newly built home following the new build's sign off.

Florence Eshalomi:
For buildings constructed in recent years, developers generally have a contractual responsibility for structural faults through warranty agreements. Most new build properties are sold with 10-year warranties, which are funded through developer premiums and usually require developers to directly fix any issues identified within 2 years of occupancy. Local authorities and the Building Safety Regulator can also take enforcement action against those who have contravened the building regulations.

Planning Permission: Liverpool City Council

Paula Barker: [35679]

To ask the Secretary of State for Housing, Communities and Local Government, what data her Department holds on how many FOIs have been submitted to Liverpool City Council specifically related to the planning department in the last two years.

Paula Barker: [35681]

To ask the Secretary of State for Housing, Communities and Local Government, how many FOIs were submitted to Liverpool City council relating to the planning department were responded to within the legal time limit in the last two years.

Paula Barker: [35687]

To ask the Secretary of State for Housing, Communities and Local Government, what information her Department holds on the number of FOI requests that Liverpool City Council have declined to respond to in the last two years relating to the planning department.

Paula Barker: [35688]

To ask the Secretary of State for Housing, Communities and Local Government, what information her Department holds on the number of meetings held between Liverpool City Council planning department staff and members of the public and whether such meetings are recorded.

Paula Barker: [35689]

To ask the Secretary of State for Housing, Communities and Local Government, what oversight does the Chief Executive and planning committee members of Liverpool City Council have of complaints and FOI's about the planning department.

Jim McMahon:
The Department does not hold this information, but Liverpool City Council will hold this information.

JUSTICE

Administration of Justice: Wales

Nick Timothy: [34991]

To ask the Minister for Justice, whether the Prime Minister plans to devolve power over prisons and justice policy to the Welsh Government; and what discussions he has had with the Welsh Government on this subject.

Alex Davies-Jones:
The Prime Minister has been clear that the Government will continue to engage with the Welsh Government and other partners on matters of devolution and the Government's *Rewiring the State Delivery Plan* will set this out further. Effective partnership working is essential to improving outcomes for victims, reducing reoffending and building safer communities, which is underpinned by the significant benefits that flow from the single England and Wales legal jurisdiction. The Government wants to ensure the shared legislative framework, common sentencing powers and judicial arrangements, national operational standards and the ability to maintain consistency are sustained, while drawing on expertise and resources across both nations and delivering for the people of Wales.

UK Government ministers and officials have regular discussions with the Welsh Government and other Governments of the Nations on a range of matters, including devolution.

Bail

Mr Tanmanjeet Singh Dhesi: [36256]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, what recent assessment he had made of police force compliance with the Victims' Code in informing a victim on (a) a suspect's bail status and (b) any relevant bail conditions.

Alex Davies-Jones:
The Government is committed to ensuring that victims receive the entitlements set out in the Victims' Code, including the right to be informed when key decisions are made during a police investigation, such as a suspect's bail status and any relevant bail conditions. That is why in January 2025 a new statutory duty in the Victims and Prisoners Act 2024 was commenced, which requires agencies who provide Code services to comply with the Code unless there is a good reason not to.

The Victims and Prisoners Act 2024 also creates a framework to monitor certain criminal justice agencies' compliance with the Victims' Code, including police forces, with duties on those agencies to collect and share information on compliance. Once commenced, the framework will introduce local scrutiny and national oversight of compliance with the Victims' Code. The Victims and Courts Act 2026 strengthened the powers of the Victims' Commissioner within the framework by requiring the Commissioner to produce their own report on Code compliance, to enable independent oversight of the criminal justice agencies compliance with the Code.

The Government is working with criminal justice agencies, including policing, to develop the data and metrics needed to support the assessment of compliance with the Victims' Code.

Earlier this year, the Ministry of Justice consulted on a new Victims' Code, seeking views from victims, sector experts, criminal justice practitioners and young people. The consultation included consideration of how agencies communicate with victims and keep them informed throughout the criminal justice process. The Department is now taking the time to consider nearly 200 responses and will issue a public response ahead of finalising the new Code and bringing it into force. The findings will also help inform future work to understand and measure victims' experiences of the criminal justice system and the delivery of Victims' Code rights.

CAFCASS: Greater Manchester

John Cooper: [30739]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, what the average percentage attendance rate was of assigned CAFCASS staff at Piccadilly Gate, Manchester in the most recent working week for which figures are available as a percentage of assigned staff attending the workplace and in absolute terms.

Jake Richards:
Cafcass does not routinely record workplace attendance by employees' designated office location.

As of October 2026, 138 staff had the Manchester (Piccadilly Gate) office recorded as their designated office location. During the most recent working week for which data are available (5-9 October 2026), an average of 9.8 unique users per day accessed the Cafcass network from the Manchester office, with 49 unique daily logins recorded across the week. These figures are derived from network access data and represent unique daily logins from the Manchester office.

Cafcass does not require staff to attend an office for a specified number of days each week. Staff whose designated office location is Manchester may be working from another Cafcass office, attending court hearings, undertaking visits with children and families, or carrying out other work-related travel. Equally, individuals accessing the Manchester office may be based at another Cafcass location. As a result, the data should not be interpreted as the percentage of Manchester-based staff attending the office.

Compulsorily Detained Psychiatric Patients

Nick Timothy: [36208]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, how many restricted patients were released from hospital into the community in 2025 by (i) index offence group and (ii) index offences of (a) murder, (b) manslaughter, (c) rape and (d) sexual assault; and how many of those were conditionally discharged.

Catherine McKinnell:
The specific information requested could be provided only at disproportionate cost.

Criminal Proceedings

Munira Wilson: [34895]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, how many criminal cases in England and Wales are listed for their next substantive hearing in a) 2027, b) 2028, c) 2029 and d) 2030 or later.

Sarah Sackman:
As at 30 September 2026 (the latest available data), the number of criminal cases in England and Wales listed for trial in 2027, 2028, 2029 and 2030 are as follows:

FUTURE TRIAL DATE	NUMBER OF TRIALS
2027	26,999
2028	7,997
2029	2,736
2030	702

HMCTS Management Information – extracted Crown Operational Dashboard 15 October 2026

1. The management information presented in this table reflects what is recorded on relevant case-management systems on the date of extraction. The case management systems are continually updated and so the information presented will differ from any previously provided or published information. Management Information is subject to inaccuracies inherent in any large-scale reporting system.
2. The number of listed trials for each year is defined as: a future trial date is listed where for that case a plea and trial preparation hearing (PTPH) has taken place. For context, the PTPH gives an indication of defendants' plea. Once a not guilty plea has been registered against any offence on the indictment, a trial may take place.
3. If a case has two trial dates listed, the latest trial date is captured.
4. Note that the data are quality assured to remove future trial dates that do not meet accuracy standards - this means there is potential for undercounting the true number of cases where a trial is listed in future years.

The Lord Chancellor has made clear his commitment to reduce the Crown Court backlog and enable victims to have their day in court faster – this is why we are acting on all fronts. We are investing heavily in Crown Court capacity, court infrastructure, uncapped sitting days, technology and legal aid. We are also driving greater efficiency in the courts through measures such as responsible AI innovation, case coordinators for every Crown Court centre, and close collaboration with the judiciary on their reforms to listing practices and virtual hearings guidance. The Government has also brought forward structural reforms through the Courts and Tribunals Bill – based on Lord Leveson's recommendations in his Independent Review of the Criminal Courts – to ease pressure on the Crown Court, ensure proportionate allocation of resource, and redress the balance between victims and defendants.

Crown Court: Trials

Munira Wilson: [34896]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, what is the latest date currently to a Crown Court trial as a result of court backlogs.

Sarah Sackman:
The Government inherited a record and rising backlog. We know this means that thousands of victims, witnesses and defendants are waiting years for their day in court, and justice delayed is justice denied. As at 30 September 2026 (the latest available date), the furthest-listed Crown Court trial was scheduled for December 2030.

Employment Tribunals Service: Scotland

Imogen Walker: [35208]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, what recent assessment he has made of the adequacy of current waiting times for employment tribunal cases in Scotland.

Sarah Sackman:
The Government has not made a specific assessment of the adequacy of current waiting times for Employment Tribunal (ET) cases in Scotland. However, we continue to monitor Employment Tribunal performance through regular engagement with HM Courts and Tribunal Service (HMCTS) and the judiciary.

HM Prison Service: Recruitment

Sarah Pochin: [35041]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, how many people applied for a role, were assessed for a role signed a formal offer for a role in the Prison Service by nationality in each year between 2016 and 2026.

Catherine McKinnell:
This information could only be provided at disproportionate cost.

Homicide

Max Wilkinson: [35247]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, what assessment he has made of the potential merits of creating a specific offence for one punch Manslaughter.

Alex Davies-Jones:
The Lord Chancellor in 2024-5 asked the Law Commission to undertake a review of homicide law and murder sentencing. The review will cover the full range of homicide offence issues, including the merits of reform on the issue of one punch manslaughter. The publication for the final report is due in 2028.

The Government will carefully consider any recommendations arising from the Law Commission's review once it has concluded.

Immigration: Appeals

Blake Stephenson: [36075]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, how many appeals by foreign national offenders are pending before the First-tier Tribunal (Immigration and Asylum Chamber) on the latest date for which data is available; and what the average time to determination was for those appeals in (a) 2025 and (b) 2026.

Sarah Sackman:
The information requested is not held centrally.

Juries: Allowances

Bell Ribeiro-Addy: [34550]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, when his Department last reviewed the maximum daily rate of the loss of earnings allowance for jurors.

Bell Ribeiro-Addy: [34551]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, what assessment his Department has made of the financial impact of jury service on lower-paid workers.

Bell Ribeiro-Addy: [34553]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, what assessment has his Department made of whether financial hardship is a factor in requests to be excused from jury service and the effect on the diversity of juries.

Bell Ribeiro-Addy: [34554]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, what data his department holds on the number of jurors who have claimed the loss of earnings allowance each year for the past five years.

Sarah Sackman:

Jury service is an important civic duty, and the Government is committed to ensuring jurors feel supported throughout their service. All support to jurors is kept under regular review to ensure it remains appropriate and accessible.

Jurors do not receive direct payment for jury service but may claim allowances towards financial loss, travel and subsistence. There has been no separate assessment of the maximum daily rate of the loss of earnings allowance or the financial impact of jury service on lower-paid workers.

We recognise that some individuals may experience financial difficulties serving. Applications for excusal due to exceptional circumstances, such as financial hardship, can be made when summoned. The proportion of those who apply for this is low, as shown by the latest figure below for 2025/2026:

- 7.6% of all excusals were due to financial hardship.

Courts may also be able to arrange to pay expenses during the trial if a juror is facing financial hardship.

The number of jurors who have claimed the loss of earnings allowance each year for the past five years is not routinely available and can only be obtained at disproportionate cost.

We do not hold comprehensive diversity data for all jurors; therefore, no assessment has been made of the impact of excusals for financial hardship on jury diversity.

We are mindful of the impact that jury service can have on jurors in the context of long running trials, particularly jurors who have financial concerns.

It is, in part, for that reason that we are introducing the option of judge-only trials for highly complex or lengthy fraud and financial cases - where the trials can take months and therefore impose a disproportionate burden on jurors.

Magistrates: Recruitment

Jim Shannon: [34664]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, what assessment he has made of the potential impact of proposed moves to employ more magistrates in the UK on Barnett Consequentials for Northern Ireland.

Sarah Sackman:
Justice is devolved in Northern Ireland, so decisions on the recruitment and deployment of magistrates there are a matter for the Northern Ireland Executive.

Any Barnett consequentials arising from changes in UK Government spending are calculated in accordance with the established Barnett formula. It is for the Northern Ireland Executive to decide how to allocate its block grant, including funding for devolved justice services.

Marriage: Relatives

Mr Richard Holden: [34692]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, whether the Government plans to introduce a statutory definition of incestuous marriage for the purposes of marriage law.

Jake Richards:
The Marriage Act 1949 prohibits marriage between certain close relatives; this is referred to as marriages within prohibited degrees. The prohibited degrees of relationship are listed in Schedule 1 of the Act, and include parents and children, grandparents and grandchildren and aunts/uncles and nieces/nephews. These existing statutory provisions already make clear that such marriages are not valid in the eyes of the law.

Powers of Attorney

Andrew Ranger: [35484]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, what steps her Department is taking to help protect pensioners from financial exploitation by people acting under a power of attorney; and what measures are in place to identify, investigate and prevent the misuse of those powers.

Jake Richards:
Lasting powers of attorney (LPAs) are private legal arrangements which allow a person to choose who they trust to make decisions on their behalf should they lose capacity. Under the Mental Capacity Act 2005, a donor must have capacity when making an LPA and is entitled to make their own decisions about who they trust to act on their behalf. The LPA framework therefore reflects the importance of donor choice and autonomy. There are statutory eligibility requirements and safeguards which mean some people cannot be appointed as attorneys.

The Office of the Public Guardian (OPG) can and does investigate concerns raised about an attorney's conduct and, where appropriate, apply to the Court of Protection

to remove attorneys who are not meeting their duties under the Mental Capacity Act 2005. Anyone can report a concern if they are worried about the behaviour of an attorney, including family members or friends, professionals, or members of the public.

In addition, OPG works closely with the financial services sector, including through its engagement with UK Finance, to ensure financial institutions understand when and how to report suspected fraud, financial abuse and other safeguarding concerns involving attorneys and deputies. Financial institutions are able to raise concerns with OPG through established reporting routes, so that concerns about an attorney's conduct can be investigated.

Prison Accommodation

Nick Timothy: [35791]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, with reference to the Annual Statement on Prison Capacity, published on 29 January 2026, which programmes of a) construction, b) refurbishment and c) maintenance programmes that had been due to deliver prison places by October 2026 have been delayed; by how long; and how many places each delay accounts for by programme and establishment.

Catherine McKinnell:
As set out in the Annual Statement published in January 2026, we are on track to deliver 14,000 additional places by 2031. Programme delivery timelines are subject to change as external factors can affect large-scale infrastructure projects. The supply projections set out in the Annual Statement include contingency to account for shifts in delivery timelines. The next Annual Statement will be published in due course and will contain updated demand and supply projections.

Prisoner Escorts: Standards

Sarah Olney: [35068]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, how many privately contracted prison vans logged failures of service to the Ministry of Justice each year in the UK since 2015.

Sarah Olney: [35069]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, how many privately contracted prison vans logged failures of service to the Ministry of Justice each year in London since 2015.

Catherine McKinnell:
The information requested could not be obtained without incurring disproportionate cost.

Prisoners' Release

Nick Timothy: [34948]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, how many of the prisoners released as part of the early release scheme on 1 October 2026 have since returned to prison.

Catherine McKinnell:
This Government inherited a prisons system days from collapse. We had no choice but to take decisive action to stop our prisons overflowing and keep the public safe. Our landmark Sentencing Act 2026 will now deliver a more sustainable solution to the prison capacity crisis we inherited, including through the progression model, which will help ensure there are always enough prison places for the courts to be able to send people to custody.

We have interpreted your question as relating to prisoners who have returned to custody through recall following release under the progression model on 1 October 2026.

We regularly publish data on releases and recall to prison via our Accredited Official Statistics publication Offender Management Statistics Quarterly (available at: Offender management statistics quarterly - GOV.UK).

The requested information on returns to custody following releases under the progression model on 1 October cannot be provided because it would form a subset of the data that underpins future versions of these Official Statistics on total releases and recalls.

Prisoners' Release: Electronic Tagging

Sarah Pochin: [35045]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, whether people being released early under the terms of the Sentencing Act 2026 may be exempted from ankle tagging on the grounds of being diagnosed with anxiety.

Sarah Pochin: [35049]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, whether there are any neurological conditions which would exempt people released early under the terms of the Sentencing Act 2026 from being fitted with an ankle tag.

Catherine McKinnell:
Electronic monitoring and Sentencing Act 2026 guidance states that individuals may be exempted from electronic monitoring where wearing a tag is medically inappropriate. Poor mental health alone, such as anxiety, is not grounds for exemption.

Cases where a neurological condition makes tagging unsafe or impractical, or where an individual lacks the mental capacity to understand their electronic monitoring conditions may be exempt. Exemption decisions are made on a case by case basis, based on professional judgement and, where appropriate, relevant medical evidence.

Prisoners' Release: Pornography

Nick Timothy: [35979]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, whether those imprisoned under the new criminal offences related to pornography introduced by the Crime and Policing Act 2026 will be eligible for early release under the Earned Progression Model.

Catherine McKinnell:
The new offences relating to pornography in the Crime and Policy Act 2026 are not yet in force. They will come into force on 6 November 2026.

Rape and certain child sexual offences are excluded from the Progression Model as well as unlawful killing and indecent assault.

Prisoners: Parents

Shivani Raja: [34633]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, with reference to the Ministry of Justice Transparency Data entitled Updated estimates of children with a parent in prison, published on 10 September 2026, what analysis his Department has undertaken of the support needs of young adult dependents experiencing parental incarceration.

Jake Richards:
The BOLD (Better Outcomes through Linked Data) Partnerships programme has carried out extensive work on children experiencing parental imprisonment, with children under 18 as their main focus.

For children under 18, parental imprisonment can be a safeguarding and developmental issue with support needs focusing on emotional wellbeing, maintaining stability in education and school attendance, family support, and facilitating contact with the imprisoned parent where safe and appropriate. The purpose of this work is to provide early, preventative support to reduce the risk of adverse outcomes and unmet needs later in life (including as young adults).

For young adult dependants affected by parental imprisonment, the needs are likely to be around income, housing, and employment support. They may also be caring for younger siblings and may need mental health support. These services are offered through adult rather children’s services.

There is limited data on young adult dependants affected by imprisonment as there are no specific data collections relating to this age group. Support for young adult dependants affected by imprisonment is likely to overlap with employment support, youth transition from children’s social care, and youth justice related services.

Prisoners: Risk Assessment

Nick Timothy: [35492]

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, how many prisoners across the prison estate are currently assessed as (a) standard risk and (b) high risk under the Cell Sharing Risk

Assessment on the latest date for which figures are available, broken down by establishment.

Catherine McKinnell:
The information requested is not collated centrally and could only be obtained at disproportionate cost.

LEADER OF THE HOUSE

Written Questions: Arms Length Bodies

Mike Wood: [35464]

To ask the Leader of the House, pursuant to the answer of 8 September 2026, to Question 20501, on Written Questions: Arms Length Bodies, if he will ensure that sponsoring Ministers facilitate written Parliamentary Questions to the Independent Football Regulator.

Sir Alan Campbell:
The Independent Football Regulator is an executive non-departmental public body, sponsored by the Department for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport.

In relation to the scrutiny of Arms Length Bodies, I refer the Hon Member to the answer provided in response to question 20501.

SCOTLAND

Foreign Relations: Scotland

Harriet Cross: [36078]

To ask the Secretary of State for Scotland, what are the (a) legal and (b) constitutional remedies available if a Scottish Government international hub was found to be undertaking functions reserved to the UK Government under Schedule 5 of the Scotland Act 1998.

Melanie Ward:
Under the Scotland Act 1998, international relations remain a matter reserved to the UK Government. The Scottish Government is entitled to promote its trade and economic interests abroad and the UK Government believes this is most effectively achieved by working through the UK's extensive diplomatic footprint to ensure we are speaking with one voice on the international stage.

The Scottish Government international hubs are hosted by the Foreign Commonwealth and Development Office (FCDO) at Embassies, Consulates and High Commissions across the world, and benefit from UK Government accreditation and FCDO Services. All UK officials on platform must act in accordance with the Scotland Act and are accountable to the Head of Mission.

The Scotland Office and FCDO closely monitor this issue and remain committed to upholding the areas of reserved competence, while working with the Scottish Government to deliver on the priorities of the people of Scotland.

Sovereignty: Scotland

Harriet Cross: [35939]

To ask the Secretary of State for Scotland, whether he has sought assurances from the Scottish Government that no public funds, civil service staff time or other official resources are being used to support the SNP's Choose Scotland campaign for Scottish independence.

Melanie Ward:
The people of Scotland deserve governments that are focused on delivering for them. This Government does not support independence or another referendum. We are focused on protecting and respecting devolution and delivering better outcomes, including through the offer of joint work on further decentralisation within Scotland that the Prime Minister made to the First Minister on 16 October.

The UK Government strongly believes in the need to uphold the reputation and impartiality of the civil service in Scotland. The Scottish Government's Permanent Secretary, who is a UK home Civil Servant, is the Accountable Officer for the Scottish Government, and responsible for ensuring that the requirements of the Civil Service Code are met, including on the use of Civil Service time.

More widely, the Civil Service code also states that civil servants have an obligation to make sure public money and other resources are used properly and efficiently, and so any spending by the Scottish Government would need to be approached in that context.

TRANSPORT

Air Passenger Duty: Scotland

Mr Richard Holden: [35899]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what discussions she has had with the Scottish Government on its Air Departure Tax.

Keir Mather:
The Secretary of State for Transport has had no discussions with the Scottish Government on its Air Departure Tax.

Air Traffic Control

Greg Smith: [34822]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what estimate she has made of the costs incurred by airlines as a result of the NATS technical failures on 8 and 21 September 2026.

Greg Smith: [34823]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, whether she has undertaken analysis of whether implementation of the recommendations of the Independent Review of NATS (En Route) plc's Performance on 28 August 2023 would have (a) prevented and (b) mitigated the NATS technical incident on 8 September 2026.

Keir Mather:
We are still in the process of understanding the impact of the 8 September NATS outage across the UK, including its impact on airlines. I recognise the significant disruption this outage caused for passengers, airlines, and airports. The Government is taking steps to ensure the right lessons are learnt. This includes asking the Civil Aviation Authority (CAA) to conduct an independent review into the incidents.

Airlines: Tickets

Jim Shannon: [34644]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what steps she is taking to support airlines to maintain their winter capacity.

Keir Mather:
The UK aviation sector is predominantly privately owned and operated, with airlines responsible for managing their operational capacity and ensuring appropriate resilience and contingency arrangements are in place to manage disruption during the winter period.

The Department for Transport engages regularly with airlines, airports and wider industry stakeholders to seek assurance that robust winter preparedness plans are in place, including arrangements to mitigate the impacts of adverse weather and other operational risks.

Blue Badge Scheme

Alex Mayer: [35389]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, how many organisational Blue Badges are currently valid, broken down by local authority.

Justin Madders:
As of March 2025, there were 21,440 valid Blue Badges held by organisations in England.

Information on Blue Badges held by organisations and a breakdown by local authority is published on GOV.UK: https://www.gov.uk/government/statistical-data-sets/blue-badge-scheme-statistics-data-tables-dis#blue-badge-scheme-statistics-data-tables.

Bus Services: Fines

James MacCleary: [36400]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, how her Department plans to enforce fines for loud music and vaping on buses in the Lewes constituency.

Simon Lightwood:
It is up to the Local Transport Authorities to decide whether they want to use the powers in the Bus Services Act to implement bus byelaws to deter nuisance behaviour on their local bus networks.

Where local authorities decide that this is a priority then byelaws will be able to be enforced by Transport Safety Officers, or other authorised officers employed by the local authority as well as by the Police.

Bus Services: Wheelchairs

Nadia Whittome: [35815]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what steps her department is taking to strengthen guidance and enforcement to ensure that wheelchair users can travel with confidence on buses.

Simon Lightwood:
The Government is committed to ensuring disabled people, including wheelchair users, can travel safely and with confidence on local bus services.

The Public Service Vehicles Accessibility Regulations 2000 require buses and coaches used on local and scheduled services to include accessibility features such as wheelchair spaces and boarding equipment suitable for passengers using a standard “reference wheelchair”. Existing regulations also require drivers to provide assistance to disabled passengers upon request.

The Bus Services Act 2025 strengthens this framework by requiring drivers and other customer-facing staff to complete disability awareness and assistance training at least every five years. The Act also requires local authorities to publish Bus Network Accessibility Plans and strengthens consideration of accessibility within local bus service planning.

In addition, the Department is developing an Accessible Travel Charter which will help establish clear, unified principles for disabled passengers and assist operators and enforcement bodies in upholding accessibility standards.

The Charter will set out cross-cutting commitments and practical pledges, with organisations signing up to go beyond the legislative minimum and work towards a barrier-free transport system.

c2c: Benfleet

Rebecca Harris: [34686]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what data her Department holds on the number of daily on time services at Benfleet station between October 2025 – September 2026 compared to October 2024 – September 2025.

Keir Mather:
In March 2025, the Department made station specific performance information available, showing punctuality and cancellations at individual stations for the first time. This information can be found at: Performance at stations | ORR Data Portal.

Rebecca Harris: **[34687]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what estimate her Department has made of the number of cancelled c2c rail services affecting Benfleet station and how this compares to other rail operators.

Keir Mather:
The Office of Rail and Road publishes periodic station-level information on rail performance, including the percentage of scheduled trains which did not call at each station. This includes information for Benfleet station and c2c. The data can be found at: https://dataportal.orr.gov.uk/statistics/performance/performance-at-stations.

The Department does not produce comparisons of cancellations at individual stations between train operators. Such comparisons need to be treated with care because operating characteristics vary between routes and operators.

c2c: Nationalisation

Rebecca Harris: **[34688]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what assessment her Department has made of changes to value for money for passengers on c2c services since they were taken in to public ownership.

Keir Mather:
The Department has set up the Department for Transport Operator to oversee and drive improvements in performance and financial sustainability for all publicly owned operators, including c2c. Considerations include areas such as fares, punctuality, customer experience and accessibility, all of which are regularly discussed and challenged directly with the operator.

Regulated rail fares have been frozen across England until March 2027, saving passengers £600 million and easing cost-of-living pressures, which c2c passengers benefit from.

c2c: Rolling Stock

Rebecca Harris: **[34683]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what plans her Department has to invest in rolling stock across c2c rail services during the remainder of this Parliament.

Keir Mather:
The recently published Rolling Stock and Infrastructure Strategy sets out a new, long-term, whole-system approach to decisions about passenger trains and the infrastructure that supports them, focused on delivering better outcomes for passengers and taxpayers.

c2c is currently assessing the feasibility and affordability of an interior refurbishment programme for its Class 357 fleet. Any such programme would be subject to approval and, if taken forward, would not be completed before 2030.

c2c: Standards

Rebecca Harris: [34685]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what record her Department has of the number of severely disrupted days on c2c rail services between October 2025 – September 2026 compared to October 2024 – September 2025; and how many of these days affected services to and from Benfleet station.

Keir Mather:
The Office for Rail and Road publishes the Severe Disruption information here: https://dataportal.orr.gov.uk/statistics/performance/passenger-rail-performance/table-3157b-days-of-severe-disruption-by-sub-operator-periodic/

In the case of c2c, all the days with severe disruption can be assumed to have affected services to and from Benfleet. https://dataportal.orr.gov.uk/performance

Cars: Manufacturing Industries

Alison Griffiths: [35136]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, pursuant to the Answer of 13 October 2026 to Question 29628 on Cars: Manufacturing Industries, what criteria her Department uses to assess whether compliance costs under the Zero Emission Vehicle mandate are affordable for vehicle manufacturers.

Simon Lightwood:
The Government continues to engage with vehicle manufacturers on a regular basis regarding the Zero Emission Vehicle (ZEV) Mandate, including as part of the long-committed ZEV Mandate Review, which is currently subject to consultation. The consultation closes on 23 October, and we will publish the outcome of the review in our consultation response.

Data from the ZEV Mandate shows the average cost of trading ZEV allowances to meet compliance in the UK in 2024 was approximately £4,000 per traded ZEV allowance for cars. DfT analysis estimates the average additional cost of discounting for ZEVs was around £2,800 per vehicle in 2025. Both are substantially lower than the Mandate's compliance payment levels. Vehicle discounting is common and recent industry data suggests discounts on ZEVs are increasingly at levels comparable to petrol vehicles.

Driving Licences

Mr Richard Holden: [34455]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, pursuant to the Answer of 12 October 2026 to Question 29739 on Driving Licences, what the average time taken by the DVLA was to

process vocational driving licence applications where a medical condition required assessment in each month since 4 July 2024 by (a) new applications and (b) renewals.

Justin Madders:
The table below shows the average number of days to make a licensing decision for applications where a medical condition required investigation before a licence could be issued since July 2024. The figures relate to group 2 (bus and lorry) vocational applications.

AVERAGE NUMBER OF DAYS TO MAKE A LICENSING DECISION FOR GROUP 2 APPLICATIONS

	2024	2025	2026
Jan		46.3	42.5
Feb		40.6	46.3
Mar		40.6	56.2
Apr		43.5	49.0
May		41.5	45.1
June		37.9	46.5
July	49.4	39.1	53.3
Aug	40.1	41.7	64.8
Sept	41.0	49.0	55.8
Oct	47.3	55.8	
Nov	40.0	47.7	
Dec	46.7	47.0	

Electric Vehicles

Greg Smith: [35533]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, pursuant to the Answer of 14 October 2026 to Question 31269 on Electric Vehicles, whether she has made representations to the Chancellor of the Exchequer ahead of the Budget on increasing the £7.5 billion allocated to supporting the transition to zero emission vehicles; and whether her Department plans to introduce additional financial incentives for the purchase of electric vehicles.

Simon Lightwood:
Ministers in the Department for Transport regularly discuss a wide range of topics with Ministers in HM Treasury.

Electric Vehicles: Charging Points

Freddie van Mierlo: [35750]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, if she plans to provide new schemes when the existing charging point grant schemes for home and workplaces expire; and what steps she is taking to help ensure that EV charging infrastructure keeps pace with EV adoption.

Freddie van Mierlo: [35752]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what discussions she has had with relevant partners on increasing the number of EV charging points.

Simon Lightwood:
We continue to monitor grants for homes and workplaces to ensure best value for the taxpayer. We will make a further announcement on these grants in due course.

The Department continues to work closely with industry to support electric vehicle charging infrastructure and meet rising demand. As of 1 October 2026, Government and industry have supported the installation of over 124,000 public chargers across the UK. The Local Electric Vehicle Infrastructure Fund is expected to deliver over 100,000 more near homes across England. We continue to monitor charge point rollout.

Daisy Cooper: [35863]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, whether applicants to the Electric vehicle chargepoint grant for residential landlords whose application was refused due to not being submitted using the online portal before 31 March 2026 can reapply for the extended scheme.

Simon Lightwood:
Applicants in this situation are welcome to reapply on the extended scheme. Before doing so they should check the grant guidance as new evidencing requirements have been introduced.

Shivani Raja: [36188]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, since 27 May 2026, how many of the charge points allocated through the Local EV Infrastructure Fund are (a) operational and open to the public, (b) installed but awaiting grid connection and (c) allocated but not yet installed.

Simon Lightwood:
As of 1 July 2026, 1,268 public chargers delivered through the Local EV Infrastructure Fund were operational and open to the public. Figures on the number of chargers committed through signed contracts are commercially sensitive, but the programme remains on track to deliver over 100,000 chargers.

Daisy Cooper: [36237]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, pursuant to the Answer of 19 October to Question 32077 on Electric Vehicles: Charging Points, what proportion of applications were successful in each year since 2022.

Simon Lightwood:
The Department does not hold this information. This is because, before April 2026, the automated grant management system meant customers could not submit applications unless they met eligibility criteria.

From 1 April, a new system has been in place. Up to 14 October, 4,382 customers (46%) submitted eligible applications. This has resulted in installers making 1,443 claims on customers' behalf so far. Nearly 750 claims have been approved to date. Processing these applications and claims takes time. We are working to move them through the new system and streamline the process.

Electric Vehicles: Manufacturing Industries

Martin Wrigley: [35212]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, if she will make an assessment of the potential impact of reducing the Zero Emission Vehicle Mandate on (a) EV take-up and (b) emissions levels in Devon.

Simon Lightwood:
Alongside any changes to the ZEV Mandate, a Cost Benefit Analysis will be made which set out the potential impact on ZEV uptake and emissions at a UK level. On 14 August, the Government launched the ZEV Mandate Review consultation, which seeks views from the public and stakeholders to consider the ZEV Mandate. This consultation forms an important part of the long-committed ZEV Mandate review.

No policy decisions have been made yet regarding the trajectories of the ZEV Mandate. We are seeking views on whether a revised approach to the existing Mandate trajectories is warranted. The Government remains committed to the 2030 and 2035 phase-out dates and they are not subject to change.

Heathrow Airport: Construction

Greg Smith: [35532]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, whether she plans to designate Heathrow expansion as Critical National Growth Infrastructure; and what assessment she has made of the potential impact of that designation on the planning process.

Keir Mather:
The draft Heathrow Expansion National Policy Statement (HENPS) proposes designating Heathrow expansion as Critical National Growth Infrastructure (CNGI), recognising its potential importance to national growth. How that proposed CNGI policy would interact with the planning process is set out in the draft HENPS, located here:

https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6a3923ed0bea238415c9a3a9/proposed-draft-revision-to-the-anps-to-be-known-as-the-henps.pdf

We have consulted on this approach, and the Government will carefully consider the views received through the consultation, alongside the Transport Select Committee's recommendations, before setting out its response and any next steps in relation to the HENPS.

Israir: Aircraft

Mr Richard Holden: [33328]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what information her Department holds on the causes of damage to Israir aircraft at London Luton Airport in the last year.

Keir Mather:
The Department holds no information on these incidents.

Large Goods Vehicles: Electric Vehicles

Shivani Raja: [36431]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, pursuant to the Answer of 3 September 2026 to Question 19484 on Large Goods Vehicles: Electric Vehicles, whether her Department's assessment of the total cost of ownership of zero-emission HGVs compared with diesel equivalents differentiates between different operational use cases.

Simon Lightwood:
The Department for Transport will publish analysis regarding the total cost of ownership of zero emission HGVs relative to diesel HGVs across use cases alongside the next consultation on the HGV CO2 emissions regulatory framework.

Low Emission Zones: Fines

Shivani Raja: [30544]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what assessment she has made of the accessibility of the appeals process for Ultra Low Emission Zone penalty charge notices for people experiencing financial hardship; and whether she has had discussions with Transport for London on (a) payment by instalments, (b) the treatment of first-time contraventions and (c) the effect of payment of a penalty charge on an outstanding appeal.

Simon Lightwood:
Transport in London is devolved to the Mayor of London and Transport for London (TfL) and this includes decisions on road schemes which charge users including the Ultra-Low Emission Zone (ULEZ). We work closely with TfL on a range of issues but the operation and management of the ULEZ is a matter solely for them. It would not be appropriate for the Government to comment or intervene in these matters.

Maritime and Coastguard Agency: Translation Services

Sir John Hayes: [31975]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, how much the Maritime and Coastguard Agency spent on interpreters and related translation services in (1) 2022, (2) 2023, (3) 2024 and (4) 2025.

Keir Mather:

Financial Year	Amount
2022	£ 3,929.82
2023	£ 16,081.70
2024	£ 10,189.26
2025	£ 13,409.97

Motor Insurance: Safety Measures

Alex Mayer: [35393]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what assessment her Department has made of the potential for advanced vehicle safety technology to reduce motor insurance premiums.

Justin Madders:
My Department has not made a specific assessment of the potential impact of advanced vehicle safety technology on motor insurance premiums. Motor insurers are responsible for setting the terms and conditions of the policies that they offer and it is for them to decide whether advanced vehicle safety technology would reduce the level of risk that any given applicant poses.

Motor insurers use a wide range of criteria to assess the potential risk a driver poses before issuing a policy. This includes the age of the applicant, the type of vehicle being insured, the postal area where the applicant lives and the driving record and experience of the applicant.

NATS: Cost Effectiveness

Rebecca Smith: [34775]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what assessment she has made of the adequacy of NATS funding for operational resilience relative to dividend distributions in each of the last five financial years.

Keir Mather:
[Holding answer 19 October 2026]: NATS is a private company, run by its own board. The Transport Secretary appoints three non-executive directors to NATS'

board to look after the Government's stake but does not run the company on a day-to-day basis.

NATS is required to submit plans relating to its investments in its systems and critical infrastructure upgrades to the CAA on a regular basis. This allows the regulator the opportunity to scrutinise these, and to ensure that safety and the efficiency of NATS operation is always prioritised. However, decisions made in relation to dividends for shareholders are a matter for NATS Board.

As part of the independent review into NATS' performance following the incidents that occurred on 8 and 21 September this year, the CAA will complete a broader assessment of NATS' resilience, capital investment and modernisation plans, as well as the effectiveness of the CAA's own regulatory oversight. An initial findings report is due to be completed by end of January 2027, with a final report submitted by the end of March 2027.

NATS: Investment Income

Alison Griffiths: **[34768]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, how much her Department received in dividends from NATS in each of the last five financial years.

Alison Griffiths: **[34770]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what discussions she has had with NATS on (a) air traffic controller vacancies, (b) recruitment and training capacity and (c) disruption attributable to staffing levels.

Alison Griffiths: **[34771]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what arrangements are in place to ensure the independence of the Civil Aviation Authority's review into the NATS technical incident on 8 September 2026.

Keir Mather:
The Civil Aviation Authority (CAA) review into the NATS outage of 8 September 2026 will be carried out by a dedicated team working independently of NATS, government and the aviation industry in order to deliver a robust and impartial review. To further ensure the independence of the review, an Independent Challenge Panel, whose membership will be approved by the Secretary of State, will provide independent challenge and advice throughout.

The review will examine the causes of the incidents, broader questions relating to NATS' resilience, capital investment and modernisation plans, helping to identify any lessons needed to strengthen the resilience of the UK air traffic management system.

Whilst the CAA review will consider the adequacy of the resilience requirements, governance and assurance arrangements applied to NATS critical operational systems and supporting infrastructure, it is the responsibility of air navigation service providers to ensure that an adequate and trained workforce is in place to operate safely and effectively.

However, my department recently introduced secondary legislation giving the CAA powers to recognise the previous training of third country and military ATCOs towards meeting the requirements needed to achieve a UK civil ATCO licence. This will reduce the time it takes these individuals to become a civil ATCO in the UK and increase resilience across the sector.

Dividends received by the Department from NATS are shown in the Department's Annual Report and Accounts, available on Gov.uk .

NATS: Skilled Workers

Rebecca Smith: [34776]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what assurances she has sought from NATS that qualified engineers are available on site at its operational centres at all times to respond to critical system failures.

Rebecca Smith: [34777]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, if she will commission a review of options to provide airlines with financial redress for costs incurred as a result of NATS technical failures.

Keir Mather:
I recognise the significant disruption this outage caused for passengers, airlines, and airports. The Government is taking steps to ensure the right lessons are learnt. This includes asking the Civil Aviation Authority (CAA) to conduct an independent review into the incidents.

As part of the independent review into NATS' performance following the incidents that occurred on 8 and 21 September this year, the CAA will complete a broader assessment of NATS' resilience, which will include the adequacy of the resilience requirements, governance and assurance arrangements applied to NATS existing critical operational systems and supporting infrastructure. The review will also complete a broader assessment of NATS' capital investment and modernisation plans, as well as the effectiveness of the CAA's own regulatory oversight. An initial findings report is due to be completed by end of January 2027, with a final report submitted by the end of March 2027. As a significant shareholder of NATS, the Government expects appropriate accountability and will consider the findings of the ongoing investigation carefully.

Parking: Pedestrian Areas

Lewis Cocking: [34898]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, pursuant to the answer of 29 June to question 11865, on Parking: Pedestrian Areas, when her Department intends to lay secondary legislation on pavement parking.

Justin Madders:
The Department intends to introduce secondary legislation on pavement parking in two stages.

First, we intend to introduce powers in January 2027 enabling local authorities with civil parking enforcement powers to issue penalty charge notices where a vehicle is parked in a way that unnecessarily obstructs the pavement.

We then plan to introduce powers as soon as possible to enable local transport authorities to prohibit pavement parking in their areas, subject to appropriate exemptions. The timetable for the secondary legislation has not yet been finalised.

Public Transport: Visual Impairment

Max Wilkinson: [35234]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what assessment she has made of the adequacy of the accessibility by public transport of DVLA-contracted eyesight assessment services in Gloucestershire.

Justin Madders:
The Driver and Vehicle Licensing Agency (DVLA)'s contract with Specsavers for vision testing services provides coverage across England, Wales and Scotland, with 436 stores able to perform the services required. Where required, there are provisions within the contract that allow Specsavers to utilise alternative local opticians for customers who live more than 25 miles from their nearest Specsavers branch.

Railway Stations: Scotland

Mr Richard Holden: [30906]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, which stations in Scotland have had GBR branding applied to them.

Keir Mather:
As part of the unveiling of the Great British Railways (GBR) brand identity, it was temporarily applied to Glasgow Central Station for a week in December 2025 alongside four other stations in England.

The framework for a memorandum of understanding (MoU) between the Secretary of State and Scottish Ministers, published in March 2026, sets out the approach to branding of stations in Scotland. We are working with Scottish Ministers to develop this framework into an MoU. Other than Glasgow Central High Level and Edinburgh Waverley, stations are the responsibility of the Scottish Government rather than GBR - and are branded accordingly.

Railway Stations: Theft

Jim Shannon: [34642]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what steps she is taking to work with police to deter thieves and criminal gangs from operating at London Railway stations, targeting wealthy passengers.

Keir Mather:
Decisions about operational policing, including the deployment of officers at London railway stations, are matters for the Chief Constable of the British Transport Police (BTP), who is operationally independent of Government.

As the dedicated police force for the railway, BTP works with partners to keep all passengers safe across the network. BTP undertakes operations to tackle theft of passenger property and organised criminal activity, using targeted plain-clothes deployments and intelligence-led activity to disrupt organised criminal groups.

This work has delivered a sustained reduction in theft of passenger property and other volume crime, including high-harm offences.

Theft of passenger property fell by 9.2% in 2025/26 and this improvement reflects joint targeted prevention activity with industry partners, including safety announcements on the London Underground by serving BTP officers, high visibility patrols at peak times and improved use of data to identify prolific offenders.

Railways: Tickets

Peter Lamb: [34735]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what steps she is taking to help prevent ticketless travel on rail and underground services.

Keir Mather:
The Government is working with the rail industry to tackle ticketless travel, while ensuring passengers who make genuine mistakes are treated fairly and consistently.

We have committed £33.4 million to new and improved ticket gates across England, targeted at fare evasion hotspots. We are also working with the rail industry to improve data sharing, prosecutions and the consistency of revenue protection activity.

Responsibility for enforcement on London Underground rests primarily with Transport for London and the British Transport Police.

Road Signs and Markings

Max Wilkinson: [35232]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what assessment her Department has made of the cost and efficiency of Traffic Regulation Orders in the delivery of yellow lines.

Justin Madders:
The Department has not undertaken a formal assessment of the cost and efficiency of Traffic Regulation Orders specifically in relation to the delivery of yellow lines. The making and implementation of individual Traffic Regulation Orders is a matter for the relevant traffic authority.

Roads: Fees and Charges

Tristan Osborne: [34808]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, what assessment her Department has made of the potential merits of establishing a national payment system for parking charges, tolls and other road-user charges, enabling motorists to register for automatic payment.

Justin Madders:
The Government is committed to making road-user payments simpler and is supporting the rollout of the National Parking Platform, which enables motorists to use their preferred parking app across participating area, supporting greater interoperability, choice and competition.

The Platform is also exploring opportunities to support tolls and other road-user payments in future, including how payment could be made more seamless for motorists.

The Department has made no assessment of, and has no plans to introduce, a mandatory national payment system for all parking charges, tolls and road-user charges.

Speed Limits: Cameras

Mr Richard Holden: [34472]

To ask the Secretary of State for Transport, pursuant to the Answer of 12 October 2026 to Question 29875 on Speed Limits: Cameras, what tactics the police are using to enforce speeding offences on sections of the Strategic Road Network affected by the technical anomaly since October 2025.

Justin Madders:
As stated in the Written Ministerial Statement issued in December 2025, National Highways have implemented interim measures such as increased traffic officer patrols on affected sections of road. In addition, the police continue to use a range of tactics to enforce speed limits on the Strategic Road Network, including mobile camera deployments, roads policing patrols, and average speed sites.

TREASURY

Defence: Manufacturing Industries

Stuart Anderson: [34786]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, what evaluations have been conducted on the economic multiplier effect of domestic defence manufacturing investments.

Emma Reynolds:
Increased domestic defence investment will improve our security and stability and boost economic growth, through more skills, innovation and spillover effects.

The government will ensure that economic growth considerations are central to decision-making in the allocation of defence investment. Our Defence Investment Plan will back British workers, support businesses and innovation, and create thousands of better-skilled jobs and apprenticeships by increasing Defence exports.

Dental Services: VAT

Mr Gregory Campbell: [35921]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, what VAT distinction has been made between elective orthodontic treatment in adults and essential appliances used to correct craniofacial and occlusal abnormalities in children.

James Murray:
There is no distinction in VAT treatment dependent on whether the patient is an adult or child.

Orthodontic treatment is exempt from VAT where it forms part of a package of medical care whose principle purpose is to protect, maintain or restore a person's health, provided the conditions for the medical exemption are met.

Equitable Life Assurance Society: Compensation

Susan Murray: [35990]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, how much of the £100 million contingency for Equitable Life With-Profits Annuitants has been drawn on to date.

Susan Murray: [35991]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, whether the £58 million of Equitable Life Payment Scheme payments that could not be issued to untraced policyholders has been returned to the Exchequer.

Torsten Bell:
The Liberal Democrat Conservative coalition government chose to allocate £1.5 billion to the Equitable Life Payment Scheme, which included a contingency of £100 million.

Significant efforts were made to identify and trace eligible policyholders and payments to them began in June 2011.

At 30 September, the total value of payments stood at £1.3957 bn, and the Scheme is on track to pay out the remainder.

Gold: World War II

Mike Wood: [36105]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, if he will ask the Bank of England to provide the dates when Nazi gold was disposed of.

Lucy Rigby:
Relevant distribution dates of recovered Nazi-looted gold are set out in the publicly available Final Report of the Tripartite Commission. [1]

[1] https://2009-2017.state.gov/s/l/65668.htm

Government Departments: Procurement

Jim Shannon: [34639]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, what steps he is taking to reduce the public spend in offshore companies.

Emma Reynolds:
The government is ensuring that public procurement delivers the best value for taxpayers by protecting national security, enhancing supply chain resilience across critical sectors, and supporting businesses, growth and innovation. Changes, including those to the Social Value model announced by the government in August 2026, will ensure that suppliers will be assessed by their commitment to back British jobs, skills and opportunities, to deliver benefits for communities across the UK.

As set out in Managing Public Money, central government bodies should avoid contractors using offshore jurisdictions, consistent with international obligations and the government's stated objectives on tax transparency and openness.

Hydrogen: Storage and Transport

Graham Stuart: [35790]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, whether his Department is considering (a) reducing and (b) reprofiling funding for hydrogen transport and storage.

Emma Reynolds:
The government recognises that Hydrogen can help reindustrialise Britain by cutting emissions from heavy industry and providing clean power, helping to maintain our manufacturing base, and creating new clean energy industries and skilled jobs in our industrial heartlands.

The Chancellor will set out his plans for spending at future fiscal events.

Income Tax: Tax Allowances

Alan Gemmell: [34863]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, whether he has considered the potential merits of extending the transferability of Personal Allowances for partners of disabled people.

James Murray:
The Chancellor makes decisions on tax policy at fiscal events, and does not routinely comment on proposals.

Lord Mandelson

Mike Wood: [34921]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, pursuant to the answer of 9 October 2026 to Question 20511 on Lord Mandelson, whether any business was fed back to the Department following the then Chancellor's meeting with Lord Mandelson.

Dan Tomlinson:
I refer the honourable member to the answer on the 9th of October. In line with usual practice, any government business raised in meetings is fed back to the Department.

National Insurance Contributions

Susan Murray: [34816]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, what estimate his Department has made of (a) the total additional National Insurance an employee affected by the £2,000 salary sacrifice cap will pay by State Pension age and (b) the investment growth that sum would have earned if saved in a pension.

Susan Murray: [34817]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, what estimate his Department has made of the reduction in the value at State Pension age of the pension savings of an employee affected by the £2,000 salary sacrifice cap.

James Murray:
The Government has not made an estimate of the reduction in pension savings at State Pension age for an individual affected by the £2,000 salary sacrifice cap.

The impact on an individual's pension savings will depend on their circumstances, including their age, earnings, pension contributions, investment returns and how they and their employer respond to the change.

The Office for Budget Responsibility has published information on the methodology and assumptions underpinning the costing of the measure.

No 10 North: Hotels

Mike Wood: [36104]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, pursuant to the answer of 15 October 2026 to Question 20970 on No 10 North: Hotels, what is the gross cost to date for hotel

accommodation for No10 North staff, Ministers and special advisers since its opening, in relation to HM Treasury budgets.

Dan Tomlinson:
The cost to date of hotel accommodation for No10 North staff, Ministers and special advisers since its opening has been £4,514.34 in relation to HM Treasury budgets.

Public Houses: Sutton Coldfield

Sir Andrew Mitchell: [35999]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, what recent steps his Department has taken to support pubs in Royal Sutton Coldfield.

Dan Tomlinson:
The Government recognises the important contribution that pubs make to local communities, including in Royal Sutton Coldfield. The Government has taken steps to support the sector with eligible pubs benefiting from a 15 per cent business rates reduction from April 2026, followed by a further 20 per cent reduction for pubs, social clubs and qualifying live music venues from April 2027. Taken together, these measures are expected to save the typical pub around £3,100 in 2027-28.

We have also doubled the Hospitality Support Fund to £10m which will help rural pubs to diversify and ensure they can continue to be vital community hubs. We have also ended upward-only rent review clauses and new Community Right to Buy legislation will strengthen powers for local people to buy assets like hospitality venues and pubs before they are lost – keeping them in the hands of the community.

Public Sector: Borrowing

Dan Norris: [35163]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, what recent discussions he has had with the Office for Budgetary Responsibility on public borrowing.

Torsten Bell:
The Chancellor engages regularly with the OBR's Budget Responsibility Committee, including in preparation for fiscal events. The OBR publishes a log of substantive contact between the OBR and Ministers and their Special Advisers, alongside its Economic and Fiscal Outlook.

Revenue and Customs and Treasury: Remote Working

Dame Harriett Baldwin: [34332]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, what the average office attendance rate was for staff in (a) HM Treasury and (b) HM Revenue and Customs for each of the past three calendar years.

Dan Tomlinson:
HM Treasury's office attendance policy applies across all of its office locations. Employees are expected to spend a minimum of 60% of their working time in their

contractual workplace, unless alternative arrangements have been agreed through workplace adjustments.

Line managers are responsible for supporting and monitoring compliance with the department's office attendance expectations. Attendance data is not collated for individual offices as anonymised, aggregated building access data is used to understand overall occupancy levels and does not identify individual members of staff. HMT is currently reviewing its attendance monitoring regime in order to improve its accuracy.

Under HM Revenue and Customs' attendance monitoring regime, they are only able to provide the latest validated individual attendance rate data which cover the last two years, Sept 2024 – August 26.

September 24 - August 25: 78.5% of colleagues met their office attendance expectation.

September 25 - August 26: 85.6% of colleagues met their office attendance expectation.

Dame Harriett Baldwin: **[34334]**

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, what the average office attendance rate on Fridays was for staff in (a) HM Treasury and (b) HM Revenue and Customs for each of the past three calendar years.

Dan Tomlinson:
HM Treasury's office attendance policy applies across all of its office locations. Employees are expected to spend a minimum of 60% of their working time in their contractual workplace, unless alternative arrangements have been agreed through workplace adjustments.

Line managers are responsible for supporting and monitoring compliance with the department's office attendance expectations. Attendance data is not collated for individual offices as anonymised, aggregated building access data is used to understand overall occupancy levels and does not identify individual members of staff. HMT is currently reviewing its attendance monitoring regime in order to improve its accuracy.

Under HM Revenue and Customs' monitoring regime they are only able to provide the latest validated individual attendance rate data which cover the last two years, Sept 2024 – August 26.

September 24 - August 25: 37.4% colleagues worked from their office on a Friday

September 25 - August 26: 38.7% colleagues worked from their office on a Friday

Dame Harriett Baldwin: **[34337]**

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, which day of the working week had the lowest average office attendance rate among staff in (a) HM Treasury and (b) HM Revenue and Customs, for each of the past three years.

Dan Tomlinson:
Line managers are responsible for supporting and monitoring compliance with HM Treasury's office attendance expectations. Attendance data is not collated for individual offices as anonymised, aggregated building access data is used to understand overall occupancy levels and does not identify individual members of staff. Employees are expected to spend a minimum of 60% of their working time in their contractual workplace, unless alternative arrangements have been agreed through workplace adjustments.

HM Treasury is currently reviewing its attendance monitoring regime in order to improve its accuracy.

Under HM Revenue and Customs' monitoring regime they are only able to provide the latest validated individual attendance rate data which cover the last two years, Sept 2024 – August 26, which shows that fewer staff worked in the office on Fridays.

September 24 - August 25: 37.4% colleagues worked from their office on a Friday.

September 25 - August 26: 38.7% colleagues worked from their office on a Friday

Small Businesses: Corporation Tax

Peter Lamb: [34720]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, what steps are being considered for improving the corporation tax payment rate amongst small businesses.

James Murray:
In the 2025 Budget, the government announced new policies that raise £2.4 billion in additional tax revenue from closing the tax gap in 2029-30. This brings the total revenue from closing the tax gap announced this Parliament to £10 billion in 2029-30.

The Chancellor makes decisions on tax policy at fiscal events, and does not routinely comment on proposals.

Small Businesses: Credit Cards

Ben Maguire: [35054]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, whether his Department has made an assessment of the potential merits of requiring card payment providers to proactively offer small business customers the lowest rates for which they are eligible.

Lucy Rigby:
The Government recognises the importance of customers of financial services firms, including payment firms, receiving good outcomes.

A market review by the Payment Systems Regulator (PSR) found that the supply of card-acquiring services, which allow businesses to accept card payments, did not work well for small and medium-sized merchants and large merchants with annual card turnover up to £50 million.

In response, the PSR introduced new rules to improve outcomes for small businesses. These include personalised summary boxes containing key price and non-price information; online quotation tools; and messages prompting businesses to shop around or switch. It also introduced an 18-month maximum duration for point-of-sale terminal lease and rental contracts, followed by rolling monthly contracts. These measures are intended to help businesses compare offers and reduce barriers to switching.

Furthermore, the PSR has also recently introduced a set of requirements on the information that Mastercard and Visa must supply to card acquirers when setting certain fee levels that may be passed down to small businesses. This should help reduce unnecessary operational costs, support more accurate billing and pricing to small businesses, and help card acquirers and small businesses make better-informed choices about optional services and behavioural fees.

The Financial Conduct Authority's Consumer Duty also requires firms to act to deliver good outcomes for retail customers. The FCA has confirmed that the Duty applies to card acquirers serving micro-enterprises and charities with annual income below £1 million. The FCA expects firms to give customers the information they need, at the right time and in a way they can understand.

Tax Avoidance

Neil Duncan-Jordan: [34941]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, how many cases of death and serious injury of people facing HMRC action for disguised remuneration cases has HMRC referred to the Independent Office of Police Conduct.

James Murray:
As of 22 October 2026, HMRC has made 41 death or serious injury referrals to the Independent Office for Police Conduct (IOPC) involving separate individuals who had used a disguised remuneration scheme.

The government and HMRC take the safeguarding of individuals extremely seriously. HMRC has a statutory obligation to refer incidents of death or serious injury of a customer where there is an indication that HMRC contact may have directly or indirectly contributed to the event.

Following each referral, HMRC has conducted internal investigations and has found no evidence of misconduct by any HMRC officer. HMRC is taking forward organisational learning to strengthen the support provided to individuals who need extra help.

Neil Duncan-Jordan: [34942]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, what assessment he has made of the value-for-money to the taxpayer of the Loan Charge.

Neil Duncan-Jordan: [34943]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, how many outstanding disguised remuneration cases he expects will be settled as a result of the new settlement offer following the McCann Review.

James Murray:
Tax avoidance deprives the Exchequer of funds needed to deliver vital public services and it is right that HMRC target their resources to stop this.

The Loan Charge was intended to encourage those who had used disguised remuneration loan schemes to settle their affairs before it came into effect. HMRC estimates that £2.3 billion of these liabilities had been paid, largely by customers who agreed a contract settlement before the Loan Charge arose.

There are are around 32,000 individuals and 5,000 employers with outstanding or unresolved Loan Charge liabilities in scope of the Loan Charge Settlement Scheme, with liabilities estimated to be around £3.6 billion in total(£1.7 billion and £1.9 billion respectively).

Treasury: Translation Services

Sir John Hayes: [34873]

To ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer, how much HMRC spent on interpreters and related translation services in (1) 2022, (2) 2023, (3) 2024 and (4) 2025.

James Murray:
The information requested can be found in the tables below.

Translation

FY	SPEND
FY22/23	£393,566.21
FY23/24	£589,212.67
FY24/25	£641,494.83
FY25/26	£546,422.61

Interpreting

FY	SPEND
FY22/23	£590,484.28
FY23/24	£602,185.23
FY24/25	£596,363.74

FY	SPEND
FY25/26	£584,199.35

WALES

Pensioners: Social Security Benefits

Andrew Ranger: [35481]

To ask the Secretary of State for Wales, what steps he is taking to improve take-up of Pension Credit and Housing Benefit among eligible pensioners in Wales; and what discussions he has had with the Welsh Government and local authorities on coordinating efforts to increase take-up of those benefits and Council Tax Reduction.

Stephen Kinnock:
Maximising Pension Credit take-up is a key Government priority. The Government has been running its biggest ever Pension Credit take-up campaign across Great Britain, encouraging pensioners and their families to check their eligibility and make a claim.

This has been reinforced through the autumn campaign and Pension Credit Week of Action from 12 October, including advertising across television, radio, print and social media, supported by media partnerships and social media influencers.

Around 660,000 leaflets are also being distributed to selected households across Great Britain, and DWP continues to work closely with partners and local authorities to support the campaign.

DWP is also bringing together the administration of pensioner Housing Benefit and Pension Credit to deliver a more joined-up service, improve access to financial support and help ensure that more pensioners receive all the benefits to which they are entitled. Council Tax Reduction is devolved in Wales.

My department continues to engage with the Welsh Government and relevant partners to ensure that reserved and devolved support works effectively for people in Wales.

WOMEN AND EQUALITIES

Conversion Therapy: Prosecutions

Tom Hayes: [30654]

To ask the Minister for Women and Equalities, when she expects to introduce the Conversion Practices Bill formally to Parliament.

Tom Hayes: [31475]

To ask the Minister for Women and Equalities, what her planned timetable is for the next steps following publication of the draft Conversion Practices Bill.

Simon Lightwood:
The draft Bill will be undergoing pre-legislative scrutiny until 22 January, when the Joint Committee will share its recommendations with the Government.

We will consider the Committee's recommendations carefully and respond to them, after which we will introduce legislation when Parliamentary time allows.

WORK AND PENSIONS

[Subject Heading to be Assigned]

Steff Aquarone: [901515]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what steps his Department is taking to encourage businesses to recruit young people.

Lilian Greenwood:
This Government is committed to backing young people, bringing down the number of those who are not learning or earning and incentivising the hiring of new talent. We are investing an additional £2.5 billion by 2029 through the Youth Guarantee and the Growth and Skills Levy. This investment will support almost one million young people and create up to 500,000 opportunities to earn and learn, including unlocking up to 200,000 opportunities for employment. The Government is also committing to over £1bn to deliver training opportunities targeted at key industries, including £295m for 29 new Technical Excellence Colleges that will serve over 100,000 students and deepen employer partnerships.

Through the Youth Guarantee, we are encouraging:

- businesses to take on new talent through a new Youth Guarantee Gateway

- additional work experience and training opportunities

- a £3,000 Youth Jobs Grant

- a £2,000 apprenticeship hiring payment for employers

- a fully funded six-month job for long-term unemployed 18–24-year-olds

Employers are also not required to pay Employer National Insurance Contributions for employees under-21 and for apprentices under-25, on earnings up to £50,270.

Access to Work Programme

Dr Allison Gardner: [31927]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what assessment he has made of the effectiveness and accessibility of Access to Work support.

Sir Stephen Timms:
Access to Work is a government scheme which provides grant funding to disabled people, as well as those with a health condition enabling them to start and stay in work. The Department is making improvements to the Access to Work scheme and to manage these improvements, we have engaged in extensive discussion with stakeholders to make sure the needs of customers are met.

The Department published a new Access to Work research report, in June 2026, Journeys to Access to Work, which was delivered by NatCen and builds on earlier research with Access to Work customers and employers. The report summarises applicants' and employers' journeys to Access to Work, their experiences of the application process and delivery of the scheme, perceptions of its impact and recommendations for improvement.

We announced in May 2026 our commitment to deliver an Access to Work that is timely, efficient, and can meet new levels of demand by employing nearly 500 additional staff. It will help to restore confidence in the capability of the Scheme to award the right support at the right time and sets a pathway towards further improvements.

Recruitment commenced as planned in September 2026, with new colleagues joining in cohorts through to December 2026. As these recruits move through coaching, consolidation and accreditation, we expect productivity to increase progressively over the following six months.

Bus Services: Concessions

Greg Smith: [35530]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, pursuant to the Answer of 14 October 2026 to Question 30027 on Bus Services: Concessions, which (a) programmes and (b) budgets within his Department will be reprioritised to fund the cost of extending free bus travel for disabled people in 2027-28; and how much funding will be reallocated from each.

Andrew Western:
The £60 million funding for Free bus travel 24/7 for disabled people comes from existing Department for Work and Pensions (DWP) and Department for Transport (DfT) budgets. It is made up of a £40 million contribution from DWP, and a £20 million contribution from DfT. The precise budgets for 2027/28 that will support this measure will be agreed through DWPs internal allocations process, which will conclude ahead of the new financial year.

Carer's Allowance: Hamilton and Clyde Valley

Imogen Walker: [33051]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, how many people in Hamilton and Clyde Valley constituency receive Carer's Allowance.

Sir Stephen Timms:
In Scotland, Carer's Allowance has been replaced by Carer Support Payment.

Carer's Allowance is devolved to the Scottish Parliament. Social Security Scotland publishes Carer Support Payment statistics, but the published dataset does not provide a Westminster parliamentary constituency breakdown.

Department for Work and Pensions: Public Expenditure

Ben Obese-Jecty: [35040]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, with reference to The Defence Investment Plan Funding explainer, published on 30 June 2026, whether his Department is required to contribute to the funding laid out under line 5, to reduce departmental capital budgets by one per cent.

Andrew Western:
The Ministry of Defence and HM Treasury will provide any further information on the funding of the Defence Investment Plan in the normal way in due course.

Disability: Children

Mr Andrew Snowden: [33919]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what support his Department provides for families with severely disabled children under three who need a suitable vehicle to transport their child and specialist mobility equipment.

Mr Andrew Snowden: [33924]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, whether he plans to reinstate or replace the Family Fund Mobility Support programme.

Sir Stephen Timms:
Disability Living Allowance for Children (DLAc) is a tax-free, non-contributory and non-means-tested extra-costs benefit. It provides a contribution to the extra costs associated with being disabled to those under the age of 16 who, due to a disability or health condition, have mobility issues and/or care needs which are substantially in excess of a child the same age without the disability or health condition.

DLAc claimants must have needs substantially greater than their non-disabled counterparts. The higher rate mobility component is payable from age three. The lower rate mobility component is payable from age five. Only children over the age of three can claim the mobility component of DLA, as all younger children have substantial mobility needs.

There are no current proposals to change the existing age restrictions for the mobility component of DLAc. Children under three, however, can still access other forms of support, including the care component of DLAc, which can be paid from the age of three months.

The Family Fund Mobility Support Programme, funded by the Motability Foundation, operated from 2018 to 2026 and supported more than 1,800 families with disabled children under three, including through a funding commitment announced in 2022 of £5 million per year for three years, helping provide access to leased vehicles before families became eligible for the main Motability Scheme, the programme closed after the funding came to an end and the Motability Foundation has not committed to continuing this support. We are continuing discussions with the Family Fund on how best to support children with these needs in the future.

Disability: Leicester East

Shivani Raja: [34657]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what steps his Department is taking to support disabled residents and families in Leicester East constituency.

Sir Stephen Timms:
The Department is taking multiple steps to support disabled residents and families across the country, including in Leicester East.

Financial support is available to people on low or no incomes through benefits, including additional support through Universal Credit for disabled adults, children and young people via the UC Health Element and the Disabled Child Addition. For disabled people looking to start, stay or succeed in work, Access to Work provides a demand-led personalised grant to support recruitment and retention in employment. We have also put in place the equivalent of over 1,000 full-time Pathways to Work advisers across Great Britain, offering tailored employment support.

Locally, through Jobcentre Plus and partnerships with local providers, we provide a range of support for disabled residents. This includes Connect to Work, our voluntary supported employment programme (more information is available here: Connect to Work for job seekers | Leicestershire County Council). We also deliver outreach through Belgrave Library and St Barnabas Library, alongside Family and Community Work Coaches who provide benefit and employment advice. Leicester Jobcentre Plus works closely with Connect to Work, WorkWell, Talking Therapies and Mental Health Individual Placement Support services to help disabled people access employment and health support. In addition, Schools Advisers and Disability Employment Advisers work with Leicester College, Gateway College and Ellesmere College to support disabled young people through Supported Internships and their transition into employment.

Disability: Veterans

Imogen Walker: [35204]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what steps his Department is taking to improve access to specialist employment support for disabled veterans in South Lanarkshire.

Andrew Western:
The Department for Work and Pensions supports disabled veterans in South Lanarkshire through a dedicated Armed Forces Champion (AFC) covering the local Jobcentre Plus district. The AFC provides tailored employment and health-related support, benefits advice, and assistance in overcoming barriers to work, helping disabled veterans access the support and services available to them.

Disabled veterans may be eligible for a range of support, including disability and health-related benefits, income-related benefits and compensation schemes for injuries or illnesses attributable to military service. The AFC also supports veterans by connecting them with local partners and specialist organisations. By developing strong links with services such as Defence Medical Welfare Services, Veterans First Point and Lanarkshire Armed Services Advice, we are better able to support veterans through coordinated referrals, helping them access the specialist assistance they need and reducing barriers to support.

The AFC also participates in the Lanarkshire Firm Base, led by North and South Lanarkshire local authorities, which brings together local government, the Armed Forces, NHS services, charities, and employers to promote the aims of the Armed Forces Covenant and support serving personnel, veterans, and their families. Participation in this network enables us to raise awareness of the Armed Forces Champion role, strengthen relationships with key partners, identify additional sources of support for veterans, and develop collaborative opportunities that enhance the range and quality of services available to the Armed Forces community.

Through attendance at these meetings, we have identified a newly launched Veterans Hub run by an Armed Forces charity supporting members of the Armed Forces community with their mental health. We are exploring opportunities for future partnership working, including the potential to deliver support and engagement activities within the Hub and strengthen referral pathways for veterans.

Employment

Sarah Olney: **[36055]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what changes there have been in levels of employment between 2024 and 2026.

Andrew Western:
The independent Office for National Statistics publish data on the levels of employment in the UK. This can be found here: A01: Summary of labour market statistics - Office for National Statistics.

Employment Schemes: Disability

Liz Jarvis: **[31743]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what assessment he has made of whether Work Coach and Disability Employment Adviser support is effective for people

with a visual impairment, and whether any evaluation has looked at differences in outcomes of such support between people with different types of disability.

Sir Stephen Timms:
The Department for Work and Pensions is committed to ensuring disabled people, including those who are blind or visually impaired, can access appropriate support from Jobcentre Plus.

All staff complete mandatory learning on the Public Sector Equality Duty, including the protected characteristics covered by the Equality Act and the Department's responsibilities for providing reasonable adjustments. Work Coaches and Disability Employment Advisers receive further learning on disability, its potential impact on customers and the practical steps they can take to provide appropriate support. This includes specific content on blindness and visual impairment, helping colleagues understand the barriers customers may face and the support and reasonable adjustments available.

Disability Employment Advisers provide specialist support, helping Work Coaches and Pathways to Work Advisers tailor support to individual customer needs. They can also work directly with customers and engage with employers, local communities and third-sector organisations to help facilitate appropriate local support and promote initiatives including Disability Confident, WorkWell, Connect to Work and Access to Work.

The Department has also worked with Microsoft to develop Accessibility Fundamentals learning, delivered to over 25,000 frontline colleagues, to improve understanding of how Microsoft accessibility tools can support disabled jobseekers. Every Jobcentre also has access to a District Provision Toolkit, providing links to local specialist support for customers with a range of complex needs and circumstances.

We continue to engage disability organisations through the Reasonable Adjustment Forum, using their insight to identify, test and recommend improvements to the accessibility of our services. This has included working with organisations representing a range of disabled people to improve the accessibility and language of the alternative-format screen in Universal Credit.

Employment Schemes: Leicester East

Shivani Raja: [34653]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what steps his Department is taking to provide targeted employment support in Leicester East constituency.

Andrew Western:
In Leicester East, Jobcentre Plus works closely with local partners to provide targeted support for groups facing additional barriers to employment. This includes dedicated youth employability support through the city's Connexions Hub and Leicester City FC's Youth Hub, which your constituents can access, alongside outreach activity in community settings such as day centres and libraries. Support includes personalised employment advice, access to skills and training opportunities, apprenticeship

signposting, and specialist help for disabled people, care leavers and those with complex needs.

The department forecasts customer cohort volumes to anticipate the level of support and work coach resource required. Work Coaches offer personalised advice to help individuals secure roles that reflect their skills, qualifications and prior experience, alongside targeted job-search support. Where appropriate, Work Coaches also identify any skills gaps and signpost jobseekers to relevant training and provision.

For those who have been on Universal Credit for 6 months or more, the Restart Scheme provides 12 months of personalised and tailored support to help them move into work. The scheme is delivered across England and Wales.

The Government is investing an additional £2.5 billion by 2029 into the Youth Guarantee and the Growth and Skills Levy.

For those disabled people, individuals with long-term health conditions and people with more complex barriers to employment who need intensive, specialist support, Connect to Work, our £1 billion voluntary Supported Employment programme, is available across England and Wales. It will deliver tailored support to around 300,000 by the end of the decade.

Learners in all areas of England, including Leicester East, may benefit from ASF-funded provision where eligible. This can include English, maths, essential digital skills, employability provision, sector-based training and Free Courses for Jobs, helping adults to develop the skills needed to progress into employment or improve their prospects in the labour market.

Logistics: Employment

Mr Paul Foster: **[35202]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what steps his Department is taking to work with the logistics sector to improve employment outcomes for prison leavers.

Andrew Western:
DWP works with employers across the logistics sector to help prison leavers into work. Logistics is a sector where there is a high potential for prison leavers to fill skills shortages across the economy and to drive good growth in every postcode.

DWP works closely with HM Prison and Probation Service's New Futures Network (NFN), the prison service's specialist employment team, which brokers employment opportunities for prison leavers. This includes strategic partnerships with major employers in skills shortage sectors including logistics with employers such as GXO and Morrisons.

Ministry of Justice figures show that employment outcomes for prison leavers continue to improve, with 36.5% of prison leavers in employment six months after release in the year to March 2026, compared with 34.5% in the previous year.

Offshore Industry: Health and Safety

Brian Leishman: [34432]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what recent discussions he has had with Cabinet colleagues regarding the impact of a safe weight limit on workers in the offshore oil and gas industry.

Brian Leishman: [34434]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, when his department was informed that employers in the offshore oil and gas industry were seeking to introduce a safe weight limit on offshore oil and gas workers.

Brian Leishman: [34437]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what discussions he has had with (a) trade unions, (b) employers and (c) Cabinet colleagues regarding the introduction of a safe weight limit on offshore oil and gas workers.

Brian Leishman: [34439]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, if an assessment has been made of the effect that the introduction of a safe weight limit on offshore oil and gas workers from 1 November this year will have on the objectives in the (a) North Sea Future and (b) Clean Energy Jobs Plans.

Brian Leishman: [34441]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, when his department was informed by employers that the industry was seeking to introduce a safe weight limit on offshore oil and gas workers being transported to installations by helicopter.

Sir Stephen Timms:

Offshore Energies United Kingdom (OEUK) is a trade association that represents the United Kingdom's (UK) offshore energy industry. OEUK introduced an industry-led Safe Weight Limit Policy (SWLP) for offshore workers on oil and gas installations in order to manage the risk associated with exceeding specified weight limits and maximum lifting capacities on the UK's search and rescue helicopters. The risks around safe weight limits were raised by the Maritime and Coastguard Agency (MCA).

In 2025, OEUK held a workshop with member companies, subject matter experts across aviation, marine and emergency response disciplines, trade unions, trade associations, HM Coastguard and helicopter operators, to discuss and identify the hazards and risks presented by a heavier workforce. OEUK provided HSE with a copy of the final draft of its guidance on its Safe Weight Limit Policy once its members had agreed to implement it.

HSE was first made aware that industry were looking to introduce a safe weight limit in June 2025. HSE provided comment to OEUK on technical aspects of the guidance relating to occupational health legislation and International Maritime Organisation (IMO) Safety of Life at Sea (SOLAS) standards. HSE, along with other industry

stakeholders, was kept informed of the intention to implement an industry policy on safe weight limit, through regular attendance at a number of industry forums. HSE was not a consultee on the decision to implement the safe weight limit and was not involved in the development of the policy.

Personal Independence Payment: Medical Examinations

Daniel Zeichner: [34983]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, whether the impact evaluation of Transformed Decision Making in Personal Independence Payment will be published before a decision is taken on wider rollout.

Daniel Zeichner: [34986]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, whether his Department will publish outcomes under Transformed Decision Making broken down by primary disabling condition.

Daniel Zeichner: [34987]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what assessment his Department has made of the impact of Transformed Decision Making on the volume of mandatory reconsiderations and appeals and the resulting cost impact to HM Courts and Tribunals Service.

Sir Stephen Timms:
The Department is currently testing an operational change to decision making in PIP, as part of the Health Transformation Programme, now known as Evidence-led Decision Making. The Department is also undertaking preparatory work so that scaling can take place next year, if the evidence and operational readiness support that approach. No assessment of the impact of the change on mandatory reconsiderations and appeals has been made at this point. Evaluation activity is continuing and future implementation decisions will continue to be informed by emerging evidence. We will publish the evaluation evidence in due course and we will look at the feasibility of including a breakdown of outcomes by primary disabling condition as we collect more data to enable this analysis.

Social Security Benefits

Dr Ben Spencer: [31694]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, how many claims were referred for investigation by AI or machine-learning models in each year since 2023; what proportion were upheld; and what the referral and outcome rates were by protected characteristic.

Lilian Greenwood:
The Department does not use artificial intelligence or machine learning models to refer claims directly for fraud investigation.

The Department has strong controls in place to tackle fraud and deliver savings. Since the Autumn Budget 2024 we have committed to delivering gross savings of £14.6bn up to the end of 2030 – 31 from fraud, error and debt activity.

Our activities include:

- investments to deploy up to 3,000 additional staff within counter fraud teams,
- the extension of Targeted Case Reviews (TCR) in Universal Credit to check accuracy of claims at risk of being incorrect,
- implementation of Pension Credit Claim Reviews (PCCR) to check claims at risk of being incorrect,
- the introduction of the Public Authorities (Fraud, Error and Recovery) Act 2025 (PAFER) which introduces new powers to better identify, prevent and deter fraud and error
- and continuing to seek prosecutions in the courts for those who commit benefit fraud.

Overall, levels of benefit fraud are the lowest since the pandemic and currently stand at 2.2%, compared to a peak of 3.0% in FYE 2022. This demonstrates that the Department has strong controls in place to tackle fraud and deliver savings.

Tom Morrison: **[32614]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what procedures apply where a claimant's email address is recorded by the DWP but a contractor acting on behalf of the DWP is unable to verify or use that email address.

Sir Stephen Timms:
Assessment suppliers are only allowed to use email as a method of communication when it has been agreed by DWP as a reasonable adjustment. Where a contractor acting on behalf of the Department receives notification that an email to a claimant has not been delivered, they will check that the email address held is correct. If necessary, the email will be resent using the correct address. Where the address is confirmed as correct and delivery remains unsuccessful, the contractor will contact the Department to investigate further. Suppliers will also try other methods of communication available to them to establish contact with the customer, if possible.

Social Security Benefits: Fraud

Sir Christopher Chope: **[34725]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, for what reason his department has withdrawn its published guidance on the benefits fraud investigation process.

Lilian Greenwood:
[Holding answer 19 October 2026]: The "Fraud Investigations: Staff Guide May 2019" was withdrawn from the Gov.uk website because the guide was no longer in use.

The Department continually reviews its operational guidance and processes to ensure they remain effective and up to date, making changes where necessary to reflect emerging risks, operational learning, and opportunities for improvement.

Social Security Benefits: Leicester East

Shivani Raja: [34651]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what assessment he has made of trends in the level of welfare spending in Leicester East constituency.

Shivani Raja: [34652]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what assessment he has made of trends in the level of Universal Credit expenditure in Leicester East constituency.

Sir Stephen Timms:
Spending on benefits within each parliamentary constituency can be found in DWP's Benefit Expenditure by parliamentary constituency publication: Benefit expenditure and caseload tables 2025 - GOV.UK.

Social Security Benefits: Medical Examinations

Tom Morrison: [32207]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what service standards apply to complaints concerning the Health Assessment Advisory Service; and what mechanisms exist where a claimant is unable to access or progress the contractor's complaints process.

Tom Morrison: [32208]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what steps his Department is taking to ensure Maximus's compliance with reasonable-adjustment requirements when delivering the Health Assessment Advisory Service.

Tom Morrison: [33038]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what contractual requirements apply to the creation, retention and availability of assessor consultation notes, paper-based review notes and audio recordings of PIP assessments.

Sir Stephen Timms:
Information on the contractual requirements for the creation, retention and availability of assessor consultation notes, paper-based review notes and audio recordings is set out in pages 207 to 212 of the Functional Assessment Service (FAS) contract and available here.

The Department for Work and Pensions (DWP) holds Health Assessment Advisory Service (HAAS) suppliers to a robust set of contractual performance measures. Suppliers are required to meet a series of Target Performance Levels (TPLs), which are monitored through management information, performance reviews and governance arrangements. Where performance falls below the required standard,

contractual remedies, including improvement plans and financial measures, may be applied.

The TPLs and wider contractual obligations are set out in the FAS contract, which is published on Contracts Finder and available here.

The Department and its assessment suppliers are committed to ensuring that claimants are treated fairly, sensitively and with respect throughout the assessment process. Suppliers are contractually required to consider and, where reasonably practicable, provide reasonable adjustments to support claimants' needs. Compliance is monitored through contractual performance measures, including TPL11, which assesses the extent to which reasonable adjustment requests are met.

Further information on reasonable adjustments is available in the Personal Independence Payment Assessment Guide which is accessible here.

The Department continues to monitor supplier performance and keep its processes under review to ensure assessment services remain accessible and supportive for all claimants.

State Retirement Pensions: Uprating

James McMurdock: [34752]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, with reference to the letter to hon. Members entitled The future of the Triple Lock, dated 13 October 2026, what estimate he has made of the annual difference in State Pension payments per pensioner under the (a) adjusted and (b) existing Triple Lock in each financial year from 2030-31 to 2039-40.

Torsten Bell:
I refer the hon. Member to the answer I gave on 21 October 2026 to Question UIN 34753.

Universal Credit

Mr Lee Dillon: [34748]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what procedures his Department has in place to support Universal Credit claimants experiencing immediate financial hardship while errors in their earnings calculations are being investigated.

Sir Stephen Timms:
Universal Credit claimants experiencing immediate financial hardship while an earnings issue is under investigation are encouraged to contact the Department. Staff will consider the claimant's individual circumstances and discuss support available. Where an error affecting entitlement is identified, the Department, working with HMRC/Employers where appropriate, will correct the earnings at the earliest opportunity.

Mr Andrew Snowden: [35740]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, how many Universal Credit claimants in the searching for work conditionality group have been claiming continuously for (a) 6 to 12 months, (b) one to two years, (c) two to five years and (d) more than five years.

Andrew Western:
Monthly statistics showing the number of people on Universal Credit (UC) by conditionality group and UC claim duration are published every three months in the People on Universal Credit dataset on Stat-Xplore, and the statistics are currently available to May 2026.

Users can log in or access Stat-Xplore as a guest and, if needed, can access guidance on how to extract information. There is also a Universal Credit Official Statistics: Stat-Xplore user guide.

Universal Credit: Mental Illness

Neil O'Brien: [33780]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, with reference to Figure 9 of the Department's publication Universal Credit Work Capability Assessment statistics, April 2019 to March 2026 and the response to FOI2026/95977, how many Universal Credit Work Capability Assessment decisions for non-ESA transition claimants in the period covered by that figure recorded "Mental Health Problem" as their only medical condition overall.

Neil O'Brien: [33781]

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, with reference to Figure 9 of the Department's publication Universal Credit Work Capability Assessment statistics, April 2019 to March 2026 and the response to FOI2026/95977, how many Universal Credit Work Capability Assessment decisions for non-ESA transition claimants in the period covered by that figure recorded "Mental Health Problem" as their only condition within the Mental and Behavioural Disorders ICD-10 chapter.

Sir Stephen Timms:
879,800 Universal Credit Work Capability Assessment decisions for non-ESA transition claimants in the period April 2019 to March 2026 recorded "Mental Health Problem" as their only condition within the Mental and Behavioural Disorders ICD-10 chapter.

Of those, 143,100 recorded "Mental Health Problem" as their only medical condition overall.

Notes:

1. Medical condition is based on evidence recorded at the WCA. An LCWRA recommendation at WCA is established when a claimant meets any one of the relevant qualifying descriptors, which are applied on a "met / not met" basis. This

means the assessment can be concluded before all health conditions are discussed and recorded.

1. Cases in which, due to evidence provided, a decision can be made without an interview-based or paper-based WCA have no medical condition information available on the analytical system data. These filework cases can relate to claimants who are severely or terminally ill, or have other complex conditions and thus may not be representative of the cohort of known medical conditions.

1. Claimants often have complex health issues and can thus be recorded with multiple conditions. Primary conditions are not identified.

1. The figures have been rounded to the nearest 100 and the data supplied is based on bespoke analysis of departmental datasets and has not been certified as National Statistics or Official Statistics.

Universal Credit: Musculoskeletal Disorders

Neil O'Brien: **[33779]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, with reference to Figure 9 of the Department's publication Universal Credit Work Capability Assessment statistics, April 2019 to March 2026 and to the response to FOI2026/95977, how many Universal Credit Work Capability Assessment decisions for non-ESA transition claimants were recorded for each of the 10 most common individual conditions within the ICD-10 chapter "Diseases of Musculoskeletal System and Connective Tissue" in the most recent period covered by that figure.

Sir Stephen Timms:
This table details the 10 most frequently recorded conditions in the medical condition group 'Diseases of Musculoskeletal System and Connective Tissue (M00 - M99)' for UC WCA decisions, excluding Employment and Support Allowance transitions, January 2022 to February 2026; as aligned with Universal Credit Work Capability Assessment statistics, April 2019 to March 2026 - GOV.UK

CONDITION	VOLUME OF WCA DECISIONS
Musculoskeletal problem	546,100
Back Problem	99,200
Back Pain	91,200
Fibromyalgia	80,300
Hand problem	52,400
Knee Problem	51,400
Leg Problem	46,600

CONDITION	VOLUME OF WCA DECISIONS
Shoulder Problem	43,100
Osteoarthritis	31,400
Arm Problem	30,100

Notes:

1. Medical condition is based on evidence recorded at the WCA. An LCWRA recommendation at WCA is established when a claimant meets any one of the relevant qualifying descriptors, which are applied on a “met / not met” basis. This means the assessment can be concluded before all health conditions are discussed and recorded.
1. Cases in which, due to evidence provided, a decision can be made without an interview-based or paper-based WCA have no medical condition information available on the analytical system data. These filework cases can relate to claimants who are severely or terminally ill, or have other complex conditions and thus may not be representative of the cohort of known medical conditions.
1. Claimants often have complex health issues and can thus be recorded with multiple conditions. Primary conditions are not identified.
1. The figures have been rounded to the nearest 100 and the data supplied is based on bespoke analysis of departmental datasets and has not been certified as National Statistics or Official Statistics.

Work Capability Assessment

Lisa Smart: **[34910]**

To ask the Secretary of State for Work and Pensions, what the average waiting time is for existing claimants awaiting a work capability reassessment; and what steps he is taking to reduce that time.

Sir Stephen Timms:
Demand for initial Work Capability Assessment (WCA) assessments has risen so we continue to prioritise initial claims. This enables us to ensure that claimants receive the right level of benefit, and we establish capability for work at the outset of a claim.

The department is taking a number of steps to increase the capacity of the Health Assessment Advisory Service to deliver WCAs, including reassessments for existing Universal Credit (UC) claimants. This includes the recruitment and training of additional healthcare professionals across all assessment suppliers, alongside improvements to workforce planning to better align available resources with demand. The department continues to monitor assessment volumes closely and works with suppliers to ensure sufficient capacity is in place to reduce waiting times and support timely reassessment activity.

The department prioritises WCAs for new claims in order to minimise waiting times and ensure that individuals receive the correct benefit entitlement as early as possible. We recognise that some existing claimants may experience delays when awaiting reassessment and continue to keep the impact of these arrangements under review while taking steps to improve overall assessment capacity and reduce waiting times.

As of 1st October 2026, the average waiting time for a WCA reassessment was 272 working days. Claimants awaiting reassessment continue to receive their existing rate of benefit in the meantime. Where a reassessment results in entitlement to a higher rate of benefit, any increase due will be backdated in line with the date entitlement arose.

Please Note

- Figure has been rounded to the nearest whole number.
- Information on the average waiting time for existing claimants awaiting a WCA reassessment is derived from unpublished management information produced by assessment suppliers for internal departmental use and is not routinely published as official statistics.

MINISTERIAL CORRECTIONS

CABINET OFFICE

AI Security Institute: Staff

Dr Ben Spencer: [30890]

To ask the Minister for the Cabinet Office, what is the (a) current and (b) planned (i) headcount and (ii) FTE staffing for the AI Security Institute.

An error has been identified in the written answer given on 19 October 2026. The correct answer should have been:

Kanishka Narayan:
The headcount of the AI Security Institute is 24 **3** ~~1~~, equivalent to 2 **27.8** ~~11.2~~ full time equivalent (FTE) posts (as **at** ~~of~~ 12 October 2026). This includes over 100 ~~members of~~ technical frontier AI specialists in the ~~AI Security~~ Institute's Research Unit.

The **AI Security** Institute's future staffing is managed in line with the budget it **w** ~~h~~ as allocated in the Spending Review, and is kept under regular review so that it is resourced to deliver its priorities.

WRITTEN STATEMENTS

BUSINESS, INNOVATION, SCIENCE AND TRADE

Update following Round 6 of negotiations on an enhanced Free Trade Agreement with Turkey

Parliamentary Under-Secretary of State (Minister for Reindustrialisation) (Blair McDougall): [HCWS403]

My Honourable Friend the Minister for Trade, Department for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade (Lord Sarwar) has today made the following Statement.

The sixth round of negotiations on an enhanced Free Trade Agreement with Turkey took place in London between 28 September and 2 October 2026.

International trade is central to the Government's ambition to deliver good growth in every part of the UK. The UK and Turkey already enjoy a strong trading relationship, with total trade reaching £28.3 billion in 2025, an increase of 3.9% on the previous year. By building on this foundation, we can help unlock new opportunities for businesses, workers and consumers across the UK.

Negotiations were constructive, with positive progress being made in a number of areas:

Trade in Services

Sessions were held across a range of important areas, including digital trade and investment. UK negotiators continued to pursue ambitious outcomes across these areas and beyond, seeking an FTA that supports the UK's world-leading services suppliers. Text-based discussions on digital trade, domestic regulation and investment took place. We look forward to continuing discussions across trade in services over the coming months.

Trade in Goods

Negotiations covered a range of market access and regulatory issues, including Goods Market Access and Sanitary and Phytosanitary measures. Discussions focused on reviewing respective proposals, recognising regulatory equivalence and reviewing audit requirements, while maintaining and upholding the UK’s high standards. Both sides discussed their first tariff offers, alongside their respective market access interests and sensitivities. These sessions were productive, with both sides seeking an ambitious outcome that supports businesses and drives progress forward.

Additional areas

Further productive discussions took place across a number of chapters, including Intellectual Property, State-Owned Enterprises, Environment, Core Text, Government Procurement and Trade Remedies.

The UK will only ever sign a trade deal which aligns with the UK’s national interests, upholding our high standards across a range of sectors.

Both sides will work constructively towards the seventh round of negotiations in the coming months. Ministers will continue to update Parliament on progress as discussions with Turkey advance.

CABINET OFFICE

Strengthening community resilience across the UK

Minister of State (Security Minister) (Dan Jarvis): [HCWS409]

On 14 July 2026 the government published its annual update on the implementation of the Resilience Action Plan, outlining significant steps made to bolster the UK's resilience in the year following its publication. We also announced our intention to launch a campaign to raise awareness of the simple steps people can take to be ready for everyday emergencies.

The storms last winter and the wildfires this summer have shown how severe weather events can cause disruption to our everyday lives and impact the services we rely on, like phones, power, water and the internet. They have also shown the strength of our communities, the skill and bravery of our emergency services, and are a reminder that we can all play our part to keep ourselves, our loved ones, and our communities safe in times of emergency.

Since committing to launch a campaign, we have:

- published updated research that shows just 13% of people in the UK feel they're prepared for an emergency that could cut them off from the services they rely on, and that 84% want the Government to do more to share information about the steps they can take to increase their preparedness;
- met with international partners to gain insight about their efforts to improve household resilience; and
- engaged with more than five hundred organisations from across the country - ranging from emergency services, local authorities, businesses, voluntary community groups, charities, and advocacy organisations representing older people, disabled people, people with mental health needs, and people who rely on foodbanks - to help ensure our advice is simple, relatable, reassuring and meets communities' needs for a range of emergency scenarios.

I am therefore pleased to confirm that we have today published updated advice for households at GOV.UK/BeReady, and that members of the public will begin to see more information about what they can do, as part of a three-year campaign to 'Be Ready'.

The updated advice calls on households to be self-sufficient for three days in the case of an emergency and includes a checklist of simple steps people can take. This brings the UK into line with many of our European peers who also have the "three day" message at the heart of their campaign. There are two key actions:

- sign up to the Priority Services Register if they are eligible; and

- have three days of bottled water and non-perishable food stored at home.

Many simple steps on the website are completely free and items on the checklist can be gathered or ticked off overtime. For example, signing up to the Priority Services Register is a straightforward process that doesn't cost anything. Taking a few minutes to ensure eligible households are signed up ensures utility companies know who prioritise for additional support in an outage. We also understand that not everyone will be able to take all of the simple steps. This campaign is simply about providing basic advice on how to prepare, so people can take the steps that work for them. Our emergency services will be ready to respond when needed. And other charities, community organisations and services will be there too. Because when households take steps to look after themselves during an emergency, it reduces the strain on our emergency services. This ensures first responders can help those most in need first

As part of the steady campaign rollout we will also publish a partner toolkit with products and information that community groups and local businesses can use to share messages locally. 'Be Ready' has been developed by the UK Government, working closely with the Scottish Government, Welsh Government, and Northern Ireland Executive - as well as mayors and local councils - as we collectively seek to improve national resilience across all communities in the UK.

DIGITAL, CULTURE, MEDIA AND SPORT

Publication of White Paper on Critical Undersea Infrastructure Security and Resilience: Proposals for modernising the UK's legislation

Minister for Creative Industries, Media and Online Safety (Ian Murray): [HCWS404]

I would like to provide the House with an update on the government's work to strengthen the security and resilience of undersea infrastructure that is critical to the United Kingdom.

Today, the government is publishing a White Paper on **Critical Undersea Infrastructure Security and Resilience: Proposals for modernising the UK's legislation**. At the same time, we are launching a twelve-week public consultation on these proposals.

Critical Undersea Infrastructure (CUI) underpins services essential to the UK's security, economy and daily life. Subsea telecommunications cables carry approximately 99% of the UK's international data traffic, while subsea pipelines, interconnectors and other offshore energy infrastructure play a vital role in supporting the UK's energy needs. As reliance on this infrastructure grows, so too does the importance of ensuring it remains secure and resilient.

In April, the then Defence Secretary revealed that the UK's Armed Forces, working with allies, tracked Russian submarines tasked with surveying subsea cables. Incidents of this kind underline the global risks to CUI and the need for modern legal frameworks to protect it.

The Joint Committee on the National Security Strategy (JCNSS) has made clear that UK legislation has not kept pace with the growing importance of CUI or the risks it now faces. The government agrees. The principal offence for damaging subsea cables dates back to 1885, refers to 'telegraphic' communications, and makes limited provision for energy infrastructure. It no longer provides an adequate deterrent.

To address such deficiencies, the White Paper sets out detailed proposals for:

- a new criminal penalties regime to strengthen deterrence against harmful conduct affecting CUI;
- new security and resilience duties for providers of subsea telecoms cable systems and services;
- a new national security power to enable the government to require industry to take specified action where necessary and proportionate to ensure the security and resilience of subsea telecoms cable infrastructure and services; and
- a new regulatory framework to help ensure the secure deployment and operation of subsea sensing technologies.

Through our consultation, the government welcomes views from anyone with an interest in these proposals, including individuals, industry, academia, and civil society organisations. The responses will inform the development of future legislation. The White Paper contains 72 consultation questions covering the proposed framework.

The proposals are based principally on the reserved competences of telecommunications, national security and defence. The government recognises that some proposals will interact with devolved responsibilities, including environmental and marine management functions.

The White Paper has been presented to Parliament as a Command Paper and will be placed in the Libraries of both Houses. It is also published on the GOV.UK website.

EDUCATION

Progress towards improving children's outcomes, giving every child the best start in life

Parliamentary Under-Secretary of State (Minister for Early Education) (Paul Waugh): **[HCWS405]**

The government has today published the early years foundation stage profile (EYFSP) assessment data for the 2025/26 academic year.

The Government has set a national ambition for 75% of children in England to achieve a good level of development (GLD) by 2028, as set out in the *Giving Every Child the Best Start in Life* strategy. Achieving this ambition requires a collective effort across schools, early years providers, local authorities, health services and wider family support services, including Best Start Family Hubs, recognising that children's outcomes at the end of Reception are shaped by their learning and development throughout the early years.

Early childhood development is strongly associated with later outcomes, providing the foundation for achievements throughout school and beyond. Children who achieve a good level of development at age five are more likely to succeed at school and less likely to be not in education, employment or training (NEET) later in life.

The latest data shows strong progress towards this ambition, with 72.3% of children reaching a good level of development, an increase of 4 percentage points on last year. This brings the country significantly closer to the 2028 target and reflects the dedication and hard work of teachers, early years practitioners, school leaders, local authority teams and wider partners across England.

While this progress is encouraging, the gap between children eligible for free school meals and their peers widened slightly, underlining the importance of the whole system working together to ensure that all children benefit from continued improvement. Further progress will depend on schools, early years providers and local leaders using data and evidence to identify gaps, target support effectively and implement approaches proven to improve outcomes.

To support delivery of the national ambition, the Government has set local authority level targets. Publishing these targets provides greater transparency and accountability, while enabling local leaders to focus action where it will have the greatest impact for children.

The Government will continue to support local areas through delivery of Best Start local plans, investment in teaching and learning across the early years system, and action to strengthen support for children and families. Working across education, health and family services will be particularly important in improving outcomes for disadvantaged children and those most at risk of falling behind.

Today's results demonstrate the progress that can be achieved through collective effort. By building on this momentum and maintaining a focus on evidence-led improvement, we can move closer to our ambition of 75% of children reaching a good level of development by 2028 – a first step to ensure more children get the best possible start in life.

ENERGY SECURITY AND NET ZERO

The Renewables Obligation to Exchequer Scheme Expenditure: 1 July to 30 September 2026

Minister for Energy Consumers (Ms Polly Billington): **[HCWS408]**

I am making this statement to update hon. Members on expenditure incurred under section 13 of the Energy Prices Act 2022 (EPA), in accordance with the statutory requirement to provide quarterly reports to Parliament.

This quarterly report is required under section 14 of the EPA. It covers expenditure incurred from 1 July to 30 September 2026 under the Renewables Obligation to Exchequer scheme.

The Renewables Obligation to Exchequer scheme was announced at Autumn Budget 2025 as part of the Government’s package to reduce energy bills for households. It came

into effect on 1 April 2026 and will run for three years. Under the scheme, 75% of Renewables Obligation costs are removed from domestic electricity bills and funded instead by the Exchequer, thereby reducing costs for consumers.

The expenditure set out in this report relates to the delivery and operation of the scheme during this reporting period, as well as the cumulative spend to date.

£M	B) EXPENDITURE INCURRED BETWEEN 1 JULY TO 30 SEPTEMBER 2026	C) CUMULATIVE EXPENDITURE INCURRED TO 30 SEPTEMBER 2026
RO to Exchequer Scheme (GB)	£530,253,737.06	£1,050,963,025.28

NOTE: The expenditure figures set out above relate to Great Britain only, reflecting the territorial extent of this scheme, which applies in England, Scotland and Wales.

The figures in the table do not include administrative or running costs.

The expenditure incurred between 1 July and 30 September 2026 includes an adjustment for the first quarter of this financial year, reflecting the reconciliation between forecast and actual supply volumes. A reconciliation between forecast and actual supply volumes for the period 1 July to 30 September 2026 will be calculated, paid and reported as part of the Quarter 3 payment cycle.

All former energy affordability schemes under which s.13 EPA expenditure has been incurred have now closed, and their final expenditure positions have been fully reconciled. The table below sets out the cumulative expenditure incurred under those schemes.

PREVIOUS ENERGY AFFORDABILITY SCHEMES	ACTUAL CUMULATIVE EXPENDITURE INCURRED UP TO AN INCLUDING 30 TH JUNE 2026 (£M)	STATUS
Energy Bills Support Scheme GB & NI	11,874.00	Closed
Energy Bills Support Scheme Alternative Funding	59.47	Closed
Energy Price Guarantee GB & NI	24,075.00	Closed
Domestic Alternative Fuel Payment	401.20	Closed
Energy Bills Relief Scheme GB & NI	7,533.37	Closed

PREVIOUS ENERGY AFFORDABILITY SCHEMES	ACTUAL CUMULATIVE EXPENDITURE INCURRED UP TO AN INCLUDING 30 TH JUNE 2026 (£M)	STATUS
Energy Bills Discount Scheme GB & NI	481.79	Closed
Energy Bills Discount Scheme Heat Networks GB & NI	113.38	Closed
Non-Domestic Alternative Fuel Payment	62.30	Closed
RO to Exchequer (GB)	520.71	Open
Total (£ billion)	£45.1 billion	

Future costs

At Autumn Budget 2025, the expected cost of the Renewables Obligation to Exchequer policy was estimated as follows:

Exchequer impact (£m)

	2025-26	2026-27	2027-28	2028-29	2029-30	2030-31
Exchequer Impact	+0m	-2,580m	-2,100m	-2,195m	+0m	+0m

NOTE : Costs for the Renewables Obligation to Exchequer policy are based on forecasts costs of the overall Renewables Obligation scheme and an assumption of the proportion of electricity usage that relates to domestic consumption. Actual costs will vary depending on actual domestic supply volumes and the actual Renewables Obligation and buyout price.

FOREIGN, COMMONWEALTH AND DEVELOPMENT OFFICE

Six-monthly report on Hong Kong 1 January to 30 June 2026

Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs (Ed Miliband): **[HCWS407]**

The latest Six-monthly Report on the implementation of the Sino-British Joint Declaration on Hong Kong was published today and is attached. It covers the period from 1 January - 30 June 2026. The report has been placed in the Libraries of both Houses. A copy is also available on the Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office website:

https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/six-monthly-report-on-hong-kong-january-to-june-2026. I commend the report to the House .

Attachments:

1. 59th Six-monthly report on Hong Kong [59th Six-monthly report on Hong Kong.pdf]

HOUSING, COMMUNITIES AND LOCAL GOVERNMENT

Representation of the People Bill – Contingencies Fund Advance

Minister of State for Homelessness, Democracy, Communities and Faith (Florence Eshalomi): [HCWS406]

I hereby give notice of the Ministry of Housing, Communities and Local Government's intention to seek approval from HM Treasury for advance expenditure totalling £2,800,000.

This request follows the passage of the Representation of the People Bill, which is currently before Parliament and which the Government expects to receive Royal Assent by Spring 2027.

The funding for this work has already been provided through the Department's Spending Review settlement and does not represent new or additional spending. Approval for expenditure in advance of Royal Assent is required to enable the Department to commence essential digital development activity to implement the Bill's provisions, specifically the manifesto commitment to extend the franchise to 16- and 17-year-olds. Deferring this work until after Royal Assent would compress delivery timescales and increase the risk of delays to implementation.

The proposed expenditure will support the development of the digital infrastructure required to implement the legislation. This includes a secure service enabling eligible young people to register to vote using data held by the Department for Education as part of appropriate identity checks. It will also support development of the wider systems required to implement the reforms, including Electoral Management Systems, the citizen-facing service and Electoral Registration Officer Portal functionality. The advance will allow this work to progress alongside the Bill's passage through Parliament, reducing implementation risk and supporting timely delivery. This will help ensure the necessary systems are in place to provide local government with an efficient and resilient mechanism for processing applications and maintaining electoral registers .

Parliamentary approval for additional capital of £2,800,000 for this new service will be sought in a Supplementary Estimate for Ministry of Housing, Communities and Local Government. Pending that approval, urgent expenditure estimated at £2,800,000 will be met by repayable cash advances from the Contingencies Fund.